When The Moon Starts To Fall

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When The Moon Starts To Fall

by TodayWeSlayTigers

Summary

In an alternate mirror reality resides a slightly different version of Izuku Midoriya and the rest of the cast of My Hero Academia. In a world that mirrors the canon universe albeit with a few changes.

The Butterfly Effect.
A tiny butterfly flapping its wings today may lead to a devastating hurricane weeks from now.

Fate is a strange and fragile thing, events left up to chance can cause a ripple in the very fabric of time and life as we know it. With each simplistic choice we make a consequence is paid.

Öde is an alternate word for fate. Something that Izuku Midoriya has found himself constantly at odds with. Rather it's accepting a shitty hand at life or carving out his own path and finding a whole new destiny for himself. A simple chance encounter, a mere choice, and before you even have a chance to breathe, an alternate reality is born anew, with only yourself left to blame. Izuku realizes this very fact much too late.

His story starts with something as simple as a bite and ends with a trail of bodies and a body count no longer worth counting.

~It all comes crashing down when the moon starts to fall~

Notes

~Hello!~

Welcome to my very first MHA fanfiction! I hope you guys enjoy this story as much as I do. I'm really excited and am always open to any comments with your ideas, thoughts, feedback, etc, I appreciate anyone that takes the time to check out my piece and I hope you stay for the ride. This story will be pretty long and will have multiple one-shots/extras that go along with it within the same canon I have created. Oh, and I have a Spotify playlist that I'll be making for each chapter as well.

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In an alternate world than the one we are most familiar with resides a slightly different version of Izuku Midoriya and the rest of the cast of My Hero Academia. In a world that mirrors the canon universe albeit with a few subtle changes.
This very world is known as one of the various parallel worlds that appears much like the 'original' with a few variations, such as the people, the technological advancements, completely new locations, and the different states of connections between characters. It could be considered as 'alternate realities' that were caused by a single chance encounter. One that could throw the entire world on its head in a turn of events, changing its set course with each step. One of these 'alternate' events in this parallel reality would be the way in which Izuku formed a bond with All Might, an alternative 'quirk' manifesting, and various other unpredictable events that lead our characters to where they were always meant to be.

This is a journey of a lonely boy, who despite being led astray by fate, prevails and carves his own future.

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Prelude 00: The World In Which We Live

Chapter Summary

Izuku has the worst day in history and meets a cruel fate. Forever to be damned, and never the same, or so he thinks.

Chapter Notes

For this chapter, I have a few warnings I'd like to add to avoid accidentally triggering someone without warning!
Several parts of this chapter will include dark themes involving deteriorated state of mind, implied suicidal thoughts, depression, overall sad boy Izuku and towards the end of the chapter grotesque and graphic violence with some body horror mixed in there.

Thank you so much to anyone that reads and enjoys my story! I have now begun rewriting chapters to make it easier for people to hopefully understand, but remember its supposed to be hella confusing and frustrating in parts as these scenes are told from Izuku's POV and he is very much not in the right state of mind for quite some time and is just as confused as the readers and the author, this is intentional. Have any ideas, thoughts, or anything else please let me know in the comments as I love seeing what everyone thinks! If you like the story don't forget to leave a little love as it helps keep us authors motivated and able to bring you more content!

Prelude 00: The World In Which We Live

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During the last year of his middle school experience, Izuku Midoriya was inflicted with a dangerous and unpredictable variable in his life. It came in the disguise of a solution to the most devastating part of his life, the part that made him socially preyed upon and ostracized by his peers. This new and frightening power came with a great cost. Too much for a young man to handle. He had unknowingly become cursed, by no feelings any normal human could ever understand and empathize with. Not even a second after having this new, supposedly ‘life-saving miracle’ Izuku was once again forced into a situation that left him colder and more alone than ever before.

As quickly as life goes on, this incident came and unrooted everything about Izuku and Inko Midoriya's lives. It came in waves, like a broken dam, endless and running rampant.

It had been an average day for the mother and her son, nothing overly exciting or interesting really. The day itself hadn't been overall pleasant, to begin with, but something neither of them could have predicted was, how different their lives would become in a matter of minutes. Sure there had been subtle hints of what would befall that small close-knit family, a few subtle warnings that should've made both of them more cautious, more aware of the world happening around them. That simple news report or those missing pet posters Izuku had caught sight of on his way to the school a few times.

But who would've thought that such minimal signs could lead to something so dangerous and cruel? The morning news had broadcasted about a local zoo having a breakout. It wasn't all that widespread or concerning for most people. The broadcast had told of a small group of wolves escaping from a nearby zoo, a pack of around 12. These wolves were small and had been entirely raised in captivity, so they were more acquainted with humans than other wild wolves. They were thought to be docile, familiar with humans in general, and much less likely to commit irreversible damage.

The citizens however were warned to be aware of their surroundings and avoid contact with any wolves they may come in contact with. But that was really the end of the whole thing, It had been a small segment of the show lasting no more than ten or so minutes. The broadcast hadn't even been all that widespread, ending with the newswoman promising that the pro heroes were already on the case and that the public should reframe from any panicking that may ensue.

Like many other citizens, Inko and Izuku took their words into account at the time. Though after all was said and done they put the information somewhere in the back of their heads, never to see the light of day again. No doubt later they'd forgotten about such an insignificant warning. Sure Inko was concerned for her son who walked to school most days. Though after much convincing from Izuku, she compromised and made him carry potent pepper spray and be more vigilant. He agreed and that was all there was to it. Problem solved. Or at least that is what they would've thought. As it turns out Izuku Midoriya is either the luckiest bastard alive or the most unlucky of all.

As one could predict, not all was well with the viridian-haired boy. Not only had he had one of the worst days of his life, but something much more sinister seemed to be awaiting him. His average day consisted of never-ending harassment that always came with school, closely followed by the cruel words screamed at him by the person he loved most in that shithole of a middle school. He often would mentally refer to the place as the 'gates of hell' though he was the only one that ever heard such thoughts, he never told a soul, not even his mother knew how torturous his days at Aldera Junior High were. This however wasn't the end of his rather shitty day, he had also somehow found himself face-to-face with one of these so-called 'lost wolves.' Only these wolves couldn't be the ones described in the news report, could they?

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(A Few Hours Before - Mid-January)

Izuku Midoriya had had a rather terrible day, one of the worst he could remember really. That was really saying something too because he had a lot of those days. They always seemed to pile up without his permission anyway, so he had long stopped fighting them off. Today however had left an especially guttural wound deep within his flesh, one that he knew would never truly heal. No physical damage today, thankfully, but this wound was a straight arrow to the heart in every other possible way besides physically. So much so that his entire body was still wrecked with grief and sorrow.

He was sitting on the rooftop of the Aldera Junior High, with a melancholic look across his features and legs fluttering about behind the steel railing. His head was full of worrisome thoughts that no teen his age should even have riding on his shoulders. Yet *here* he was, scorched notebook in hand and legs limply kicking at the gentle air that resisted the motion. Long tired sighs escaped every second or two, his shoulders limp and his tiny bit of confidence chipping away the longer he sat here. He felt *empty* and never had he felt so inexplicably alone in the world. So completely *insignificant* compared to the bright city over the railing, the one that stretched on for a near entirety.

"I really hate it here."

The green-haired teen sighed, clutching his burned notebook closer to his chest. He hated how much his hands shook, how much his entire body shook as he silently sobbed to himself on the open rooftop. This small journal that he held so delicately and with such despair, was crafted from a dying life. Within its papyrus pages held the love notes of every one of his analytic observations relating to heroes, vigilantes, and villains alike. Carrying his every passing thought on heroes and the quirks that fascinated him more than anything else in the universe. It had meant the world to him for *so long*. Now though, seeing it in such a sorry state thanks to his supposed best friend, turned worst enemy, just left him feeling numb and tattered. It had once brought a gleaming smile, one more blinding than the sun even on his worst day. Now it only left him *hollow* and wishing his life had turned out just a little bit different than his *reality*.

Time passed by in a flash and his last string of positive thoughts dissipated, becoming one with the soaring wind and carrying away the last of his happy thoughts with it. Not really wanting to get up, but knowing he couldn't stay longer due to his mother and how worried he knew she'd be if he showed up home late one more time. The thought grounded him and reminded him that someone

was *still* counting *on him* to come home, so he begrudgingly recollected himself and his meager possessions. At least the few that weren't ruined from the earlier water incident curtsey of one Katsuki Bakugou. He gave a pitiful sigh as he stood up, more than ready to move on from today.

Inko wasn't aware of how cruel her son's life had treated him, yet there were times she suspected as much. Any mother with half a brain and any ounce of love for their child would notice and could see just how 'tired' her son was becoming with each passing day. The clear signs of trouble whether in school, with friends, or mental state of mind. Inko was worried, yet held herself back from prying too deep into her son's affairs, as she thought that intrusive and she didn't wish to upset her son by interfering in some time he obviously didn't want to share with her. Izuku had always been surprisingly secretive when it came to friends and how school was during weekdays. At least in detail and if she tried to dig for a deeper answer he'd always answer vaguely with an air of caution in his tone or just entirely reflect any proper form of an answer. It unsettled her that he wouldn't confide in her, but she held onto the hope that he would eventually tell her if he was in trouble.

So instead, Inko did everything she could at home to make her boy smile just a little brighter, a little more sincerely. If he truly was having a hard time with friends and school, at least he'd be able to escape to a safe and loving space at home. She'd do anything for her son, rather that was in the form of brand new exclusive merch that she knew he would fawn over when his eyes caught sight of it or being sure to fix the boy's favorite dishes anytime she had the funds to do so. The Midoriya family held little wealth and even more minuscule power, even their quirks weren't overly flashy or useful to most. Though if they had one thing that rivaled other families it would be the amount of love they shared.

If nothing else, the Midoriya family was known for this one thing, and that was unconditional love. Everyone that was familiar with the mother and son duo, knew how much the two loved and cherished each other. It was obvious and heartwarming to most, while others were quite envious of how close they two appeared, behind closed doors or not. They had always been close, growing up in a single-parent household would do as much. They were all the other had, the only family that remained from both sides. They knew firsthand how devasting loss could be. Hence they deeply treasured their bonds more than most and everyone noticed and complimented Inko for raising such a thoughtful and caring boy all by herself.

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"You know, if you really want to be a hero, there actually might be another way. Just pray that you'll be born with a quirk in your next life."

"While you are at it, why don't you take a swan dive off the roof of this building. Maybe then your dreams will be nicer. Hey, it might even turn your whole sorry life around?"

From the moment the taunting words left the explosive blonde's lips, to when he used his flashy quirk to further pour salt into the other's wound. Izuku physically heard the sound of his already tattered heart shatter. *Katsuki was cruel.* Crueler than most, but only because of how much power Izuku gave Bakugou. He cared too much and too deeply, compared to the others his words always *burned* the worst. Burning the cherished notebook of his ex-childhood friend, one of the only cherished possessions the boy had, was one of the last actions to fully break Izuku beyond repair.

Izuku had already hit near rock bottom for the day. Though that was all minor compared to what would befall the teen later that night. Izuku was normally a crier. He cried about any and everything, for happiness, sadness, despair, excitement, fear, any emotion a human could possibly express, he'd cry. His mother was the same way, they were naturally expressive and emotional people. Inko had always reassured her son that that was a beautiful trait. A real 'diamond in the rough' type of trait and one society of today often lacked. It was a trait of strength and love, not a weakness, she'd constantly remind him, almost daily. Most days Izuku wasn't so sure he fully believed her words, but he had hope that her words held weight.

Right in that moment though, Izuku didn't cry, he didn't sob and he didn't even gasp, he simply stared with an unnaturally blank face. Everything about the look was foreboding and just *wrong*. Izuku was always the most expressive person, blindingly so, annoyingly so. But looking at that unnaturally dulled and lifeless look was startling, even for Katsuki.

Izuku felt *nothing*, something that was completely abnormal for a boy who usually wholeheartedly felt everything so deeply. Though all he felt was numbed, *numb* to everything that was happening around him. That empty husk feeling left him strictly on autopilot, leading him to a place he didn't even know. Somewhere unfamiliar and potentially dangerous.

How true that would turn out to be was yet to be seen. Izuku wandered under a bridge that almost appeared out of nowhere. He'd been so absent of mind that he hadn't even noticed the green slime rapidly crawling up his leg, nor the suddenly suffocating feeling of his body being overtaken. He felt numb to the world and everything within its accursed walls. Even as his vision grew black and his eyes tired, he felt no pain, no fear, and certainly no sense of danger or regret. He was simply **tired** of fighting, fighting for everything, fighting to be simply *be alive. Tired of being alive.*

Some time passed and he found himself thrown against the concrete as a loud voice seemed to ask him a question. He didn't register the words, nor the sight before him at first. His ears were ringing and his vision was dancing with black dots. When his mind seemed to reboot and come back online Izuku's doe-like eyes widened even further than they normally were. All Might, the unmistakable tall and strong figure of Japan's very own number-one hero stood proud before him. The *man* Izuku respected and admired the most, besides Kacchan of course.

Izuku's favorite hero was the last man on earth to hold that final sliver of hope, a chance to save the overpowering thoughts of darkness and sorrow that were encroaching on the drowning teen. The only one that could hold his head up and out for eh drowning depths of his own sadness. This man could make or break Izuku for the last time. The final straw that broke the little camel's back some would say.

Sadly the latter was the answer, and there once again stood a near permanently numbed teen. A boy with nothing left to lose and even less a reason to exist. All because of a few painful words, that for anyone else may have been so minor that they'd brush it off and move forward without a second thought. For Izuku these words were the last nail in the coffin. Nothing could hurt worse than being told by your beloved idol and favorite hero that you, as a *human*, a *quirkless* human could be *nothing*. That you could *only* ever be what *everyone* had been telling you for the entirety of your life.

"Even without a quirk, can I too be a hero?"

"I cannot simply say 'you can be a hero even without power."

"I see."

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(An hour later)

Even with another reason to hate today, the boy continued to wander after breaking away from the pro he had admired his entire life. He'd broken his heart, and hurt his last snippet of pride beyond foreseeable repair. But he was still breathing so that meant he'd have a chance to try again eventually. That is if the darkness didn't suffocate his already dimming light. By some sick twist of fate, Izuku found himself in a whole other problem, one that temporarily made him forget about that overpowering numbness settling within his soul.

The sight of spiked blonde hair hidden beneath a watery green sludge, drowning in the same way Izuku had just an hour prior, had his heart doing somersaults from distress. Fearw as all he could feel, all his eyes could see, the fading of light in the blonde's eyes was the catalyst. His heart clenched, his fingernails impaling his palms as he noticed the lack of pro heroes assisting his oldest and only friend. There were at least four or five on standby, yet not a single one was making any attempt to rescue the obviously drowning boy. Izuku felt his stomach lurch, all the contents from his awful lunch begging to come back up at the sickening sight.

His pulse raced, running at top speeds as if it was about to burst forward from his chest and run a race on its own. Seeing the look of *fear* and *defeat* in the blonde's simmering carmine eyes, gave Izuku an inhuman burst of strength *to do something*. When the people we love are put in dangerous situations, inhuman bursts of adrenaline surge forward and guide us to do the unthinkable. At this moment, despite being weak and quirkless, Izuku felt like a fucking god straight out of storybooks. And all it took was seeing those two emotions laid so incredibly bare on the teen's honorary **symbol of victory's** face. That *vulnerability* caused the green-haired boy's blood to freeze over, but only for a second before he was throwing himself headlong into an uphill battle, he knew he'd never win. He'd never seen those looks before today on Katsuki's paling face. Anything that could distract the disgusting beast from stealing away his most precious light.

His mind was rushing a mile a minute and before he could properly decide on a plan, his body was reacting to the strangled choking sound that escaped the blonde, *his blonde*. *His Kacchan*. Izuku felt feral and lunged into action, tearing his backpack filled with heavy books, an apple, and fifty or so pens, using every last bit of strength he could muster into throwing the damned bag at the sludge creature.

The villainous slime growled, Izuku having successfully caught its attention, giving the green-haired boy a moment to strike a second attack. Snatching up one of his fallen pens that had been scattered across the ground the teen drove the pointed object straight into the slime's visible eyes. Repeatedly he stabbed at the beast's ocular unit with as much force as his unimpressive arms would let him. In the few seconds, he'd accessed the slime he took note of his only obvious weakness, the *eyes*. Of course, he exploited that weakness to his own advantage. He'd never been so thankful to be so analytically gifted more than in that minute.

The slime recoiled and leashed its suffocating death grip on the blonde. Izuku continued his assault, despite all the screaming protests of the bystander heroes. He gave them no time of day though, and *why should he when they were watching an innocent child be killed right before their eyes?* His arms were growing as heavy as lead, but he didn't give up. *He couldn't. He refused to. Not when something so precious was on the line.*

Dropping the pen from his slimy palms, he started pulling at the slimy bits, tearing the substance blanketing Kacchan's face and mouth. He couldn't manage to remove much, as it was continuously regenerating, but by some miracle, he had cleared just enough to allow air to enter the blonde's compromised lungs.

He gasped and Izuku growled ripping and tearing with all his might as if his life depended on him. Not just his own but the explosive childhood friend under him as well. It was life or death and only he seemed to realize such an obvious thing. *What had those heroes been thinking?* He wanted to scream out loud but held his tongue, nerves eating up the words before they could escape. His focus

was strictly on securing Kacchan's survival, nothing else possibly mattered to him after all. Without his 'victory' he'd never be a hero anyway.

As if being shocked out of their stupor and realizing their negligence the pros started to assist the boys as much as they could. With All Might suddenly reappearing and smashing the villain right in the face. The villain fell in a melted heap under the crackling punch, causing the blonde to drop and fall against the green-haired boy in front of him as the slime spattered the buildings and people behind them. Izuku's legs buckled, but he did his best to hold his friend up, though he didn't have to wait long for someone else to take the blonde's weight off his short stature. A deep sigh of relief and Izuku was collapsing on the ground as the adrenaline high wore off and the nerves won out. He felt his body collapse in on himself with sheer exhaustion, as the fear of what could've happened today seemed to come back to him. They both *almost* died today (twice for Izuku, but he didn't care about that, all he worried about was Katsuki) and the heroes had done ***what***? *Watch them suffocate?*

He hadn't expected a proper thank you for saving his life, not really. He knew Kacchan since they were babies and knew better than most that the blonde was not one to apologize or give proper thanks, for anything. Not even life. And certainly not for the useless 'Deku' that had followed him around from diapers to their teen years. That being said what he hadn't expected was to be on the receiving end of another train of vocal slaughter.

This time he did tear up, he didn't sob or make any other sound, but obvious tears filled his viridian pools as he watched the undeniable *hate*, the deep *loathing*, and sheer *anger* flash through the crimson eyes before him. If his heart hadn't already been shattered enough today it was in crumbles now. Maybe even nonexistent. The damage had been dealt and Izuku was positive he'd never be able to recover from the day that had so horribly abused him today. No good deed went unpunished. That was a saying he'd heard a few times, though he'd always argued against it before today. No longer could he find it in himself to defend such a bitter, yet undeniable reality. He'd learned his lesson this time, maybe for the first time he truly believed all the horrible things he'd heard. It **hurt**, *it **really** hurt*.

Today really just had been too much for one soft-hearted teen to handle. It ***wasn't fair*** that he had been treated so cruelly by the whole universe today. The hits just kept coming, one after the other in a brutal and taxing onslaught that left him utterly shattered. A broken and abused husk of a boy that was just incredibly lonely and wished for nothing more than to be loved. *Was that truly impossible for someone like him?*

His mind felt akin to a *broken mirror, cold* and *lifeless, incomplete*. Even if attempted to *repair*, it would never be the same, inside or out. He was forever changed from the ruins of the day, he was no longer the same boy he had been just hours prior.

"I didn't need your help you worthless Deku! How***"** The angry shouts started to fall on

deafened ears after that, Izuku couldn't understand the words that came after that. His head was too empty and his ears too full. His heart...well he wasn't even sure if he had one left. At some point he noticed that he couldn't even hear his own heartbeat anymore, it was as if the entire world fell *silent.*

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(Several Hours After Meeting All Might)

Aimlessly he followed the next path his feet found with little thought, little regard for his own well-being or safety. He was so far away from it all, that the city lights and tall infrastructures disappeared from sight. Instead, the entire surroundings consisted of a blackened sea filled with nothingness. Not even the city lights dared to encroach in this forgotten area, civilization was nearly non-existent out here. Poetically it reminded Izuku of his inner turmoil and feelings, of emptiness in a vast and frigid world. Izuku hadn't had the mind to take note of the changes, he was too deep in his own head to notice the places his feet were leading him. The dull roar of the city life evaporated with every step he took to a path that had no true destination. The soft rumble emitted through vibrations from large 2-ton vehicles went as equally unnoticed as everything else. Head underwater and eyes filled with blindness to the world outside of his own mind. He was lost in a world of his own making, maybe never to be seen again.

It seemed safer to be there than in this real and pain-filled world that suffocated and choked him with its despair and loneliness. Izuku was enjoying his stay so much that he feared he might never return. It's not like the world would miss him anyway, his mother would sure. *But the entire world? **No***, he wasn't *worth* more than that to anyone but her. Oddly, he was okay with that parting thought. He was so far below the waters, that he neglected to notice the raging waves rippling on the surface. The coldness of the sea welcomed him and he was lulled into a constant embrace of the turning tide undercurrent. He felt at peace with whatever awaited him on the other side when he awoke if he were so unlucky.

Towering trees made entirely from shadowed bone and ominous echos of a forest that was never meant for human footsteps to infect, circled the boy on all sides as unforgiving eyes watched from the distance, scheming and chattering in whispers of excitement and disgust. At least he'd thought as much, but maybe his mind was truly playing tricks on him. The shadows hovered above him, swaying gently in the wind as if breathing right there with him. The forest was silent, not even the chorus of obnoxious crickets could be heard, each step thundering louder than the last. Any animals that roamed such a forest of horrors thought it wise to hold their tongues, releasing not even a peep in fear it is their last.

The chilling wind whipped through the ghostly trees, moaning and groaning with each hit that landed against the forest floor and everything attached to it. A few stray ropes of wind slapped at

Izuku's readily cold cheeks, leaving freezing kisses against his already paled skin. His normally vivid and alert eyes filled with wonder and curiosity were dulled and fogged over with glacial numbness. A numbness that solely existed inside of someone who had given up all forms of hope. All of the usual light refused to enter the pupils, causing a haunted look to flitter through them. It was as if the boy's very essence had been *torn away* from him, his soul retracted from his flesh-covered husk, with nothing but a blackened void left to rot within. He looked as haunting as the forest he disgraced.

The forest and its silence were a clear-cut sign of the dangerous predators running rampant that had been hidden behind the green and golden foliage. Obvious telltale signs of a most dangerous beast lurking inside, lying in wait for foolish prey to wander into its woodland prison. Unluckily for Izuku, luckily for the vicious creature, a young teenage boy of tender age had found himself lost in the undergrowth and no one was looking for him. Not a soul had noticed, it was still too early for that.

With little worry of creating a disturbance, the green-haired boy stomped onward with feet of lead, crushing a variety of brittle branches in his wake. If it had been any normal predator maybe the boy could have fled unscathed. On a standard day with that mossy green hair and viridian emerald eyes of his, he'd have blended quite well with the forestry. However, today's *predator* was not an average run-of-the-mill small fry creature. No, this *creature* was bred and created with only *destruction* in mind. It was a beast of fairy tales, with a nasty appetite and an even nastier bloodlust targeted toward its human counterparts. Humans just so happened to be one of its particularly favorite flavors. Not a rare trait among its species.

The further the boy wandered into the forest the closer the predator stalked its quarry through the restless shadows. Precariously lapping at its lips in anticipation the closer it became, scorching hot acid-filled drool fell upon the forest floor, leaving small singe marks as each droplet made direct contact. Its calcite torches flickered like a becoming beacon from within the shadows, the eyes as dangerous as they were enchanting and lustrous. That abnormal glow emitted from the ocular sockets like a wayward torch in the pitch-black darkness. The illuminating calcite orbs flickered with excitement and anticipation with each carefully calculated step in complete silence. She was far too hungry to let this masterpiece of a meal slip away. It had been a long while since she'd last eaten human as well and it'd be a lie to say she was frothing at the mouth at the promise of such a delicious flavor once again.

A low rumbling growl of thrill and excitement left the creature's impressively large maw, its enormous canines sticking out from its lilac-colored gumlines in an eerily similar stance to the long-extinct saber-toothed cat. Its wide and powerful hunches lurched forward, lowering to the ground on occasion when the creature thought the prey had noticed its presence. The human *never* did, but the beast wasn't about to risk ousting itself before it was good and ready to show its fearsome face. The game was as important as the weak human's inevitable demise. The desire that builds within an apex predator's stomach scorches its insides so sensually, steadily building a different kind of *tension* they otherwise lacked in stimulation. Until at the end of the hunt said compression of heat bursts forward and releases a feeling more euphoric than any other.

Soon patience wore thin and the creature's belly rumbled more vocally, demanding to be filled. A dream that could never be accomplished, as its feeding frenzy was relentless and neverending. With the last of the taunt string coming unraveled the beast struck, *much* faster than any human could ever react. Enormous and overpowering canines and deadly incisors found their way clamped around the boy's left thigh, gripping the flesh with its mighty maw in a deathlock. Izuku's body reacted much quicker than his brain, screaming out in pain as the flesh wept and cried out for immediate help.

The longer the beast's maw remained in contact with fragile fresh the more excruciating the pain and the darker the blood. The silky skin began to melt and tear, with each unbearable second. The acid in its jaws burned and sizzled, eating away at Izuku's soft and delicate flesh. The creature's grip was confident and strong. So much so that the creature began to ruthlessly shake its head in a tearing motion. From the sheer force of the grip, all was over before it even began. Before he even had a minute to process the enlarged teeth sinking deeper into his flesh it was far too late. With a single snap of its neck upward and the ungodly cries of a frightened child, the leg was torn loose. Removing the entirety of the leg in one fell swoop, was efficient in every possible way, the beast got an early treat and the prey was left completely incapacitated. A horribly morbid and much too calculated attack for any mere mindless beast to be capable of.

Although it wasn't entirely successful, due to Izuku's intense and frantic punching of the beast's overly sensitive and elongated canine-like snout. From the knee down was lost in the fight for freedom. Bloodied ribbons of muscles and brittle strips of skin were ripped from the fleshy puzzle but at the cost of the beast's much-needed incisor. Overall the loss for the wolf was minor, but it still cried out from the sensation along with the now steadily bleeding nose. It was without a proper sense of smell outside of its own blackened blood, but the nose was no longer necessary, the prey was left incapacitated and without any means of escape. All was not lost for the beast and the fang would grow back before long, its prey's leg, however, would not. Izuku's own screams of terror and pain followed at the traumatizing sight of the bloody mess of freefalling tendrons and ruptured muscles, that was all that remained of his missing limb. Blood poured in a fatal waterfall, painting the gravel and grass alike in a crimson bloom. Dark crimson was not the only color that added to the unnatural landfill of bodily fluids, the monster's black and rotting blood swirled throughout the red as it wept out of a broken and bleeding nose.

It took everything in the boy to not instantly faint from the sight. Though blood loss would catch up to him soon enough. No way was he making it out of here, not after he'd already lost so much with a single attack no less. Had he really been so distracted in his own thoughts that he missed all the warning signs and could've easily prevented this? Even in the face of death, he was a fool. *Was that all he was ever meant to be?*

His chances of survival were unlikely, almost as much as his ability to have prevented this outcome. Fate had always had a morbid interest in leading him to a life of misery and torment after all, who's to say this wasn't another one of its sick tricks? The thoughts of guilt and terror harassed him, holding him in place and preventing him from all immediate action. He could think all he wanted about his, but one variable would never change, *Izuku Midoirya was meant to die in this forest.*

An ear-piercing snarl echoed throughout the forest, followed by a pained cry of a wounded animal. With its maw full of flesh, the beast greedily swallowed the clumps of his tender flesh and taunt muscles, in a singular motion. The sight was impressive had the situation been different. With a flicker of its violet and black-colored tongue lapping at blood-coated lips, it was once again snarling and stepping toward its prey, eager for a second bite. The enormous dire wolf furiously snapped its jaws, not waiting for another second to lunge forward. This time the teeth found themselves deeply embedded into the boy's tender stomach flesh. He cried out again as the powerful jaws clamped themselves around the delicate epidermis, biting through muscles and straight to the bone as if they had all been made from *flimsy paper*. Izuku coughed up blood as the beast pulled back, taking another generous amount of flesh and muscles with it.

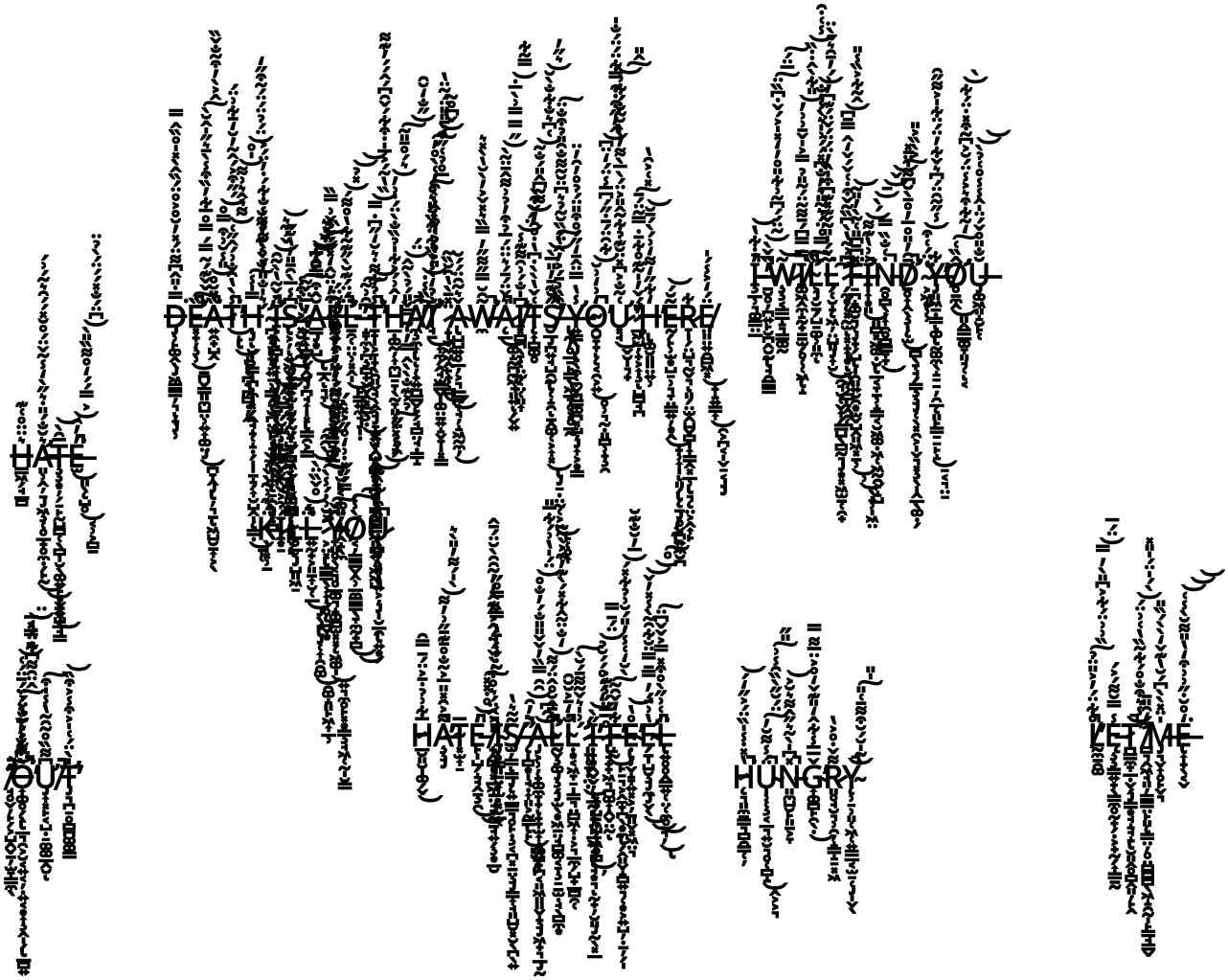
The wolf hurled the boy off to the side this time, carefully watching as the *little lamb* came crumbling to his knees. The boy did everything he could to hold in the contents of his stomach innards, but the hole was too large for him to hold and his hands had never been overly large. Even with both hands. It was only a matter of time before the entirety of his intestines and other major organs fell, along with his shaking and unsteady hands. The intense taste of a metallic substance and salt assaulted his mouth, blood pooling inside and dripping down his chin in a river of crimson. He gasped and tried to hold pressure, but the wounds were too deep and he was much too weak to hold on. He couldn't even attempt to fight back. He was at his limit, falling across the threshold between the conscious and the unconscious world. He wanted nothing more than to fall into a deep sleep, but he knew if he did he'd never wake up again. That would be it, he'd die from blood loss and a ripped-open stomach just like that.

He had literally become one of those idiots in horror movies, the ones that were stupid enough to wander alone without a clear head and made ridiculous life decisions. They always died in the first half of the movies and it seemed that Izuku too would be one of those fools he'd always criticized. How embarrassing, but so '*fitting for a Deku like him,'* he thought bitterly, coughing up blackened blood as he did. A mocking and melancholic smile on his face, the blood coated his teeth, in a crimson smile. In another world maybe the smile was meant to be a nod towards All Might, his hero and the man he had hoped would be his mentor, at least his supporter one day. *What a foolish and oh-so-naive dream you had Izuku.*

His heart ached, for his horrible day, for his soon-to-be loss of life, for All Might crushing his dreams, with a smile no less. For Kacchan...the boy he had loved for far too long and for what reason other than maybe he was a closeted masochist. He wanted to weep for his mother and the tears she's undoubtedly shed when she found her son in such a pitiful state if they ever even ground his body in these shitty woods. Most of all he felt anger, anger for everyone, everyone who had failed him time after time, and for this beast. This fucking beast, the one that looks so goddamned happy eating his organs like he was made of the best type of candy. He felt a startling and empowering anger, years of suppressing such hatred and anger would do that to you after all. He had nothing to lose anyway, no face to lose, and who cares if his thoughts were a little dark? He was a deadman anyway. Might as well go out will all the anger and bitterness he'd held inside for all these years. If he released such toxic feelings bottled deep within him, maybe such thoughts would have the ability to poison that beast. Hatred was a powerful weapon.

He'd been told at least, he knew it better than most though, he was exposed to daily and constantly reminded of such feelings of hate simply because he was born the way he was. The boy he loved once upon a time had been the most generous with it after all. Well if Kacchan taught him anything it was how to be explosive and impulsive. Right now with nothing to lose why didn't he just take a page out of his favorite tormentor's book?

'I...I'll... ki-ll yo...u." He spat with as much venom as he could, which was surprisingly a lot. Bloody droplets flew with the malicious threat, and the wolf just sneered, giving the boy a devilishly mocking smile. One so eerily similar to the ones Katsuki always gave him, a look that was filled with mockery and ***hate***. It pissed him off more than dying. How dare that wolf, that devil look anything like his Kacchan. It *disgusted* him, causing a flurry of hate and anger to surge through his veins.



An overbearing fire ignited within his soul, a new bitterness towards the world, and a flicker of hate iced all the blood in his veins. He'd never felt so alive, ironic since he was dying in a pool of his own blackening black. With a raspy voice, he swore he'd ***kill this*** **bitch** if he ever got the chance. Funny how in your dying moments you suddenly gain the will to finally stick up for yourself. Izuku had never been a *hateful* boy, he'd always been a lover, not a true fighter, violence wasn't his ideal. But as he looked at this wolf, this enormous wolf with that fucking *cocky* grin he felt burning *hatred* for this beast. He wanted its **blood** to be spilled and he promised he would get *revenge* for playing him like this.

Seeing the *lamb* fall, a look of utter defeat, laced with unbridled hate and anger invaded the prey's viridian irises, leaving the creature thrilled and excitable. That ***look*** on their quarry's face when it realized that this had all been a game, was its favorite moment. Some were angry and filled with hate, others filled with looks of utter despair and loss of hope, each look thrilled the beast. Humans were the most fun to watch die though, they always had the best reactions. It loved seeing that look of complete defeat in its prey, it was more exciting than the *actual* part of the hunt. *Chao*s was truly such a *fun* game.

Circling the crumpled human the dire wolf leaped again, grabbing onto the teen's shoulder from the backside. Unlike before instead of taking a singular piece and jumping back the creature clung to the victim's back. It took a second for its hind claws to sink deeply into the flesh. As it felt its claws finish sinking, it used the front claws to slice the meat into more sizable pieces. Chunks of flesh and muscle fragments were flung to the nearby ground, some landed with decently wet thumps while others landed after a few meaty bounces. The bloody rainbow was *beautiful*.

Izuku cried out, calling for help that would never be able to hear him. Satisfied with its artistry and the prey's delectable taste, the feral beast decided to end it once and for all game it was time to feast. It wrapped its enormous maw around the entirety of the green-haired boy's neck. The beast counted to three before a deafening snap and a few smaller cracks echoed throughout the forest. The body fell limply to the ground, a deep crimson pool painting the ground around it. The crimson mixed with the black almost resembled spider lilies, the irony of such wasn't lost on the boy. *Truly his life was such a joke.*

His heart cried as it held on will all its might, begging some invisible god to save him, but that day there was no help within sight. No one even knew that Izuku Midoriya was missing. Not a soul even knew where he was. He didn’t even know where he was, or why he had thought it a good idea to wander into a forest alone in the dead of the night. Maybe everything was always his own fault and this was the final lesson given to him. It's a shame he only learned it the day he was meant to die.

Just as it had always been, even in his dying moments, not a soul stood beside the lonely boy. The entire world became silent, anxiously listening for the last breath to come. Not ever being one wanting to disappoint, even on his deathbed, Izuku took his last unsteady breath. Once it was over

the forest seemed to return to normal, losing interest in the life that had been lost today. In nature everyone knew of this unfortunate rule of the woods, *life wasn't to be grieved*, if *another* died that meant a *separate* life had been fed to live a new day. *The cost of being alive was heavy. To live another must die. To thrive is to divide.*

What the forest and the now disinterested direwolf failed to notice was the unnatural seafoam glow in the boy's otherwise lifeless eyes. A beast was about to awaken. A beast much larger than any other creature in this forest. It was only a matter of time before the light returned to his eyes.



Prelude 01: There's A Wolf In These Woods

Chapter Summary

Izuku Midoriya has been missing for two weeks, he has been unseen and unheard of ever since the slime incident. Elsewhere a strange phenomenon is happening in the woods.

Chapter Notes

~Hiya! And welcome to the rewrite of these older chapters!~

Hope you guys are enjoying the prelude so far, still plenty of parts to go until we arrive at the main meaty part of the story, but until then I hope you find Izuku and Inko's past interesting. I just created a Spotify playlist to follow each chapter and the ones I took inspiration with. More songs will be added the further along we get! Have any epic song recommendations, please let me know maybe I'll add them!

~Warnings for this chapter include~
Dark themes, death, dead animals, gore, body horror, blood and violence, and Izuku's small descent into madness and death.

Spotify Link -> https://open.spotify.com/playlist/1HQJ4C2IfX5Ld5B8j5qJzO

The song that I feel best suits this chapter would be 'Mr. FEAR' by SIAMÉS along with 'Not Dead yet' by Ledger! I highly recommend watching the zombie Warrior Cats AU MAP. It's breathtaking and definitely inspired me!

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Prelude 01: There's A Wolf In These Woods

Part 2 of 'The World In Which We Live'

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(Ten Years Prior To Chapter One - Izuku Age 4)

Inko Midoriya never considered herself a great mother, that's not to say she didn't try her best or give all her love to her son. No, quite the opposite really. Her son Izuku was her entire world, he was all she had in this world, the very thing that she lived for. Despite this, she had her shortcomings, such as her inability to completely chase away all the pains her son had faced.

Being born quirkless hadn't been easy on either of them. Her husband that was sworn to love her and their son for life, left them simply because Izuku had disappointed him. Inko became on the receiving end of all his disappointment, as in his eyes his wife failed to present a viable heir to him. Hence she was equally as much of a failure. It was around this time that Hisashi had given Inko an **ultimatum**, leave their son to the 'wolves' of social services or come with him and try for a better offspring.

At that moment, any sense of love and feelings of affection the short woman had for her soon-to-be ex-husband vanished in an instant. With the mere implication of such a horrific thing, Inko had to control herself and not actively commit murder, though that was nearly asking for the impossible. Without a second thought, Inko chose her son. He may not have been what either had originally expected but that mattered little to Inko. She'd sworn to love him no matter what the second she learned she was finally pregnant after so many tries that led to nothing but despair.

The moment Izuku opened his matching viridian eyes, meeting hers she knew no matter what they faced the two of them would always be okay. She was going to love her son with all her heart and more. Nothing could change that fact, not even if Inko would have to make many morally grey decisions on her son's behalf. She'd do it all in a heartbeat.

Before he even took his first breath he had become the love of Inko's life, her purpose, and her proof of existence. This was her **sign**. This was *someone* who needed her more than anyone else in this horribly cold world and she'd be damned if anyone took her light without utter hell to pay. She would no doubt commit any crime, no matter how steep the cost may be if it meant her son would be safe and allowed to live another day.

Another day with that blinding smile of his, the one capable of obtaining all the love in the world. With the mere thought of losing such a blindingly sweet boy, the world would face a monumental

loss. No matter what happened Inko knew that Izuku would do great things and she'd support him no matter what he chose for his future. Though she secretly hoped he never chose to throw himself into a dangerous profession, she had a nagging feeling that was never going to happen. Izuku was never meant to live a simple and peaceful life, after all, she knew as much since he was a few months old. He was destined for too many amazing things.

Inko's finances took a great hit from her divorce. That bastard took everything he could from her, from their son, all for what? Spite? To no end did Inko's hate and disgust bubble for her once beloved significant other. Leaving them near penniless, Inko was forced to swallow any spec of pride in order to persevere her son's happiness and prevent the two of them from becoming homeless. This led to many life debts that Inko feared she'd never be able to pay. Not even in twenty lifetimes, but even with such an impending risk, she took everything she could to keep them afloat if only for a little longer.

For so long everything seemed so impossible, fear of constant eviction, starvation, lack of baby supplies, and moments of weakness filled Inko's days. It wasn't until she coincidentally reconnected with her long-time childhood best friend that Inko finally found a light at the end of the tunnel, in the form of one young and beautiful Mitsuki Bakugou. Overwhelmed with relief and years of overflooding loneliness and fears, Inko fell into Mitsuki's arms and cried for what felt like days.

After several months of being in Mitsuki's care and support, Inko felt confident in herself once again and did everything to pull her life back from the shambles Hisashi had left her increasingly small family in. The Bakugou couple did everything they could for the young mom, they loved Inko and Izuku, as seemed their son Katsuki.

He and Izuku hit it off pretty well, they became practically glued at the hip, and they shared everything. Well except for Katsuki's toys, those were a big no-go for Izuku sadly. But the doe-eyed boy didn't mind, he had toys of his own. Though, unlike Katsuki, he loved sharing more than having his own toys. It was simply in his nature to do so, even as a toddler.

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Thanks to their undying support, Inko managed to rise from the ashes of her old life and start anew, just like the legendary phoenix. The single mother found solace in her newly achieved job, she worked in an accounting office most days, but during the weekends she worked closely with children that suffered from mental or behavioral disorders. One job filled the wallet and one filled the soul.

She couldn't do much but knowing she could make a few kids feel a little less angry and alone in the world made her heart happy and the best part was she got to spend time with Izuku while at

work without punishment.

Because of her determination to give her son the best life she could, Inko's goal was met much quicker than she could have ever imagined and within a few months, she was able to confidently buy her own home. A little slice of heaven and safety, just for her and her beloved Izuku.

By some divine intervention she thought, Inko's new apartment was on the same block as the Bakugou's, this made keeping in contact and morning brunches easier. With such a strong support system just down the road and a place of comfort for both Midoriya's, life felt a little bit brighter.

Seeing how bright and happy her child was and knowing she was truly capable of giving her son a happy and pleasant childhood meant everything to Inko. The icing on the cake was her son having such a dependable and awesome aunt and uncle for her little boy and a best friend for him to grow alongside for the entirety of their lives. That was at least the dream both she and Mitsuki had been imagining, they were even taking bets on the nature of their son's relationship. Oftentimes politely arguing over exactly what their children's lives would bloom into, it was very domestic and heartfelt and both women loved being able to gossip over brunch every other morning.

Sometimes even Masaru would join the ladies in their mischievous endeavors, he also played middleman any time the two women got too carried away. While Izuku no longer had a father, he wasn't left without a stable and loving father figure. Masaru loved Izuku even more than Mitsuki, both women teased the man about it, mostly because Izuku and he were such gentle souls. Unlike the other two fireballs of the Bakugou household. Izuku brought a certain air of tranquility and empathy, the opposite of Masaru's wife and son. Their wavelengths simply meshed well together, they always had fun and went on adventures when they could, Katsuki tagged along of course. Some of their favorite bonding activities were the simpler things, they curled up together in warm blankets with their doctored hot cocoa and cried over romantic dramas without judgment. A guilty pleasure of both. At least Izuku enjoyed them as much as he did, unlike his teasing wife and his emotionally constipated son. Life had been good, so good...

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(The First Days After Izuku's Disappearance Mid-January - Izuku Age 14)

When the rain fell, it came in waves, viciously tearing down walls and drowning all within its radius. Everything had happened so suddenly, so unexpectedly that neither woman could even begin to comprehend what had caused their worlds to come crashing down.

With Izuku's sudden disappearance, and possible kidnapping, which Mitsuki worried the most about, as everyone knew Izuku had always been a pretty child. He was easily on the radar of creeps constantly, always drawing in the worst kind of attention that the families would have to fight off tooth and nail. Life became increasingly dark, shadowed by the weight of the unknown. Neither

family was coping well with the teen's disappearance, though neither dared to lose hope. It had only been a few days after all. Surely he was still kicking around out there somewhere.

Inko knew she wasn't the world's greatest mother around, but goddammit she did her best. She worried every day if her son was still out there if he was even alive...**which she just knew he was**. No way would such a strong and beautiful boy die so easily. Never in a million years did Inko fear the worst, she couldn't allow herself to be plagued with such negative thoughts, because what if those horrid thoughts somehow escaped and made her worst nightmares come true? She was not willing to risk such. She held her ground and held that unbreakable faith for her son close to her heart. **Her boy would come back home to her**. Whether it would be in a box or completely unscathed could not yet be decided.

He had to, there was absolutely no other option. And the second he did Inko was going to apologize to her boy for her silence *that day*, because dammit she needed to instill her boy with all the confidence in the world. She had seen the wonders doing such had for Mitsuki's boy, she'd take a page out of her book for inspiration. In her own kind of Midoriya way of course. She wasn't a personal fan of the tough love method, but that just seemed to work best for her best friend's family so she never voiced out against it.

But before that, she was gonna hug the everloving life outta that boy and suffocate him with all the kisses in the world. Even if he protested, she was not planning on letting up. She knew after she got first dibs the Bakugou's would likely do the same in an all but more unconventional way. They had a very strange way of showing affection after all.

Of course, she wouldn't have it any other way, none of them would. Without words, they all knew Izuku meant the world to each of the people's lives he'd slipped into. He just had a way of bringing out all the love in the world. He was a blinding ray of sunshine, a real smile in a bottle, a colorful being in a world of sheltered darkness. Without him, the world seemed so much dimmer.

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(Two Weeks Since The Events Of the Last Chapter - Late January)

Two weeks passed agonizingly slow with no signs of Izuku Midoriya. With zero leads and even fewer clues of his status, hope was starting to feel pretty lost. The only thing that kept them somewhat sane was the fact in knowing that no signs, good or bad meant that they hadn't found any proof of remains. Meaning he could and was likely still alive wherever he was hidden away. It wasn't much but it was all they could cling onto, and they were desperate for something.

No proof of him meeting an unfortunate demise appeared, not even a blood smear. Inko Midoriya, Izuku's last remaining parent and guardian, was feeling the weight of her son's disappearance more with every day that passed. She could no longer sleep, eating was difficult, and looking religiously at photos of her lost child was doing little to help her grief and anguish of having lost her only child.

She wasn't entirely alone, with the number of visits or the calls she received from officers with updates or for more questioning, she rarely had a moment to breathe. Mitsuki Bakugou, the woman's resident best friend and surrogate sister along with her soft-hearted husband, made sure to provide the tormented mother with everything she could need. Rather in the form of company, support, or the necessities of life. There was also a new face among them in the form of a man named 'Mr. Yagi,' a man that seemed extremely passionate about finding Izuku and helping Inko achieve such. If times had been different Inko knows she would've easily fallen madly in love with the blonde-haired man. It seemed Izuku's tastes also came from his mother, blondes were Midoriya's true weakness she supposed. She wondered if hair as cold and white as snow counted as a variant of blonde. Not that that mattered anymore, she absolutely wouldn't be marrying another man with such frosty hair.

The Bakugou couple never left the woman to her own grievances, even the pair's little shithead of a son made several appearances to check in on his aunt. Under the pretense of course, that he was simply 'fuckin' bored' but they all secretly knew he was full of it and was just as worried as the adults about the little green-haired woman. Over the time that Izuku was missing Inko and Katsuki grew closer, call it trauma bonding. Though they'd always gotten along quite well things felt a bit different now, they leaned on each other for constant solace, quieting the taunting voices that haunted both of them. With every day that passed without any clues about their missing person the world outside grew a little colder and the clouds became a little darker. Katsuki didn't even deny their relationship now, Inko was now officially 'Auntie' or 'Aunt Inko' instead of simply 'Deku's mom.' It was a big step forward. In times of grief, bonds are tested and broken, but they are also mended in unexpected ways. Grief is a funny thing really, it can tear us apart or bring us together. It all depends on perspective.

Despite their unwillingness to move forward, time went on and before long the case had grown completely cold. The officers on the case were soon forced to shelve the case, as it had been long past the first week. This meant that instead of searching for the boy alive, they'd have to chalk Izuku's disappearance efforts to search for remains. A corpse was after all more likely now than a living breathing boy. They simply couldn't spend all their energies on finding one missing teen who could've simply run away despite what their witnesses claimed. They just had too many other villains and missing persons to find. Though despite that Mr. Yagi along with his lifelong friend and partner, Detective Naomasa Tsukauchi remained on the case, doing everything they could to locate one *alive* Izuku Midoriya, a boy who surely just wanted to return home. Both men, like the two distressed families, refused to use the *'D' word*, they weren't about to give up hope. How could the honor Symbol of Hope give up and forget the most important part of his job, saving those in need? Never giving up was part of the job and he surely wasn't about to start now, he'd faced much more harrowing and slim odds in the past. Finding one missing green-haired teen couldn't be so hard...right?

Although unbeknownst to them, they weren't exactly looking for a green-haired boy anymore...

Elsewhere a lone direwolf was wandering aimlessly, transversing from forest to forest with no true goal in mind.

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(An unknown amount of time has passed since Izuku Midoriya died)

Time is a human construct and has no importance to a beast that relies solely on its utmost instincts. From their perspective, obviously, the world is timeless and they are immortalized by such.

A half-eaten corpse lay motionless, with green hair and eyes were hidden behind the foliage of the same color. Few identifiable traits remained, limbs torn and shredded, body abused behind repair and limp as it seemed to be returning to the earth once and for all. This was simply on the surface though, as a faint motion stirred in the chest cavity. The slight impression of the chest, as if the corpse was still breathing, if only faintly.

Eyes forced shut and teeth gritted together, frozen in a motion of apparent pain painted across the freckled features. A few twitches on the left hand, a sudden sound of bones creaking and moaning as they knitted themselves back together, new skin gliding across the parts that lay broken and tattered, repairing themselves like a silken blanket. Limbs throbbed and twitched as new bones crept out from the open wounds. The feeling of muscles skittering across newly reconnected bones, as nerves mended and forged back together. As the days passed by and the body resumed proper shape, flowers and foilage grew around the fallen corpse, brushing against its sides with gentle caresses, as if sending him silent encouragement. It was an ominous and morbidly beautiful scene, even the shining sun high in the blue sky seemed to agree as it shone down on the maimed body. The entire process appeared straight out of a fairy tale, no doubt the scene would have made a beautiful painting to any artist. The forest suddenly seemed all the more alive, making quiet peas for the boy to wake up once again and open his beautiful viridian eyes. Though when he opened

them they were no longer viridian, but a glowing seafoam with a dangerous glint circling in their depths.

Hours, maybe days, of repair later and the boy's body was all but repaired, whole once again as it had always been. He still lay motionless against the slowly heating ground, his toes and fingers twitching at random intervals as his nervous system seemed to come back to life, along with the rest of him. His body was preparing to get back into business as usual.

His breathing had steadied, his throat which had previously been torn ached but was whole. No longer could he feel the freezing breezes of the winds whipping at his sensitive insides. His body temperature was rising, almost too hot. Some would say explosive. The rays of the sun and his new high body temperature brought a frown on his otherwise blank face. He felt extremely uncomfortable and itchy.

His skin itself seemed to be the cause of such horrid feelings, he felt as if a million ants were dancing across the top of his skin. Though with a few hesitant looks he could clearly see no sign of lowly creatures poking and prodding at him. He was completely alone, he wasn't sure how he knew that, but something settling deep within his bones promised he had no nearby threats to stress over. He was surprisingly reassured by the feeling and closed his eyes when the suns blinding rays became too much for him.

Not even crickets or insects dared to chirp in the suddenly large radius he could pick up. It was rather unnerving, yet he found himself loving the complete feeling of solitude and silence. He had always cursed the silence and loneliness that filled his world, but now it all felt so foolish and unnecessary. He realized he rather liked being alone. Because people *and humans* annoyed him.

His throat felt comfortable and silky once again. With a sudden impulse, he hummed his content, and a deeper rumble than he was used to, greeted him. His body went ridge, adrenaline that he was unfamiliar with surged through his newly developed veins. He took silent notice that he felt more artery pathways than he ever had before. That was something he surely hadn't ever felt before, because how would anyone ever know the exact status of their bodies like this? Somehow he noticed he did, along with the sudden complete attunement he felt within his body. It was as if he could clearly see every vein, every artery, and which path led to each organ. He swore he could even feel the pump of every blood vessel in where the feeling originated. It was unlike anything else in the world.

He could even understand the state of each organ and nerve, a few felt bruised, but were tingling as they seemed to repair behind the backs of his eyelids. It was as if someone had given him the cheat notes to how everything within his body functioned, a blueprint to everything that connected him as a living being. It was unsettling and felt wrong to know so much about his body, but he didn't quite

question it for now. He reveled in the euphoric feeling it gave him instead of focusing on the negatives and other things he defiantly should be questioning right now but isn't. He feels far too fluttery and light to think of such heavy things. He hadn't felt light in so long, he hadn't felt free of his mental baggage since he was four years old and found out he was quirkless. Yet right now he felt as if a missing piece of him had finally returned to him after being so far from him for so long. He felt as if he could fly if he tried, not just that, but that he'd *soar*.

Really everything about his body screamed 'changed,' he felt like a stranger in his own flesh... and it wasn't a feeling he completely hated...but he did feel uncertain about all these new feelings overtaking him.

Once he understood that something had *changed*, *everything* seemed unknown and brand new. It was as if he was just now seeing the world around him for the very first time, feeling and tasting everything with a whole new perspective. Even the air had a specific taste to it, the earth, the taste of his own tongue, the feeling of sudden overwhelming intimacy he felt from simply laying on the ground.

The world around him suddenly seemed frightening and far too bright for his eyes. He hissed and threw a hand over his overly sensitive eyes, crying out when he tried again and failed. An annoyed almost animalistic growl left his lips, and a deep vibration followed after. The sound felt as if it was originating from a cavity below his ribs. He couldn't figure out ***why*** the sun was suddenly too bright, ***why*** the trees and the green surrounding them were making him feel nauseous and overstimulated. The songs of birds made him nauseous, their chirping was simply so very loud. The world around him thundered and shook with vibrations and electrical cracks of static penetrated the air every few seconds. He guessed that was the speed of sound and hearing such things surely had to mean something...right? *Everything was* ***too much.***

A deep sigh was blown from his nose, a thorough intake of air and the unexpected scents of the forest and flowers overtook his senses. He clamped a hand over his nose as he felt an intense sneeze at the amount of pollen his nose had picked up. The sneeze was successfully warded off, the disgustingly sweet scents of the outdoors however were not. Somehow they smelt stronger than they did a minute ago. It was frustrating, *feeling* so much. He felt like a fucking magnet to everything.

Feeling uncharacteristically aggressive, the pressure of becoming increasingly pissed off took him by surprise. He had never had such strong impulses to ***kill*** something, to take another's life. It was completely startling, yet a darker part of him reveled in the new sensations that came with snuffing out the light behind someone's eyes. The mere thought had him drooling, his pulse racing, and embarrassingly he felt a little hard from the surge of sadism. Whatever that even meant anymore, he wasn't sure. He couldn't understand why such a natural bodily reaction could be embarrassing. Few things truly made sense anymore, the worries of humans no longer suited me anyway.

A low rumbling purr eluded him, his ear managed to make a twitching motion as the sound of hooves pounding on the forest floor echoed throughout his head. The pounding of the hooves against the forest ground was alluring, seducing him in a way he never thought possible before. It was a siren crying out to him, begging for him to finally let loose of all this stress and anger, to take action. Not to mention he felt increasingly *hungry*.

With little reason, purely from instinct, Izuku rose to his feet, aggressively sniffing at the air as he did. As if he could pick out something that smelled desirable simply through such a gesture. He found zero trances of food, though the flowers smelled lovely enough. Picking up the traces of each individual flora and moss was relatively easy, even though he'd never smelled such scents so intently in the past, he now instantly knew which smells led to each plant and whether the plant was pollinated yet or not. The pollen caused a kitten sneeze to be pulled from him, but otherwise, he found himself happily lapping up the scents surrounding him. Soon the soft thrum of life filled his flaring nostrils. A pleased ‘hfmp’ resounded and he began to sneakily follow the path that would no doubt lead him to what he most sought, finally something to fill his all-consuming hunger.

It took a minute of slow and unsteady walking on four legs instead of the usual two before his pace gained a certain steadiness to it and he felt confident enough to try sprinting. And sprinting he did, taking off like a foal on new legs, the thrill of such a feeling was exhilarating and suddenly he'd never felt so free. The further the distance he crossed the more his speed increased and accelerated again until he was in a full-on dead sprint. The thundering of a rapid and pulsating heartbeat filled his invisible hunger. His desire continued to flourish until he was bursting from his organic seams, acidic drool rolled down his maw in droves, and the undeniable heat and wetness sleeping down his muscular arms and legs only furthered the growing arousal of his first hunt. The scent that he found to be fur, warm *breathing* fur, and the pounding of soaring hooves shattered the ground as the life form sprinted, all filling a thirst that lingered deep beneath his skin.

The closer his prey got the more his skin felt uncomfortable and all the more ***wrong***. It was *heavy* and *slow.* His footsteps were too *loud* and alarming for his **prey**. Any creature could hear his clumsy and deafening fleshy thumps against the foliage. It disgusted and frustrated him to no end. How could he have been born with such a ridiculous body? He *needed* a better form, one that was much *quieter*, *lighter*, and much more suited for the environment laid out before him. Humans had no business in a forest such as this anyway, he'd already been breaking the most absolute and scared rule by trespassing here and as such he'd paid a hefty price for such negligence. Life was the most scared gift one could be given and he's been reckless enough to abuse and lose such a special gift.

If he were to become *exactly* what he knew he desired more than any other, he would be able to wholeheartedly claim this forest as his own, taking anything from the fertile land he pleased. Anything that the sky reached would be **his**. Anything the shadows hid would be his and his alone. Everything he wanted would and could be his if only he'd just release himself and free the beast tearing under the surface of his ribcage. A hushed whisper reminded him that all he had to do was shed this horrid and lanky form, and let everything fall away until nothing but his soul lay free.

Bare his soul huh? He guessed one last time wouldn't hurt anyone.

If he could reap such benefits...then wouldn't his entire worthless life and painful suffering all have been worth it?

Obviously, it would end with shed blood, but did he care? He found that ***no***, maybe he *didn't care*.

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Maybe he *wasn't* capable of *caring* anymore.

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The alluring voice was right and so Izuku let the feeling overtake and claim him wholeheartedly. He laid his soul bare and he'd face the consequences of his actions later when he learned to care about such meaningless thoughts again. If the feelings ever came back that is. Maybe this change in perspective would be permanent and maybe with such, he'd finally be allowed to be happy, on his own terms. Maybe happiness meant something different now. And maybe he'd never be the same doe-eyed hero fanboy who loved everyone unconditionally and forgive most evils in the world once he looked into their eyes and saw that they had been just as scared as him. Because he didn't feel

afraid anymore. Not having to worry about anyone but himself seemed undeniably an upgrade from his old and forsaken life.

The more he desired his fantasy to be real the more his body grew to change and accommodate his inner desire as it provided a physical manifestation of everything his soul and spirit yearned for. He wanted to run *free*. He wanted to *hunt*, he wanted to *kill*. ***Freely***. He just wanted to be free of all the chains that kept him tethered to a world he was no longer a part of. A world without a burden sounded pretty irresistible after all. Why would he ever want to come back to such a sad and painful existence when he could run free and never look back on all his previous misfortunes?

But those thoughts were growing much too big, his picture, his perspective was rapidly shrinking and with it the complex thoughts he'd once grown used to. Now more than anything he wished to feel the thrill of the hunt and enjoy the salted and probably metallic taste of his prey on wolfish lips. An innate hunger for more than anything ever before. *It was dangerously enticing. He knew he could grow addicted to this feeling. All he had to do was take the first step and then he'd never look back. Why be human when he could be something so much better?*

It was all he craved and more. No longer did he have a use for a mere two legs, four seemed much more reliable and comfortable anyway. Not to mention those small and rounded human ears were so disgustingly *useless*, how could he be expected to catch his prey with such poor listening devices? The remaining sensation of something sorely missing reminded him of the beautiful and proud tail he was without in this accursed human skin. *How could humans not have such a precious and invaluable asset to their anatomy? It was inconceivable and unforgivable!*

His spine began to tingle and elongate, splintering each acre of flesh to create room for the extra vertebrae and sensitive cartilage. Once the spine came to life and breathed its first sense of life, his once missing tail was rightfully returned to him. His horribly unpleasant and flattened face transformed, growing into something much more comfortable and useful. An elongated maw filled with a multitude of needle-like teeth came into its full glory as all features that identified him as human melted away. Now shapely and pointed velveteen ears fluttered against the windy horizons behind his elongated snout, falling into a resolute pattern with the air surrounding him. His forked tongue slipped out in tactical motion as it reached out to caress the air currents and taste the direction in which the wind was strongest. It took a few seconds to find what he had been searching for, *the sweet scent of prey on the horizon*.

'Yes, this feels much more like home.' He grumbled proudly in his subconscious.

Although four legs were much sturdier than two, not being used to the extra limbs he embarrassedly fumbled a few times. After careful practice, using each foot to find the proper sweet spot in his balance, he managed to perfect the art with little effort. Everything seemed to come to

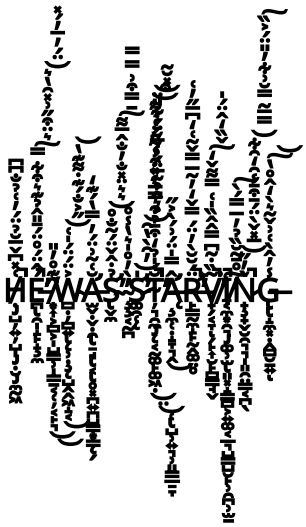
him naturally when he properly listened to his instincts anyway. It took him a moment's notice to embrace the constant impulses being thrown his way, all screaming out for him to simply run. So run he did.

Being the incredible listener he was, he abided by following the voices in his head as they led him somewhere hidden far out of the reach of the sun. The feeling of running so free did wonders for his wounded soul, as new air and warmth flooded his system and began the extended repair of his fragmented heart. He felt intense waves of bliss, pleasure, and excitement. The scent of an especially lively deer bounding ahead of him furthered his feelings of uncontrollable happiness. He felt like a whole new *person*. Yet ***person*** didn't seem like the right word to describe him anymore.

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He raced up a small and grassy mound, running over the occasional root or berry vine that reached out to lap at the fearsome paws carving out the earth's protective layers the harder he went. He paid little mind to them though and instead focused solely on the doe running straight ahead of him. He pushed off his hindquarters to quicken pace, giving a brief side-eye to the doe that was flashing by below him. His plan was to cut her off before the next turn, where he would then respectfully take her in his jaws and end both their suffering quickly. Surely mother nature would understand, and if she didn't well he'd challenge her too.

Just as he had predicted she took a sharp right, with a victoriously malicious inhuman grin he leaped off his mound. He was airborne for a whole two seconds before he was latching his maw around a thin and delicate neck. All it took was a simple ‘snap’ and her lights were snuffed out in an instant. And just like that, the hunt was over, uneventful but successful nonetheless. He gruffed in moderate disappointment at the lack of a proper challenge, but his stomach reminded him of exactly why he'd wrapped up the hunt so quickly. *He was* ***starving.***



He dropped the lifeless doe as soon as he felt the last muscle twitch in his jaws. His serpentine tongue grazed the deer's neck, unconsciously feeling for any signs of life, when it found none it retreated back to the place it came from. Feeling a surge of haughty pride, he stood over his prey and gave a guttural, yet victorious howl. He did so with the slight hope of bringing a competitor to his location, he couldn’t remember much of what had happened, but a burning need to maim the blurred image bouncing around his thoughts was unrelenting. He swore revenge on the one who had left him bleeding on the filth-covered ground, to die alone and at the time afraid. He'd sworn that would be the last time he'd ever feel such weakness again. Fear was but a precursor to valor and valor was gained through strength. Something he surely had enough of now, he no longer feared some invisible God nor did he cower in the face of death, instead he intended to bring it to anyone that dared cross him. The burning need to kill rumbled in the bottomless pit of his stomach. Maybe he was hungry for more than a little meat.

Revenge did sound pretty delicious. *(Revenge did sound pretty delicious)*

To his utter dismay, no predator dared approach him as he feasted on his first taste of power, he gave a disappointed whine but continued dining regardless. Surely the forest couldn't be *too* large for him to not be given a second chance to right this wrong. It would just have to wait for another day it seemed. **Karma** was after all a ruthless *bitch*, it came for *everyone*. Maybe his day just wasn't here yet. But tomorrow...tomorrow would be a new day filled with ample opportunities.

He could be a *patient* wolf, he could wait *millennia* if needed. When the bastard dared to show its cowardly tail, then he’d really show them who the real boss of this forested haven was. Only one would come out on top and Izuku would be damned if he lost to some lowly lesser wolf. He felt damn near indestructible now and he was more than willing to show it. He needed the practice anyway because surely more challenges would be around every corner and he had zero intentions of losing this second chance at life.

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It seemed his salvation would come much sooner than he’d expected and he couldn’t be more thrilled about such a variable. A few hours after his first hunt a second strange wolf’s scent entered

his awaiting nostrils. His tail stood tall with pride as anticipation overtook him, his stance held firm, and screamed confidence.

To further his point of challenging the stranger wolf he threw his head back and gave a cocky howl, tail rising high behind him in a show of absolute dominance. Soon an auburn wolf, much smaller and more skinny than Izuku came into view. The wolf was huge, around 5 and a half feet or so he'd estimate. Izuku would've thought it was enormous had he been in a smaller much weaker form, but currently he towered over the cowardly creature, much like an insect compared to a human child. The beast looked rather *sickly.* **Illness** seeped out of its's every pore, and her stature was *weak* with most muscles seeming to have long deteriorated from the sickness encasing her.

Her snout was cream-colored but littered with grotesque boils, some pitch black, others a dark almost black green. Izuku's own snout turned up in a disgusted sneer. He had wanted nothing more than to bid this ill creature adieu, but his eyes zeroed in on the other's apparent bloodied snout. A vague feeling of silent rage bubbled over under the surface of his fur as a certain memory rushed back to him. He could practically smell his own blood on her breath, he could even make out a few remains that had once been inside his own body prior. No doubt in his mind, this sickly beast was the one he had punched in the snout, he could tell in an instant. Upon closer inspection, he could see where the remnants of his own blood and hers mixed together, coating the once creamy snout in a crimson barrage. Though the blood splatter was long old now, several days old, the wilted color was undeniable.

Before his mind could linger any longer on the matter, a bloodcurdling snarl tore out of Izuku's throat. He wanted nothing more than to kill this wretched thing and avenge his past self who'd died at her despicable hands. This she-wolf, the one that had ravished his body, mauling it beyond recognization, to a point he was sure his own mother wouldn't have been able to identify his corpse. He'd be some half-bit john doe with no name and no legacy left behind, what would that have meant for his mother? The one that had so eagerly awaited him at home? He owed as much to himself and to her. He hated making his mother worry and he was probably doing it all over again. Except for this time maybe he wasn't making it back home. Did his home even still exist for a beast like him?

Despite his burning fury, defeating this sickly wolf almost seemed like a distasteful joke from the universe. *How was he supposed to dominate this pathetic excuse of a beast in this sorry-decayed state? How was he to show how much strength he wielded? To prove himself as something more than some lowly 'Deku?'* It would be an ***insult*** to win this battle and he fucking hated that. The wolf *wouldn't* even be a *challenge*, let alone the consequences of catching whatever illness it had was high and gave pause to Izuku's actions. Hesitance was a frightful and fickle beast.

Though as the beast mockingly circled him, lips curled up in *challenge* and ***disobedience*** Izuku lost all hesitancy and lunged at the ugly monster's jugular. The auburn wolf managed to dodge, at least the intended target, but still took damage from Izuku landing an iron grip on her decaying shoulder

causing the appendage to cave in on itself. The sickened wolf howled in a distorted and unnatural tone, one that hurt Izuku's eardrums, causing them to nearly bleed from the horrific song. *Was that caused from the sickness or some other underlying condition?*

Snarling into the grotesque skin to appease his anger, Izuku threw his head back and forth, shaking the flesh and the entirety of the smaller wolf's body as he did so. She cried out in a pained whimper but stood no match for pulling off the younger and **much** stronger wolf. A sound of ripping skin and muscle, filled the clearing as Izuku pulled up on the shoulder, a large bloodied chunk in his maw. He grunted at the awful taste and threw the clump off to the side in a hurried motion, not wanting to risk consuming any of the rotten and blackened meat. The taste left his mouth bitter and tingly in discomfort and disgust, its favor nothing like the fresh and delicate tenderloin of the doe. It was disappointing but to be expected.

The female wolf limped, attempting to circle the younger male again, but Izuku's pursuit was relentless and he mercilessly lunged for her throat again. This time she was much too slow and his hit landed perfectly. Without the slightest hesitation, he snapped the puny neck, causing the she-wolf to fall limp in his grasp. He held her corpse above his head rearing up on his hind legs as he jerked her towards the sky for a few more seconds before abruptly dropping the body with a disinterested 'hmfp.'

Allowing his forepaws to land back onto the soil with a soft thump, he spits the tainted blackened blood to his right with an aggrieved snarl. Before rubbing a furry forearm across his snout in hope of wiping away all the nastiness of her infectious existence. He gave a disappointed, yet victorious howl to the clouds. He had avenged himself sure, destroying the creature who had left his human husk decimated and maimed for no other reason than violence. Yet he felt an emptiness settle within him as if he had lost something or maybe was still missing something. He wasn't sure.

Was victory supposed to feel so empty? *He'd never thought as much but maybe...maybe it wasn't what it was all cracked up to be?*

Did that mean Kacchan had been wrong this entire time?

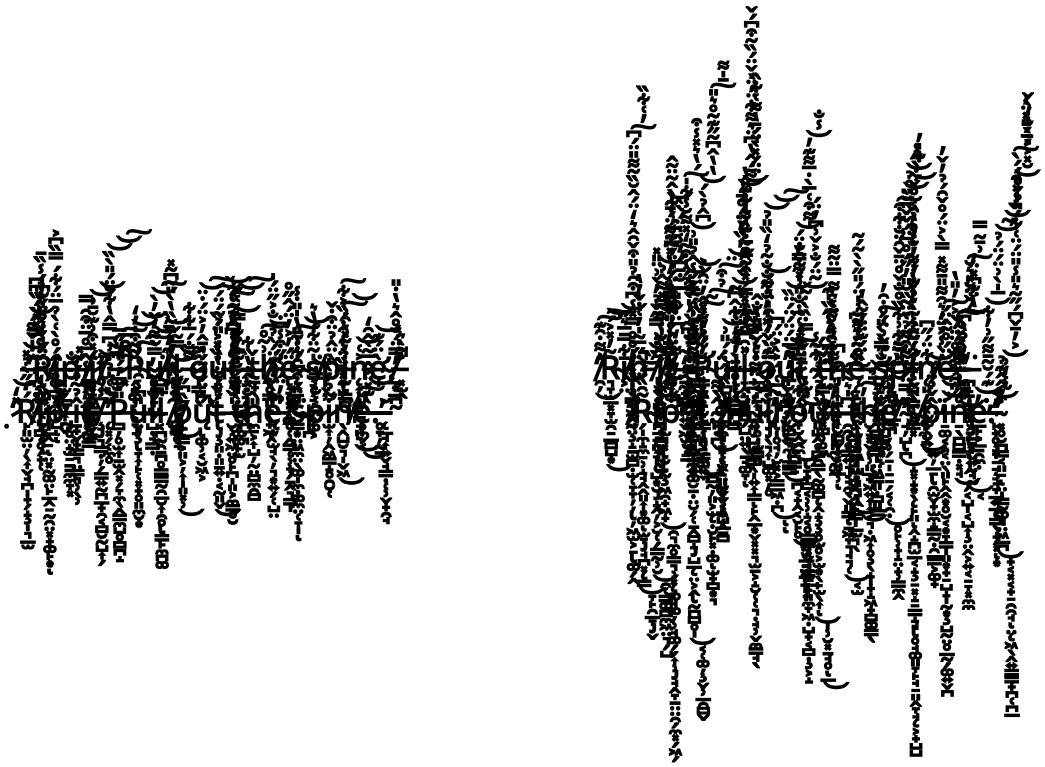
But wait...who was Kacchan again?

His gaze fell back to the still bleeding out and crippled mess at his feet. The blood seeping out was pitch black and thick like tar, inky and full of what he guessed had to be sickness. It crawled towards Izuku's equally as inky paws, pooling around the first three toe pads it could reach, he gave an annoyed gruff before pulling his paw up and walking out of the splash zone. He didn't

particularly like the way that shit was squirming about at his feet. It looked *alive* and *alien* and he wasn't about to allow that to enter his body.

The longer he looked at the defeated beast at his feet, the more he felt the nagging pull at the back of his mind. It was as if something was trying to reach out to him, calling him. It was screaming at him to listen, *to do something*. Not caring to listen, he sat on his hunches and gave his left ear a good scratch as he closed his eyes, enjoying the growing-familiar stillness of the forest. The voice at the back of his head grew louder and more threatening over time. This time he opened the invisible link and reached out to the voice, **embracing** it for once.

'Rip it out now. Pull out the spine before it's too late.' It growled with an inhuman roar. A look of confusion filled his wolfish features. He listened to the voice as it repeated the same sentences over and over again. The voice echoed through his head like a virus, overtaking his consciousness and invading his every thought and desire. It felt as if his body was being puppetted by another invisible force. But the voice...it didn't sound like an enemy, but rather an exexpected ally.



Not really understanding why or if there was a reason for such a barbaric thing, he slowly rose back up to a standing position. He cautiously walked back over to the apparent dead wolf below him. He gave a curious hum, cocking his head to the side in puzzlement. Then he took a second step closer until he was hovering over the region where the spine was hidden away by coarse auburn fur. It almost had an unnatural pale blue glow to it, it was as if he could suddenly see the blueprint of this

wolf's body, just as he had seen his own. It was strange and puzzling, but fascinating nonetheless. It caught his interest if nothing else.

Hesitantly Izuku bowed his head, anxious incisors hovering over the stilled corpse at his feet. His heart clenched and unclenched, overwhelmed with a sense of worry and disgust fighting at odds within him. A part of him sneered down at the lowly body, wanting nothing more than to **savagely** tear into this lukewarm body in a most barbaric slaughter. Another smaller part of him felt immense **guilt,** and an unexpected hesitancy to maim an already lifeless body. His morals had never felt more ~~*grey.*~~

Under the fur, he swore he saw something squirm and wiggle under the surface, the same way a centipede moved he summarized. A few erratic twitches and the faint traces of the inflicted wounds somehow healing brought Izuku down from his moral stupor, making the decision for him. Instinct won as he thrust his razor-sharp canines into the smaller wolf's back. He couldn't quite feel bone, but on instinct, his forked tongue slithered out and located the accurate and easiest route that led to the spine after a few tries. The bare spine felt rigid and sharp within the insides of his mouth, he could taste the familiar metallic flavor he had come to know as his own blood as the top of his maw was sliced with some invisible force. It didn't cause much discomfort. Nothing more than a mere prick really. It was the taste in itself that was unpleasant and almost had the blackened beast gagging.

Keeping a vice grip around the entire collum of sturdy bone, Izuku gave an erratic pull, the spine came looser than he'd have thought, almost too easily. His mind was racing, his heart rate thumping brutally against his enlarged ribcage, one that suddenly felt much too big. The spine wiggled like a squirmish centipede for a whole minute after removal. The sight was somewhat traumatizing and horrifying as if the bone was alive and had a mind of its own. Once it settled, becoming motionless beside the few odd twitches, the inner voice lurking at the back of his head spoke up again.

'That's it. Now finish it.' The voice growled, sadistic excitement clearly enveloped in its deep inhuman tone.

'End it?' Izuku asked, what he somehow knew to be himself. Apparently, a secondary consciousness that had been formed for the mere purpose of guiding the pup who was still green in his gills.

'Crush it. Let the vertebrae snap and shatter, otherwise, it will never be over.' The voice growled more strictly this time. Izuku took the hint but ignored it, as he had more questions.

'If I didn't crush it, what would happen?' The morbidly curious teen asked, his voice threatening to shake with the onset of nerves gathering in his stomach. Something about that question and the answer he'd hear left his veins freezing over. He felt like he already knew the answer, but he needed it to be vocalized.

'If even a singular piece of the spinal cord remained, a new body would form and it would walk again.' The voice grumbled, disgruntled and annoyed. Izuku mentally flinched, his physical body giving a sudden jerk as he did.

'Oh.' Was the only answer he could manage, a million in-one questions, yet no words to ask them.

The second voice gave a throaty chuff, one that Izuku was sure was meant to initiate a human pity chuckle. The boy felt like he was losing sanity the longer he stayed in his own thoughts, seemingly talking to a voice now residing in his head. That sounded pretty damn crazy. Alarmingly, Izuku felt his own inhuman chuckle rumble from deep inside his chest. Maybe he rather enjoyed being crazy. It felt a hell lot more **fun** than he'd ever thought possible.

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(Early February)

Anonymous reports of a dangerous and temperamental wolf hidden away in the woods startled the on-duty officers. Sure they dealt with worse things than a potentially rabid wolf on a daily basis, but not so much an abnormally large aggressive wolf wandering the nearby woods. They knew it must be one of the recently escaped and possibly infected wolves from their local zoo, but the mere description left unpleasant tingles on each of their necks. This creature, how it had been described was unlike any other wolf, it sounded like a fearsome beast straight out of some comic book, a fairy tale creature. In other words a real, and very much alive modern-day ***monster***.

Without delay, the officers and a few pro heroes were on the hunt for the escapee, with guns, and quirks at the ready in the event of the worst-case scenario. No one really wanted to shoot down some wolf, especially such a rare one at that. But if push came to shove and the beast was truly as deranged and feral as the reports stated it to be, a lot of bad possibilities could present themselves

and they weren't about to be liable for any more deaths. They just couldn't risk the life of one wolf verse the many unsuspecting civilians it could encounter. God forbid this wolf snacked up someone's child, they just simply couldn't take any risk.

Arriving at the scene though the officers were all left baffled, there was certainly no sign of any wolf-related misdeeds. No signs of life in this forest really, not even birds were singing as freely as one would imagine this far away from the nearest city. The forest was left eerily quiet, a sense of false safety that many picked up on. Really the whole place seemed overall cursed, something dark and dangerous was staying there. Despite their unease the pros and the officers scoured the entirety of the forest, searching for any type of signs of a feral and dangerous wolf, but found none. Not even a corpse of any sort. Or so they thought, a day later the body of one frightful wolf was indeed found, but considering the horrific state it had been left in. They all agreed to reframe from sharing such information with the public in fear of rising panic.

The corpse of a large female wolf, of unknown origin was sent off to some secret underground lab for testing after that. No one mentioned the obvious spikes protruding off the wolf, or the unnatural and alien appearance of it. The wolf's corpse had been completely mutilated, decimated to nothing more than some loose fur and a few misshapen and splintered bones. One thing everyone seemed to pick up on, the wolf had been left without a spine. Another startling revelation came into each of their minds, something much bigger than this wolf was out there. Something even scarier than this 5.5 feet tall and 10 feet long bloodied wolf carcass. The case was then closed after this, leaving many scratching their heads at what this new and potentially mutated creature could be. An extinct direwolf species? But since when did wolves ever have retractable spikes and goat horns?

Two days later they gave up and the case of 'the deranged wolf in the woods was left cold. The case of one missing Izuku Midoriya wasn't far behind, sure they were all still looking, but with no leads, the trailing was steadily losing velocity, and acceptance of his disappearance was starting to creep in. Life went on for most, for others, they continued to grieve the loss of the sunshine boy. It was exactly at the three-week marker that something incredible happened, Izuku Midoriya had **returned**. He was a bloodied mess and seemed trapped in a daze, but he was alive regardless and that was all that mattered.

The matter of the mysterious 'wolf in the woods' case was all but forgotten, though days later a few more mutilated wolf corpses would surface and raise some eerie and unexplainable questions. Three bloody and mutilated corpses of the missing wolves caught fire with the press, as people speculated on what beast could take down three full-grown wolves. Luckily these more fresh wolve corpses were unlike the first one, appearing tiny in comparison to the previous unexplainable female. Hence the officers and the pro agreed to publicising these incidents, though with great apprehension, but reporters left them no real choice after one had caught the officers relocating their bodies red-handed. They never revealed the first corpse and the officers were never filled in on any lab results or information pertaining to the she-wolf. A new national secret was set afoot. Things quieted back down after the heroes held a small press conference to reassure the public that all was *still* well and that the attacks were determined to have been caused by a local brown bear. A complete lie, but one they thought necessary.

The news grew cold, losing all fire after their dull conference was broadcast through most residents' homes. Of course, much relief was shared between the heroes and all their allies who were in the

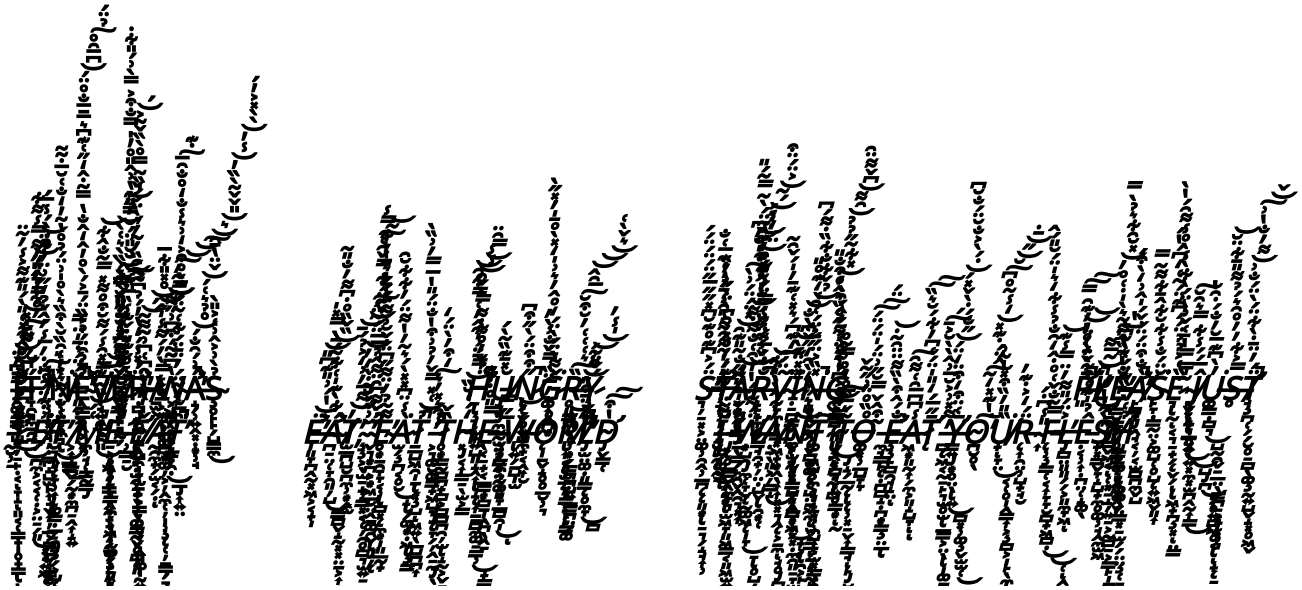
'know' about the case. The corpses left many unanswered questions, one of the most prominent being just 'why the hell these wolves had human DNA mixed in their wounds. While the other was incredibly suspicious and concerning in its own right, 'why the hell was their human-like teeth marks on one of the wolves? Of course, these facts were all kept under wraps and hidden away, never to see the light of day again. Though these worries kept living on in several avid minds.

Regardless there was something very very wrong with these wolves found in the woods and something off with the newly returned ***boy*** from the woods. Of course, no one even thought to compare the two in the same sentence, nor the cases. That of course would be a most overlooked possibility on its own. A little green-haired woman was going to find out just how much the officers and heroes had overlooked much later. Inko knew that there was in fact something not right with her boy, but **she loved her son.** He was ***her world*** and she would do ~~***everything,***~~ ***anything*** for him. Even if that meant covering up misplaced bodies or vomiting up lies to cover new truths asked about her son's recently developed behaviors. Because Inko loved her son, many more people might end up dying. ***But Inko Loves her son.***

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(A While Since Izuku Got His Revenge)

Over an infinite passage of time, a lone direwolf was wandering aimlessly, transversing from forest to forest with no true goal in mind. No thought filled any of his actions, it was all simply a starving stomach and his bare instincts leading him to new realms. The wolf was *starving*, no matter how much flesh he consumed, no matter how many rabbits he caught. No matter how many wolves he ~~*killed*~~ *relocated to better places. Nothing was* ***enough. It never was.***



His aimless wandering wasn't completely unsuccessful, some lead him to fruitful conquests of boar or sika deer. But even consuming entire big game prey, leaving nothing more than the occasional bone, still felt unflattering. The wolf couldn't consume enough to be satiated for even a second. This creature couldn't even **remember** what *'being full'* felt like. It was an agonizing trek. The further he got the *emptier* he felt.

The wolf held no purpose, without a mate he was pack-less and without a pack, he was left defensive and irritable. Always on high alert, burning more calories than he had stored. Sleep was limited and filled with darkness and horrific things he never seemed to *remember*. His head felt loose on his neck as if it would simply break away if he moved a certain way. He felt *sick*, ill.

When an animal feels that something is wrong it will act irrationally, and violently. An unpredictable force with seemingly more grip in its bite. All of these were its last attempts at self-preservation.

This large and darkened direwolf may have very well been the last or first of its kind, especially considering it had killed the only other of its *species*. With a mind of a cornered and dying animal and only his instincts to lean in and trust the wolf felt like he'd *explode*.

His outsides felt as tightly wound as his insides. The last strand held on with all its might, but it was a losing battle. The strong instinct to strike first and ask questions later was the only option. *Nothing* else mattered, *survival* was the only answer.

The animals of the forest he visited seemed to realize just how dangerous this beast was becoming the more days dragged on because they could sense its bloodlust from miles away. This caused even less prey to be a possibility for the lanky and malnourished wolf. His bones felt brittle and broken, his fur which was never quite sleek was even less desirable to look at. His eyes glowed an unnatural and ungodly teal. He looked like a beast beating on death's door, but with means of escaping this plain, destined to roam it endlessly for the rest of his days. The instincts ripped and tore everything below the surface, carving the wolf from the inside out, until there was nothing left to take anymore. He was a mere husk, a jail of flesh for his own special place in hell. One with little to no purpose simply meant to wander aimlessly for his eternity. However long that lasted. ***Alone.***

Each of his limbs appeared lankier and longer than any normal wolf's legs should be, his every bone on full display. His spine, which he somehow inherently knew was his ultimate *weakness* was exposed and almost taunting his enemies to pounce on the first chance to kill him. The beast knew he should've been protecting his weakness with his full attention, but his mind was muddled and his few thoughts couldn't decide if he wanted to protect this supposed weakness or leave it exposed. With a morbid hope, something would just come along and end this painful and pitiful existence he had become.

His muddled and fragmented mind was at war with itself as his instincts roared and shredded at his insides. They were rampaging like a broken and caged beast, one that had been pushed to go on for far too long. This beast had **snapped**, becoming something chaotic and dangerous, a danger to itself and everything that breathed in its vicinity. A beast with no fear of god within it and nothing to lose was the worst kind of enemy one could face.

His body which should've given out in the first week was somehow holding on and staying together, mostly. His body was fighting its every instinct to fall down and just die already, it fought with every tooth and nail it had to keep its host alive. Each time he fell down for the last time, it'd encourage the beast to get up again and keep moving forward to a place neither knew. Despite how broken and bloodied the body had become, it kept moving forward. The body simply wouldn't let him die no matter how lost his soul felt. His once prime fighting spirit was nothing but smoldering ash, compared to the raging flame it once was. It was all but snuffed out by now.

The wolf couldn't even recall why he had fought so hard in the beginning. Everything before today was a blur. His memory of the day would fade with the morning light that greeted him each new day. All days blurred together until all that remained was a single day, a single experience was all the beast had left. It wasn't long before the last 'human' thought had vanished just to be replaced with singular words, relating to minimum actions and basic chores until all that survived was *'hungry.' Unanquelenchable hunger that ate him whole, from the deep insides to the less than impression outsides.*

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(A indefinite amount of days pass)

The soft scent of lavender and warmth caught the wolf's full attention. It was the scent of a rabbit, plump and filled with life. A life he hoped to absorb and use as a means to restore his own diminished essence. It was a plausible idea, lengthening one's own life force by means of consuming a new and more vital *essence*. ***Stealing*** its power for his own *selfishness.*

Following the scent was enticing and left the beast filled with anticipation. The soft lavender led the wolf to an old and hollowed-out stump. Using the pads on each of his feet to soften the sounds of his presence, the wolf stealthily snuck up to the first opening of the deceased tree. He craned his head ever carefully, letting his hunting instincts guide him through every motion. He didn't have the capability to think for himself anymore, he could only rely on a hunger-pained stomach and vital survival instincts.

There, at the bottom of the stump laid a large and plump brown and white hare, sleeping peacefully with no awareness of itself. Without a second thought and no hesitation the wolf latched onto its neck without incident. Like a shadowy assassin in the dark of night, he strikes quickly and quietly. The hare gave a cry of surprise before its life essence was consumed, becoming conformed into one with the starving wolf's own essence.

The wolf ate its prey quickly, leaving nothing but a few bones and clumps of matted fur in its place. Slightly more satisfied than before, he trotted off in search of the next quarry he could get his paws on. Bloodied crimson painted the stump and the ground surrounding it, in a morbid Picasso of nature.

Bits of red splashed onto the ground as the wolf made his path, his chest and muzzle still heavily coated clear as day even with his blackened fur. Though it wasn't nearly as noticeable with the darkened depth of the fur, as it otherwise would have been with a lighter coat, it still shimmered under the fiery glare of the sun. The bloodied paws were easier to spot, as the tips of each of the feet were colored a soft white against the shadowy black.

The white would naturally draw anyone's attention with how much it contrasted with the otherwise mostly pitch-black figure, but what made this wolf even more special was the eerie patterns etched deep into his fur. Between the zagged white patterns and the skeleton-like designs on his feet, he was an abnormal beauty. The creature looked like a beast straight from the gates of hell, invading the lands and causing all the rivers to bleed carmine.

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Now thirsty and once again on the hunt in hopes of soothing the steady and painfully familiar ache within his gut, the wolf followed the scent of the closest water source. Thankfully by some divine luck, a flowing river was close in distance. The wolf's trots became hurried and desperate, and with the sudden urgency, his form became a wobbled run.

The cover of the nearby foilage whipped in every direction as the giant wolf rushed through the varying greenage, slapping and cutting into his fur and the skin that lay beneath it the further he went. The pain was simply added to everything else, not worth dragging a cry out of him. He was weak, but he wasn't weak enough to cry out because some scrubs scratched him up or impaled his cheeks as he ran. Any kind of unnecessary sound or movement would simply slow him down in the grand scheme of things. He needed every drop of energy he could conserve. His recovery time was dwindling the longer he went on fully empty.

His running this time paid off nicely, the river his nose had so expertly led him to, was glorious, the brightest shade of green you could ever see surrounded the riverside. All new plants, and life that the wolf had never recalled seeing before filled his vision. Pleasant and fresh scents filled his senses, begging him to reach them and explore more deeply until he found exactly what he had been looking for. Fresh water and a nice place to rest, maybe his *final* resting lace, but that wasn't given much thought. The water itself was overly distracting, leaving him breathless and coloring him enchanted with each step *closer*. It was haunting how much the forest and river *lured* him in, it was as if he fell into a trance. A *trap*, laid by none other than the forest itself, and maybe *it **was***. But who was he to ignore this siren's call when he had so little to lose anyway.

Everything beckoned him to drink, to feast endlessly. Here felt safe, something he couldn't ever remember being. This felt like his own personal paradise and he knew at that moment he never planned on leaving. Why would he? With a steady flow of fresh water, a sturdy influx of new and fresh life to consume, beautiful foliage to curl up into, and to top it off, the quiet was peaceful. He welcomed each gift offered to him with ease, without question, and without fear. Fear no longer seemed important, not when he was the biggest predator out here. He'd made sure of as much, killing any and all rivals that dared to cross the threshold of his domain. None had even come close to taking what was **his**.

Everything had *always* been so goddamn loud, so suffocating, but here, in this very moment all the wolf could hear was silence. Allowing himself the sudden bliss without worry, he dropped his head down to the water's edge, lapping up the deliciously fresh and revitalizing water at his fingertips and ripe for the taking. He stayed like this for a time he couldn't properly determine, simply lapping at the water as he pleased.

However, the peace was never meant to last as fate would have it. A loud plop into the nearby water had him on high alert, pulling his gaze away from the water he peered out over the forest with great tension. He hadn't seen anything out of the normal, hadn't heard a single blade of grass out of the ordinary. Everything was as it had always been since he had arrived until he turned to look at the water pooling before him. Another plop and some incomprehensible sounds left the dire wolf with a most terrifying sight.

One second he had been rich in nutrients and heart, then the next his entire body fell lax, seeming to fall apart at the very seams. His body went entirely limp and buckled, lifeless as if the puppeteer of his fate had finally cut his strings. All he could do was let out a cried whimper, as a feeling he wasn't familiar with wrapped around him. The whimpering wouldn't stop no matter how hard he begged it to. His vision blurred and battered the longer the whimpering overcame him, a fit of dizziness left his muscles collapsing in on themselves. With a loud thump, he fell to the forest floor in a cold and listless heap. The half of his body closest to the water fell into the freezing oasis, while his back legs and tail fell to the side of the bank, flattening much of the vibrant foliage he had thought was so beautiful moments ago.

Somewhere deep in his consciousness, the wolf knew this was the end, he was at the end of his rope. It had overtaken him so swiftly, attacking him from all sides he couldn't have reacted any sooner. His body felt damp and colder than it ever had before. He could feel everything leaving him, his sturdy warmth, the rabbit whose essence he had so recently consumed, with his own essence leaving him a short while later. All of it was weeping out of him, along with his own wolfish tears. He wasn't happy and was always in so much pain, but he still didn't feel ready to leave it all behind. He wanted to fight it with everything he had, but he simply had nothing left to fight with. The tank was entirely empty, he was spent. His expiration date had struck once again.

How many times could one 'person' die? He cried morosely to no one but himself for company.

As his vision began fading in and out quicker, he let his attention draw to the blurred face beside him in the water. The very image that had left him so damned, a constant mockery of what his life could've been. He couldn't remember whose face it was, nor could he make out any of the features. That all mattered little, his heart reacted more to this blurry silhouette than anything else he'd come upon. It thumped louder than ever before, doing its damned near best to flee from his chest. His heart seemed to know more than his muddled mind.

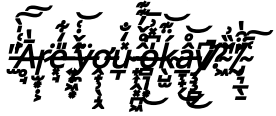
The searing pain and warmth that filled his heart when he locked eyes with the glimmering crimson ones looking back at him left him breathless, or maybe his lungs had finally collapsed. The only image he could clearly make out in the blurred figure was a pair of dazzling ruby-colored eyes, they glowed just as brightly and as frighteningly as the wolves had previously. The look in those pools spoke of a deep sadness, one that was masked with unfiltered hatred. The eyes looked lonely, more so than the wolf felt. The beast's heart thumped loudly against his brittle chest, this was it. This was his person. And he was never going to see them again. This was the end of everything.

His eyes felt so very heavy. He could no longer fight the sensation, instead allowing himself to be thrown headfirst into whatever realm awaited him next. As his vision faded to bitter blackness, he kept his eyes locked on the crimson company before him. Everything else felt bare, his body no longer ached and the thundering in his head had all but stopped. Everything had. He realized he could no longer feel anything and that was a chilling relief because suddenly everything was blank. Not even black, just simply blank turned into nothingness. The wolf accepted such, but the boy lingering within him did not.

"Kacchan."

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"Are you okay?"



"Can You Get Up?"

"Can you get up?"

"Don't keep us waiting."

"Don't Keep Us Waiting."

"It's Time To Get Up Izuku."

" It's time to get up Izuku. "

'Izuku it's time to wake up,' whispered a million unidentifiable voices. Each voice overlapping the next, running on an endless loop with varying tones and accents. It was as if the shadows themselves were calling to the wolf, luring him into a world that lead to nowhere and everywhere all at once.

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Prelude 02: The Beast Within All Of Us

Chapter Summary

Izuku meets a second half of himself he didn't know existed in a strange land. Inko is finally reunited with her beloved son, at least she thinks she is, Izuku isn't exactly how she remembered him.

Chapter Notes

~Hiya! Welcome back to another completed rewrite of older chapters! Be sure to reread or check out the new chapters as much might have changed! ~

A big part of this chapter involves vivid imagery and I thought I'd share a few of my inspirations! This time it's a few images I found on Pinterest. Obviously, I don't own them, but I compiled them into a single image for easier viewing.
Pinterest -> https://www.pinterest.com/pin/109493834681824758

One thing to consider when reading or showing interest in this series is confusion a word that very much fits certain themes of this fic. It's written to intentionally drive you up a wall and make your brain shut down haha once we get past the 5-8 part interlude it will all become a lot clearer as Izuku's headspace itself is clearing and healing along the same journey as us. So please be patient and give it a shot, I understand if it's not your cup of tea but please just embrace the feelings rather than harshly question them. Remember this narrator is unreliable and constantly changing, through passages of time or getting inside various characters' heads.

~Warnings for this chapter include~ Violence, blood, body horror, mentions of panic attacks, mild detailing of panic attacks, obviously cussing, there's some dubious touching but it's from his consciousness??? and other crazy shit no one fully understands :D ~

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Prelude 02: The Beast Within All Of Us

Part 3 of 'The World In Which We Live'

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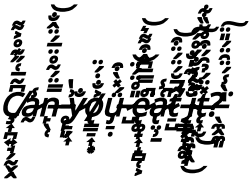
(During the same time the feral direwolf rampages through the forest)

A boy, with a name long last, wondered about a world in which time seemed to neither flow nor evolve, yet there were the unmistakable signs of activity and stale life. The world was completely black and white in color, electrical static, and white noise seemed to take a physical form in this desolate world. A few odd flashes of color could be noticed each time the static seemed to flicker, though the colors were vibrant against the black and greys. They added enough presence to be hard on the eyes that were so used to dull and diluted colors. Only the primary and secondary colors existed in these random flashes, striking as quickly as they were harsh, acting as a sudden flash of lightning would. It had the boy, flinching in recoil each time the flashes landed. Rather they were near or far, he'd flinch as if clockwork, pure instinct. He felt completely disorientated and somehow he felt *afraid*. Though he couldn't remember what these words flooding into his mind meant.

What was the act of feeling something?

What was this emotion, his brain supplemented?

What is 'emotion?'



(Can you eat it?)

It was all so confusing and the world was so *blurry*. A state matching his inner discord. The world and everything here felt ***off***. The world itself felt unsteady and easily broken if he used too much pressure for each step. The grey textured 'flooring' crumbled with groans that had long gone silent, each step he took seemed like it would be his last, yet it was still neverending. Something gently caressed the top of his head the closer to getting to somewhere he didn't know existed. It felt as if he was being ***tamed***.

The world was silent, yet deafening, the constant fluttery onslaught of white noise and static was giving the boy a severe cause of insanity. He wanted to scream, to shout out. **Do** *something* to make it all **stop**, but neither pounding in his head nor the obnoxious noises ceased. He opened what he thought to be his mouth, but not a sound escaped. Not even an intake of breath could be caught. It

was maddening. Of the voices luring him to land, he neither nor of nor understood. He was so tired of the ***silence***.

Black lines, crawled at increasing speeds among every surface the eyes could see, crawling readily across the blank and endless grey walls, painting them in messy spiderwebs of pure darkness. The lines moved as if they were alive, overtaking everything they pleased. Though with an almost sentientness to them. They were live wires, making quick work of the blank canvas around them. The boy watched in morbidly silent curiosity, as a grouping of specially active lines covered the entirety of the ground at his feet. With each movement more blackened lines appeared, just to spread more of their influence as they went.

Grey and black static, in the shapes of spilled clouds, covered the walls, if there were in fact walls at all, as they seemed to float and become one with the air particles and sky above. The static clouds moved in the same way an old-timey movie reel had once moved, flashes of secondary and primary colors coated certain cuts in the floating film, flashing brilliantly and blindingly. The boy had to hold a hand against his brow to block the distracting colors as he quickly walked under the static streams. Whenever he turned his eye away from the scene he'd be assaulted with phantom touches, ones that littered his body with imaginary scars and in shapes he could no longer recognize. He knew he was always being watched, his body and instincts told him as much, but by what and how far away he had little idea. The deeper he walked into this world the less his instincts spoke to him, he had never felt so ***alone.*** Without that constant voice guiding him, he felt as if something had been torn out of him, forcibly and unpleasantly. It left the empty crater in his soul, as the only reminder of what had previously been 'mine.'

He wasn’t sure where he was walking, or if he was he was *even* walking anywhere or simply moving his legs in place. It was too complicated for his rapidly slowing brain to fully realize. His mind seemed to be shutting down, becoming slower and less evolved the further he went. He felt it deep within his bones, if he were to keep pursuing this path, he would lose all sentience he could still currently grasp. Despite the implication and the feeling lying heavy within his stomach, he pushed on, until he no longer understood what ‘Afraid’ meant.

The boy crossed many invisible bridges, losing, even more, of a part of himself with each passing threshold. No longer could he think of sentences, only a few leftover words that he could still taste in his throat. ***Hunger***, he was *so hungry*. His stomach cried in weakness, begging for nutrients that seemed to not exist in this made-up space.

Hunger was all that remained, the only thing that kept him moving forward. This steady innate desire to eat and be full. No longer could he even remember why he had even started walking or where he was going, his only thought existed simply because his body was crying out for him to help it. Though its pitiful pleas fell on deaf ears.

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(More Time Passes, around the time Izu-wolf fights the she-wolf in the woods)

Some unknown passage of time passed before, suddenly the scenery began to change. While still black and grey in color, the world around seemed to gain shape, transforming and growing into tall black lines. Each shape was different, with a personality of its own. There were ones that shot straight up into an unknown and unseen whited-out sky. Some lines were built tall and sturdy, while others appeared lean with several smaller and thinner lines growing off the mother vein. Few of the sturdy and well-built lines also had small thin appendages growing off them, few even had appendages that seemed to wave at the dark-haired creature below them.

The previously blank and smooth lines seemed to gain varying textures the deeper a path the boy mindlessly followed. The lines gained more three-dimensional characteristics, curves showcasing earthy veins, some lines straight, others curved and zagged, almost appearing as sharpened spears made from solid darkness. Each tree was different and with its own quirks in personality. The next more so than the first, small oval-shaped eyes grew from some of the trees, awake and blatantly staring at the creature that dared to enter their woods. A few others looked on with bored disinterest, just to close their red and yellow eyes again. All of the eyes appeared the same, their irises were a starling red, while their sclerae were a pale yellow and their pupils a stark black.

Some of the eyes blinked in annoyance, others in curiosity and disgust. The boy, who seemed to physically change the further he went, growing a rather dark and monstrous-shaped face, ignored all the stares of the strange and nosy trees. Not appreciating his negligence and arrogance the trees then began to evolve and change right beside the half-human, half-something else below them. They grew pale and milky appendages, ones with slim and narrow shapes that grew into shapely taloned fingers. Though you couldn't see any nails forming from the fingers, they were shaped like small spears of ashy darkness. All were thrust out in quickened motions as they reached aggressively reached out to touch any flesh closest to them, like vipers striking in the darkness.

With their newly formed arms the trees, in a fit of burning anger and hate slapped at the half-bred creature disrupting their pale forest. Working in complete tandem, the arms all assaulted the creatures’ misshapen body, groping at everything that they could reach, slashing and swatting with vigor. Their claws were deeply embedded in the paled flesh ripping and tearing it away, leaving sooty black handprints everywhere their claws reached. No hand dared touch the beast's monstrous face, nor any other affected parts, such as the small darkened tail that swayed behind his backside or the furry erect ears atop his fur-covered head.

Most of the hands touched the lower region of the creature, mostly settling from the navel down, but one especially bold milky hand clawed at the beast's chest. The hand tore into the flesh and left a permanent and sooty black handprint embedded deep within the flesh. The ugly scar imitated a live beating heart, thumping and pulsating across the skin with unnatural and erratic beats. An eternal reminder of the curse afflicting him. A whole new heart. Another followed in suit, but never quite reached as far as the other, landing its own bold sooty print directly under the one showcased on the chest. This secondary handprint however didn't mimic the first, but rather it burned to the touch as if molten lava had kickstarted his veins. His insides and outsides alike burned with an inferno unlike any the other, it was horrifically painful and left an impending feeling of helplessness. The half-creature begged for death with his halfwit and incohesive pattern of animalistic grunts and growls, his entire body feeling as if it would explode, combust into nothing but fleshy visceral.

As he writhed in pain muffled whispers filled the forest, though he was no longer capable of this form of speech and lacked the meaning of each word. That, however, didn't stop his body from having violent reactions to each word that was whispered just behind his ears. The recoil was jarring and filled with pain, as few were able to land their words better than the previous. Words of insult and anger filled the creature's sensitive ears, though the meaning between each of the words sorely escaped him. His dimmed mind could not realize the weight between the words, nor the maliciousness present in the muddled incarnation. Each of the trees chanted a mantra of malice and vengeance, furious that such a half-creature had dared to show itself before them. It disgusted them to no end and they wanted it to vanish. It's *kind* were ***never*** welcome here. The mere brain of a beast held no right to be among the sacred grounds these trees were meant to inhabit. This was a place for the thinking, not the ***damned.***

~~*Worthless.*~~

~~*Disgusting.*~~

~~*Disgrace. Nothing. Deku. Useless.*~~

~~*'You really are nothing but a worthless Deku.'*~~

~~*'Go ***** self. Take a ******* and pray ******** next life'*~~

Don't give up Izuku

I love you, Izuku.

I am so proud of you Izuku.

You mean everything to me.

Please come home Izuku, I still need you.

So many words that made little to no sense, falling on deaf ears despite the obvious venom behind each word. But despite all the words, and possible memories that had now been lost, the creature paid little mind to its surroundings. It simply moved forward, looking for its next location, even if that led to nowhere, it cared little. It held little sense of self-preservation for its own life, it was simply alive because it was hungry, and being hungry required it to hunt. The hunger was neverending and bountiful, all-encompassing. Corrosive and dangerous, yet empty no sense of thrill or accomplishment behind its actions, it simply did them with no thought held. A starving beast that couldn't be satiated. A mere husk cursed to roam the mortal plains for as long as the earth allowed its pitiful existence.

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(An indefinite passage of time has passed)

The forest of taloned hands, that left soot-infused stains in fleshy tissue soon came to an abrupt, yet relieving end. The relief was shortlived, as soon enough another new foe came into sight. At a second glance, a swift and fluent movement of ashen black flashing behind the treeline did little for reassurance. The figure was *tall*, towering nearly as high as the endless treetops, the shadowed figure almost seemed hidden among the fading grey scenery if not for the lively ashes wafting from the shadow's towering form.

The *creature* followed the **figure** with little hesitancy, if there was another creature lurking about maybe it had quarry to share or steal. That slim promise of food at the back of his mind was more than enough to get his feet moving forward. Unknowingly throwing himself headlong into the next uncharted territory. One that held many more secrets, than answers.

The **shadow** was alluring, fluttering in and out of the trees with silence and grace, elegant and lean, moving from place to place almost as if it were dancing to a beautiful melody. A rumbling purr escaped the maw of the creature, and a new spike in energy gave him everything he needed to follow after this sensual illusion. It didn't take long for the trees to completely fade from existence, no longer was the creature in a land filled with menacing and assaulting milky hands. Instead, the familiar dulled and grey walls reentered sight. The shadowed figure was close, the creature not far behind as it quickly tailed in more fluent and concentrated steps.

Right as the creature was to reach out and snatch up the shadow's tail, it vanished into a layer of thin black ash. The moment his hand grazed the shadow's, the silhouette seemed to shatter from the touch. The ashy particles fluttered about the air, some pieces grazing high into the endless white sky and others stayed and entertained the creature with flirtatious whisps and gentle caresses. Caresses that reminded him deeply of a time long passed, but one he desperately wished to return back to. He couldn't remember from whom he had previously received such gentle and loving

sensations, caring little about names and more about returning to a world that seemed so endlessly far away.

Over time, a hand formed from ash, it stroked the monstrous head of the boy, leaving gentle caresses as it admired each strand of silkened black fur. The beast rumbled slightly in pleasure. Apparently, with the head of a beast, he could create sound again. The answer as to why, escaped him his blank mind, though seemed rather obvious. Though that didn't seem to bear fruit for any thought. His mind was still blank elsewhere and in an untouchable place. His body was simply reacting to the sweetened promise of intimacy at his fingertips. It soaked up every gentle touch, but made no movement to make one of his own, he didn't feel worthy to do such. He simply let the ashen hand lead on, taking each subtle command the beautiful embers gave him.

"Do you remember?" A sudden sultry, almost silent voice whispered. It didn't sound in the least bit human, nor like anything he could describe. It was seductive and enchanting, utterly ethereal and whimsical. Otherworldy was another word that came to mind, but only for a split second before that thought too vanished.

"Remember?... What?" The creature gruffed, his voice was equally inhuman as theirs. A noticeable change though was that his was much more feral and ragged, spoken from damaged vocals. Vocals that were never meant to speak or produce sounds besides occasional warning growls and grunts of provocation. It was just as unnatural and inhuman, yet so disgusting *wrong* compared to the seductive and allusive voice before him. A true voice of a ~~*monster*~~.

"Why are you here?" The ethereally beautiful voice asked, stroking the furred cheek with one hand. While the other held the base of the creature's chin, forcing its feral eyes to meet soft velveteen green with the other. The eyes were blurry and dulled, yet the single most beautiful shade of emerald the creature had ever seen. The eyes were so incredibly *warm*.

"I…I do not know." The feral beast grunted, putting pressure gently on the ashy hand, in an attempt to be closer. The creature wanted to feel closer, much closer. It felt as if a deep part of it had been stolen and this was the missing part it had been searching for all along. It wanted to become one with this ethereal being. Even if it cost him his *freedom*.

"Who are you?" The velvet voice tried again, moving its ashen fingers up closer to the beast's unnaturally glowing seafoam eyes.

“I-” The creature tried to answer, its head started to violently throb and its vision began to blur. The comforting touch of the shadowy ashes suddenly felt *uncomfortable, so uncomfortable*. It hated the *disgusting* feeling. *It had to flee! To run and escape this horrid touch!*

The ashen fingers, however, allowed no such movement from the creature. The gentle petting continued inching closer to the beast’s frightful eyes as if searching desperately for something. Not finding the answer it seemed to want, the remaining ashes changed. They suddenly became burningly hot as if they were on fire once again. The creature howled in pain at the burning sensation assaulting its sensitive facial flesh, shaking its wolfish head as hard and violently as it could manage. Anything that could help it free from this ensnared trap, though to no avail. He was trapped, *it had all been a trap!*

The comforting strokes evolved into a pressured and forceful presence, and the ashen fingers dug deeply into the furry flesh. Everywhere it touched was burning the remaining embers into the wolf's eye sockets. The beast cried out in fiery despair, a guttural growl of suffering caused the entire grey world to shake violently and unsteadily. I had almost been enough to cause the entire realm to collapse.

The ashes wouldn’t allow the creature to flee, not when it was this *close*. Not when it had finally *found* this wild and untamed beast again. They had been searching for so long. It had even been worried the two would never be ***reconnected***. *Never to be whole again.* It would never **fail** again. Not like **last** time.

“Then remember!” The voice cried out, the silkiness coming unraveled and collapsing into a scratchy and dry voice. "⊥ɥǝu ʁǝɯǝɯbǝɹ!"

One that screamed sorrow and despair, a voice long worn from the pains of the world. One that had little to lose and even less to gain. A broken and startled voice that had been left tattered by the ways of the world. The world seemed to swim rapidly fading to black as each word was stabbed into his paled flesh.

Rɇmɇmbɇr!

“Remember who you are Izuku! Don’t lose yourself to the fever!”

ᘜ◎ᑎ’t l◎ᔕᥴ ᴎ◎Ꮟ꒱ᔕᥴlF t◎ tђᥱ Fᥱᐯᥱ꒱!”

The words kept being screamed over and over again on an endless loop until the words seemed to finally penetrate through the matted and paling flesh. A monstrous cry of a wounded animal filled the air, pitch black tar oozed from the abused eyesockets that had been left by the fiery ashes. The black decay splattered to the ground, staining the white and grey with a murky and thick blackened mucus. The dripping never ceased, only piling and flooding the entirety of the realm. So much decay fell, with nowhere to go but up until the entire world was painted black. Filling up like a murky ocean of decay and death, encompassing everything and suffocating life until nothing remained but tar.

It had started with the grey walls. They had become an ocean of pitch black that ran as high as the creature's chest, rapidly wadding against its chest and ceasing all movements. The blackness was thick and suffocating, the tar was trapping its prey in a preservative liquid of shadow. Suddenly the entire world was eclipsed, everything was blacked out with no sign of light or color. A realm of complete and utter darkness.

It was too much to outrun, the fluids felt completely suffocating for the creature. Pale and milky hands with bloody crimson eyes reached from the depths pulling on the creature's lower extremities. False flesh tore and ripped as greedy hands played much too rough with the sensitive masses, that had been lazily stitched together by some faux feelings of completeness. All the seams were finally coming unrivaled, after so long the beast would finally be tamed. The hands mocked and whispered horrible things as they pulled harder, not caring if they had broken the creature's bodies somewhere along the way. The crimson eyes ripped layer after layer of flesh away until nothing but a barred soul remained. The soul was small, puny even, the whitish glow had long been dimmed and been tainted with grey and black tendrils holding it down so it could never properly escape.

Nothing dared to help and all the green eyes could do was water as soft sobs racked his unresponsive and numbed body. There was *no savior*. There were *no heroes* **here**. Only the fiery crimson eyes that were filled with unyielding hate and malice. Otherwise, he was alone, drowning here in his own **decayed** *state of mind*.

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(This happened During all the other events of this chapter, this happened a day after Izuku 'died' - Mid January)

The bare soul wept in its prison of darkness and torment. Nothing could be seen, but **darkness.** The darkness appeared to move on its own, alive. The shadow's consumed every stroke of color, stealing all pieces of light for their own. Just for them to lock it all away in a well-built and withering chest that would never be released ever again. The soul was left locked away in a prison of his own making, for who knows? He surely doesn't.

The soul cried harder in deafening silence, no longer able to vocalize words let alone sounds of any kind. Only silence echoed within the blackened prism, whispering voices that held no real meaning other than to be used to harm and maim the soul that dwelled within. A personal pandora's box, meant to cage a lonely soul who was no longer meant to exist in the outside world.

The decay started to fill the soul's lungs, forcing the liquid down his throat each time he opened his mouth to sob. The watery darkness was slowly drowning him, inside and out. Everything was black and cold. He tried to fight against the blackened currents, but nothing changed and soon he found he held no energy to resist, and simply let the shadows have their way with him. There was after all nothing he ***alone***, could do to get out of this damning box.

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(An Indefinite Amount Of Time Passes Once Again)

Long and narrowed fingers, crafted from the brightest light appeared like a beacon calling the boy back home. The light closed the long and harrowing distance, rapidly catching up to his frail and immobilized body that lie deep within the darkness.

The hands of light reached out to him, a hum of energy filled the area where the light touched. This sacred and beautiful light gave the lost soul the power to move once again, the process was almost immediate but with stiffened limbs, he felt extremely weakened. The energy buzzed and hummed, silently begging for the boy to reach just a little higher and take its offering hand. It only took a second for the soul to understand what the beautiful warmth wanted before he clasped the fingers of light. He held on with everything he was worth, every small bit of energy he could manage was used to keep himself afloat beside the light. They were finally reunited, he was finally being saved *after* ***so long***. The fingers made a thoughtful hum before they and the boy attached to them were hauled toward the invisible sky. Blindingly beautiful ashes of light followed after them, forever leaving a brightened trail behind them. If the soul were to ever get lost once again, hopefully, the lights would remind the boy that he is far from being alone. Maybe he'd finally learn that no matter where he went someone would always come find him all over again.

The hand of light reached the surface first, followed closely by the boy's body. He was gasping loudly, choking on the sudden influx of air reentering his drowned lungs. The tar oozed and cried out as it was forced out of every pore of the body. The blackness fled with haste from the body as if it were a plague. No longer was this a corrupted soul, but one that had somehow been returned. That of course angered the sludge, *how dare someone else reclaim their prize?* The shadowed tar crawled away, faster than any normal leech could, though the motions looked the same. Though

they didn't make it far before a beam of blinding light was brought down upon the tarry leeches. They evaporated in a matter of seconds. An angelic giggle followed with each 'pop' the tarry bits made. The soul's heartbeat was returned and he felt it thud in happily at the angelic sound.

The sudden overwhelming urge to cough consumed the soul, with one final cough and a loudened wet thump he instantly felt happiness explode within him. The last clump of tar was vomited out of the boy's mouth and he was *freed*. He was able to fully open his dulled eyes, they burned but were otherwise okay. Standing tall before him was an ambiguous creature made strictly from light, the voice that echoed from his savior even more so.

"You have been returned as promised." A melancholic voice sang to no one in particular, it wasn't looking at the boy when said, but rather somewhere far behind him. Though turning to look the boy saw no one. He had a sneaking suspicion that someone was there, however.

"Who are you?" His small broken voice painfully asked. His throat was still tender and raw from nearly drowning and the uncontrollable sobbing he'd partaken in earlier.

"Who are we?" The mysterious voice echoed. Suddenly it sounded as if it was multiple voices, undistinguishable creatures made and forced into a single body. No clear singular voice to truly recognize as the 'original,' but instead were many.

"Yes." He said breathlessly.

"We are ~~You~~ Cerberus, of course."

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(Two Weeks and 6 Days Since Izuku Has Been Missing - Early February)

The evening that night had been long and burdensome, the winds outside howling like feral beasts rampaging throughout the night. The cold chill of being the only soul in the apartment was driving Inko Midoriya to the brink. She was tired. *So tired*. Her heart ached and her body shook with every second that passed without knowing if her son was alright. If he was alone out there and frightened, especially on a night such as this. Izuku had never been one to enjoy thunderstorms and a bad experience with lightning when he was younger left him sometimes inconsolable on nights of such

turbulence. Not even Inko knew exactly what happened the night her boy had been lost out in the thunderstorm with Mitsuki's boy, both refused to talk about what did or didn't happen. In the end, despite their boy's negligence and resistance to sharing details of that night, all that mattered was that both boys had returned home safely and uninjured. Though both seemed to have gained a little more mental scarring if either mom had to guess.

This reason alone made more hot tears pool in her dimly lit emeralds. The cup of calming camomile tea in her hands had long gone lukewarm, shaking uncontrollably matching pace with Inko's own body. She was freezing, even in her 76-degree apartment, she couldn't feel the heat, her soul was frigid and shaking like a leaf. Inko knew that she promised to call Mitsuki when she had episodes like this, no matter the time of day or night, but she just couldn't put her heart into disturbing the already bone-tired best friend of hers. Neither parent had been blessed with much sleep since…' *the incident.* '

They didn't even have the courage to say *exactly* what happened. At the mere mention of it, both would break down all over again. They did everything they could to hang onto that last strand of hope to get them through this. No matter how impossible that seemed right now. Hope was a powerful thing and brought fruit to many a miracle. All they could do was hope that theirs too would soon bear a miracle of their own. Izuku would return home once again, just as he always did. They just had to have a little more faith.

So here Inko sat, thick 'All Might' shawl covering her shoulders, a familiar favorite of Izuku's and one that still vaguely smelled of her lost son. It was comforting and torturous, not being able to smell his strong scent of green apples and a hint of gardenia depending on the day around the apartment. The smell was long faded, just like his unmistakable presence everywhere else in their small apartment. The deafening silence of what had once been a place of pure happiness, an escape from all the sadnesses and hardships of her life, was now the ***bane*** *of her existence*. She ***hated*** this place. It no longer felt like home. It was a vacuous prison, filled with darkness and deception. On days she didn't think it possible to miss him more, nights like this would be thrown back in her face. She wanted nothing more than for her boy to be back in her arms, even if it was just for a moment.

A roar of thunder growled from far above the blackened skies and a loud crack of something metal breaking echoed throughout the quiet neighborhood below. Inko was snapped out of her thoughts, startled by the loud cries of creaking metal. She blinked a few times before standing up and walking over to the window she had previously been staring out blankly. The night was dark and dreary, mirroring her own feelings. Though despite how dark and menacing the storm outside seemed to rage, she didn't see anything out of the ordinary. Nothing had even caught her interest until a flash of pitch-black ran passed a dimly lit bench.

She blinked her tired eyes again in confusion but focused more on the sight before her. She didn't see anything else move sadly, however she now noticed that the street light closest to the one dimly lit bench had clattered to the ground sometime during the night. *It must've been what that screech had been previously*, she thought with slight worry. She was most concerned about the post having some astray or live wires now that it had crashed, but no sparks seemed to be flying from where she was watching. That was a good sign at least. She scratched the back of her head in puzzlement as another thought came to mind, *was this part of town so poorly built that a falling lamp post was a clear threat?*

She gave a displeased ' hmpf,' before she found her eyes searching the darkness for something else to happen. It never did, but she had a vague feeling that ***something*** was lurking around out there. It made her skin crawl with goosebumps, but she figured she was just being silly. *What could possibly be out there that was too dangerous in a heavily populated city like this?* The thought would have completely left her if not for a second crackling sound. The short woman nearly jumped out of her skin when a sudden flash of lightning crashed against the fallen lamppost. Upon impact, it caused a flurry of small sparks and popping sounds for a few seconds before the burst of energy fled the metal.

Her heart was thumping dangerously hard against her chest, her breath came out short and rapid, and she felt an onset of dizziness. Without much thought, she threw a hand over her head and steadied herself against the sturdy ledge of the nearest windowsill. A minute later she was talking herself off the ledge and berating herself mentally for being such a scaredy cat. Here she'd gone and worked herself up like that over nothing. Right now she was more than happy that she hadn't called Mitsuki about this, she was embarrassed enough without the added teasing from her best friend. Of course, Mitsuki would've been worried at first, but then there'd be endless teasing that followed once the woman realized that Inko was okay after all.

"Seriously Inko for the love of god what is wrong with you" She mumbled breathlessly, hand still over her heart. She was sure if she stopped holding it now it might just shoot out with how fast it was beating against her ribcage.

"Well, I think that's quite enough snooping for one night." She whispered finally regaining control over her frantic scaredy-cat of a heart. It was a traitor that she swore was gonna drive her into an early grave if it kept up.

Inko waddled back to her awaiting comfort chair on unsteady legs, slower than she normally would because of her dizziness spell. As she crossed the room to the chair she adjusted the small shawl over her shoulders, holding the ends closer over her chest as she nervously thumbed at the fraying material. It was a nervous tick of hers, one she'd recently picked up in the absence of her son.

It wasn't great, but it was better than her coping methods of overeating. Something she always fell back on when she was overwhelmed with too much stress and guilt. a habit that remained long from the past. Izuku had argued with her about this bad habit many a time and even if he wasn't here to see that promise through, she'd keep up her end of the bargain. If Izuku cared about her health so much, the least she could do was hold to it and do her best to care about her health as much as he did.

Some time passed and the skies outside were even darker now, it had to be around 3 A.M. or close to it. After her mild panic attack, Inko must've passed out in the aftermath of her exhaustion. At least she had guessed as much anyway. She probably would've slept through the whole night if a raucous hadn't startled her from her deep sleep. The familiar sound of the front door being slammed open with such an intense force, caused Inko to get up in a hurry despite still being half-asleep as it could only mean one thing, Mitsuki. Any time burst down her door at some ungodly hour, it had to be something related to Izuku, maybe even some news. She'd never bang the door open with such force in the middle of the night otherwise, yet alone even be awake at this hour. The blondes of the Bakugou household always had a very specific sleep schedule and nothing could interrupt it unless they expected literal hell to pay.

In her haste to rush to the blonde's side for an update, Inko stumbled, getting caught up in the 'All Might' shawl and flat-out missing her pink kitten slippers. With a loud thump, she fell to the floor in a tumbled mess of blankets and misplaced shoes. Very un-Inko-like, she cursed under her breath for being so foolish once again. She couldn't see the door from where she was seated on the ground, but she could clearly hear the fierce throaty growl that came from a few feet in front of her. Not completely in her right mind Inko took it in stride and asked about it instead of logically assessing the situation.

"Mitsuki did you guys get a dog or did the officers come with you this time? Was there any news?"

Inko paused when she didn't get any response, puzzled at the silence from the normally obnoxiously loud blonde, just made her fear the nature of the news even more. *It must be bad news. Oh god, how bad?"* Inko's mind started to race and all the negative thoughts tore through her mind, flooding to the surface all at once. Finally pulling her feet free from the last of the blanket Inko sighed in relief, properly throwing on her slippers this time. With a mildly embarrassed huff, she retied the silken robes that had come unknotted in her fall.

A series of pops and cracks filled her senses, they were almost silent, but now being hyper-aware Inko noticed right away and froze. *What are those noises? They sound painful...* She thought to herself, furrowing her brows.

“Mitsuki? What are you doing?” She asked suddenly unsure and a bit nervous, what if she ***had*** been wrong and it wasn’t her best friend in her house? *Oh god, it could be a house invader! OH GOD OR WORSE! A murderer or a villain oh gods,* she started to shake more violently than before.

The only answer she got was a masculine grunt. That sound alone brought all her fears to light. She gulped and hesitantly looked up towards the door. It was wide open, the wind was howling as it whipped in and out as the rain thunderously splattered against the now exposed linoleum. Looking to her left she found a medium-sized statue of All Might on the top shelf of the bookcase, she used her quirk to float it to her sweaty palms. Thankfully it had some weight to it, arming herself with at least something to slam over the intruder’s head if necessary. It was at this moment she wished that she had listened to Izuku and gotten that hello kitty baseball back so many months ago. *How could she have been so naive? So foolish and why didn't she listen?*

With shaking shoulders, sweaty palms, and an unsteady heart she quietly snuck towards the door. She left it open for a possible escape route and was fully prepared to just leave and walk over to the Bakugou residence to use their phone and call it in, but curiosity got the better of her. All the lights were off, but she could clearly make out the dark silhouette of a figure in her bathroom. They seemed to be doing something in the mirror, maybe the cabinet under it, but she couldn’t tell exactly what. It was too dark and she already had rather unimpressive vision as it was.

She looked between the figure and the open door, she gulped indecisively. The deciding factor was when the figure seemed to bend over and start reaching into the cabinet under the sink. With the intruder bent over like this, she could easily hit them and potentially knock them unconscious until the pros or police got here. Not her *best* solution, but quietly she crept up on the figure, holding the statue high behind her as she prepared a potent attack. The figure grunted again sounding displeased with whatever was in its hand.

With a deep breath, Inko swung the statue with all her strength and hoped to god, that All Might gave her enough strength to wound this guy. The statue shattered on impact with the back of the intruder's head, he grumbled but otherwise seemed completely unfazed. Inko gasped and screamed bloody murder at the top of her lungs. The figure stood up immediately and reached toward Inko with urgency, at least that’s what she had thought. She flinched and readied herself for her imminent death, only to realize that the figure was reaching for the light switch behind her.

“Jesus Mom what was that for?” The voice grumbled, it was deeper and sounded wilder than before but was still undeniably familiar.

Hesitantly she opened her eyes again at the intruder's words, her heart stopping when her viridian eyes met the same eyes looking back at her. She blinked owlishly up at her son. *Her missing son.* He had been *missing for two weeks*, *almost three weeks*, but somehow he was ***here***. *Right now*. The words completely escaped her and her bottom lip quivered as tears blurred her vision. The entire universe seemed to stop at that moment.

“O-oh my god Izuku.” She cried, throwing herself into his arms right away.

The boy made an ‘oof’ sound as the short woman nearly plowed him over, he was stiff for a second before he awkwardly returned the hug. It went on for longer than he’d currently like, but he sucked up the awkwardness for another moment before hesitantly pushing her off of him. Inko noticed and immediately a look of hurt filled her features. Izuku felt *horrible*, but he couldn’t very well hug his mother so intimately right now when he was covered in nothing but filth. He scratched the back of his neck awkwardly and attempted to hide his naked self behind the cabinet door. He offered an awkward cough before he continued.

“Oof, it’s good to see you too Mom, eh besides the sudden All Might to the head that is.” He chuckled. Inko blinked at the change of octaves in her son’s voice, it was so strange to hear his words from a much deeper voice. *When did that happen? Had it really been that long since she'd heard his voice?*

Suddenly Inko understood his words and was filled with horrible dread, knowing she’d tried to beat her son to death cause she was being paranoid. The petite woman then allowed her eyes to roam over her boy, actively searching for wounds. She froze halfway through, she noticed now that her son was apparently topless, and judging by how carefully he was angling himself behind the cabinet door he was completely naked.

She suddenly felt just as awkward as understanding entered her features. He wasn’t rejecting her affections without reason, that *soothed* her heart. Just for it to jumpstart again when she really took

in her boy's features. A loud gasp left her lips, Izuku wasn't just naked but the entirety of his torso was covered in a deep crimson. It looked like it had been a liquid of some kind but had dried. She tried to think of what it was until realization struck her right in the gut, **blood**. That was *clearly* ***dried blood***.

Why was her son covered so thoroughly in dried blood? She started to panic all over again.

"Oh my god, Izuku are you hurt? Where? That's so much you must have a terri-" Inko started firing off in a panic, but Izuku held a hand up to silence her before she could fully go haywire.

"Don't worry about it mom, I'm not hurt, and um it's ***not mine.***" Izuku sighed, he looked down at his covered chest with a faraway look before adding "At least I don't think it is."

Inko let his words sink in and the implantation that came with them. She felt her throat tighten as a frog formed in it. This was all so much to take in, **her son was home**, **safe** and well *covered in blood*, but it was **okay** *it wasn't his…*She didn't know what to think and her brain temporarily went into shutdown mode. Izuku must've noticed because he gave an apologetic look before a deep sigh escaped him.

"Izuku…D-did someone h-hurt you? Did you h-have to defend y-yourself? ~~Izuku did you kill someone~~…?" Inko whispered, ignoring the question that kept filling her every thought. *'Izuku did you kill someone?'* He looked down, then over at his reflection in the mirror, then back to her.

"I-" He wasn't sure how to answer her question and instead deflected it, for the time being, he needed a few minutes to recollect himself and these scattered thoughts rampaging within him. "Mom why don't you go sit down while I get properly dressed and cleaned up."

"Izuku-" Inko had so many questions, even more than she did a minute again. Izuku's answer did little to secure her mind. He gave her a shake of the head, signifying he wasn't ready to talk just yet. She understood, turning around she started for her chair, though she stopped holding the edge of the bathroom door in her fingers. She gave Izuku a sincere look and a nod before adding "I love you and I am glad you are home Izuku."

“Thanks, Mom, I love you too.” Izuku gave her a small sad smile before Inko shut the door behind her. At the click of the door, he nearly crumbled to the floor.

He gave another deep sigh before looking back at the daunting reflection across from him. To put it mildly, he looked like **a serial killer**, he had dried blood covering his entire torso, his hands up to the elbow, and splattered across his legs and feet. He felt disgustingly crusty. Looking at his own eyes he felt an unwanted chill overcome him, his eyes looked the same as ever, though they suddenly looked much sharper than before. Ridgid and filled with a sudden lack of empathy. They had a certain feral edge to them and that was rather concerning. He looked like a damned madman. Even felt like one with his itchy and irritating skin as well. He couldn't stop scratching at himself like a feral cat covered in fleas. It was really *pissing* him off.

Though what bothered him the most about his own reflection **was**…*he couldn’t even recognize himself*. He had never loved his appearance and also thought himself rather dull, but he’d felt comfortable enough in his own skin. Now, however, *he felt as if someone else had taken over his skin*. It all felt so **wrong** and he couldn’t understand why he felt that way.

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Izuku decided it best to stop fussing over the version of him present in the mirror. Mirrors were natural liars anyway, who's to say he wasn't being tricked right now as well? He walked over to the shower, started it, and set it to the hottest temperature. He figured the hotter the faster the grime would slip off, not to mention he'd always been bedazzled by refreshing hot showers. They had always eased the stress and erased high-strung nerves in his shoulders and back. Though *once* he stepped in, the heat bubbled across his skin as the horrid feeling of his body burning alive exploded across every plane. His reaction was quick, he hissed and flipped the cursed thing to the furthest cold setting.

A growl of approval replaced his annoyed hissing as the frigidness encompassed him. Steam poured off of him as the coldness collided with inhuman body heat. It was surprising to see that reaction, but he honestly didn’t care, he was gonna enjoy the shit out of this deep scrubbing. He hadn’t had a bath in who knows how long and the mere thought had his skin crawling again.

While he was deep in his obsessive deep cleansing, Inko slipped a change of fresh clothes at the door. She gave the shut door a loud knock, as she figured over the shower it'd be hard for him to hear her. However, the sound of a head colliding with the shower in surprise followed by a whimper that sounded like it came from a pained animal, caught her attention. She furrowed her brow at it, *where could it have come from? Izuku? But how can that be?* This sound was distinctly animal, not human.

“Izuku I put a change of fresh clothes here for you when you finish up Honey,” Inko called after she knocked. It took a second for her son to respond and when he did, it sounded pained.

“Mm t-thanks mom.”

His answer was curt and cracked, something else very unlike her son. He had always been one to overshare and drag normal sentences out in a paragraph style. She chalked it up to him being exhausted and possibly traumatized from everything that could've happened since he'd been gone. She'd of course ask him about it...but she wasn't sure if that was a conversation for tonight or a week from tonight...

“Of course. Let me know if you need anything else.” Inko sighed, was she being too hypersensitive about everything? That didn’t seem that abnormal, but in this case, she felt that her gut was right and that there was indeed something strange afoot here. Only time would tell she sighed. It had only been an hour so far, maybe he was just out of it still. He would need a few days to readjust to being back home she figured. She just hoped she was right and all this was temporary...

Izuku winced as he held his head in his hand, he had been fine, enjoying his freezing shower even. *What happened for him to suddenly be in such a sorry state?* It had all started with the loud shout from his mother behind the door, the words had been so ***loud*** he thought he might cry out. The mere rise in her voice was almost too much to bear and now here he was doing his best to stave off the splitting headache caused by the change in pitch.

Everything was so *very loud*, even the soft thumps of water drops rolling off his hips were rendering him to a near fetal position. The steady beats of his mother’s heartbeat in the other room, the slight sniffle she made, and the constant sound of a crimson ocean flowing throughout each of her veiny rivers. The nearly deafening honk of a car from two blocks down, the crash of thunder roaring high above the clouds, plummeting rain as it exploded across sidewalks alike, the ticking of a nearby All Might clock to his left, and the steady snoring coming from the houses next door. Each octave is more different than the last, but equally as **paralyzing**. A snapping of a tree as it was hit with a bolt of lightning was what caused him to fully cry out. The crackle of electricity caused all the waterworks, him to bite his lip a bit too aggressively and his head to rattle. Though before the thrilling shriek could leave the bathroom he threw a hand into his mouth, biting down as the scream was soundlessly swallowed whole. The tears rolled down his cheek endlessly, his body shook worse than all the times he'd been hit at school. *He felt hollow*.

The electric sizzling sound of hot blood flowing into his mouth was the next sound he heard. Bloody droplets fell with little resistance in the clear water below, giving it a freshly pink tint. The sound of the droplets falling was numbed and blended into the steady stream of water, the sound still there but no longer as distracting as before. Instead, the scent of warm and copper blood short-circuited his senses. The scent of his own blood was **disgusting**.

A deep sigh rumbled from the teen's chest as he breathed in and out, using breathing techniques he had learned so many times before from the doctor to help with his panic attacks. He closed his eyes and leaned his forehead against the side of the shower, letting the cold water wash over and soothe him. Soon he fell into a pattern and without even noticing the sounds around him quieted. They still existed if he looked, but they weren't completely overpowering his senses anymore. Now they were as normal to him as the sound of his own thumping heart. The world was quieter, more bearable now. At least for the time being, who's to say this moment of solace would last long?

It was absurd and unexplainable, but more than anything it had ***hurt***. With each sweltering sound, he thought his eardrums would burst if the pressure lasted a second longer. If they had, he knew blood would gush from his ears in a bloody waterfall of brain rot. It was a horrendous visual image and made him cringe hard even thinking it up. His eyes twitched under his lids at the imagery and he gave a light shake of the head to clear away the bothering thoughts. *He really didn't feel like himself*. He just hoped no one else noticed how strange and out of pattern his behavior would undoubtedly be.

It took five minutes for Izuku to completely refocus himself. He was able to center the pain, hence limiting it. He found that by strictly focusing on a single sound instead of an ocean of other distracting sounds he could breathe again. It worked with much more ease than he thought. The action of blocking out certain sounds and strictly focusing on a select few was surprisingly second nature, the transition incredibly smooth. It was as if a switch had been flipped and he'd been born with this little quirk about himself. It came out of nowhere, yet surprisingly felt like *home*.

He was annoyed he hadn't thought to try that before, but then relaxed when he reminded himself that now he knew better and had made a learning experience from the whole ordeal. With that line of thought, he felt a little proud, accomplished, and a bit excited to further explore the possibility of what this meant in the future. *Had this been the quirk he'd waited his entire life for?* One of his own creation, the one that strictly belonged to him after he'd suffered for so long without one by his side? He didn't think as much, but a small part of him couldn't help but feel giddy with the possibility.

Ten minutes later and Izuku thought he'd scruffed his skin aggressively enough for one night. Turning off the running water and stepping out on the bathmat he did a mental assessment of

himself, taking notice that his skin still felt oddly tingly and uncomfortable. Too tired to care about it more he toweled himself as slowly as he could. He was excited to see his mom again, even if it had only been a few hours, maybe a day, he really wasn't sure how much time had passed. But it couldn't have been very long he summarised, though her desperate reaction to him was a bit unusual. What Izuku neglected to notice doing his brief once over, was the scarred bite mark covering the entirety of his left thigh. It looked long faded, nearly hidden against the skin, but still an undeniable mark of his misadventure.

The thought of having to talk to his mom about all these scattered and fragmented thoughts didn't sound all that appealing to him, but Izuku wasn't a natural-born liar, never had been. But maybe that was bound to change over time, maybe lying came to him more naturally than he previously thought. However, he could be quite the omitter of the truth and did so smoothly. Though those were a bunch of half-truths, they were more manageable than a bunch of straight-up lies to someone's face. So with that in mind, he was very much not looking forward to Inko's insistence on mothering everything she could get outta him.

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Realizing he couldn't very well stay hidden in the bathroom for the rest of his life, Izuku with resistance left the safety of the bathroom. He felt thankful that Inko had brought him one of his shorter pairs of gym shorts and his favorite pajama shirt that read 'Nightshirt.' His sense of fashion had always been poor and ill-humored, but he liked them and they were very comfortable. He'd rather look questionable and feel comfortable than look like a fancy circus monkey that felt gaudy and cramped up. *But* no one else seemed to understand his stance on the whole thing and would just rather tease him about his ridiculous wardrobe. Well, they could think what they wanted about him because at the end of the day, all Izuku cared about was feeling comfortable.

Inko was wide awake, staring blankly at the tv in front of her. She'd been listening to the constant thrum of the flowing water, calming herself down and reminding her brain that this was *real* and that she *wasn't* dreaming. Her son *really* had **returned** this time. It wasn't another of her hellish nightmares tonight, it was the real deal, equally as *horrifying* but **regardless** she was on cloud nine. Now that the soft sounds of the shower no longer kept her company, her nerves were fraying as anxiety ate her up.

She was nervous, but also incredibly excited and immensely relieved, but all fearful. Not for her life, but for her son. The one that may have accidentally…or intentionally killed someone within the two weeks he had vanished. *How would she be able to hide him if he was wanted now? How could she ever hope to protect him if everyone else already knew?* Or if he'd left any sort of evidence at whatever crime *scene* that there might be…She was a worrying mess and she knew it. ***IT*** was still too soon to think of all this right now, she reprehended herself for losing her thoughts to the hysteria. Her uncontrollable spiraling was not going to be of any help, right now she needed

to *remain calm* and get some proper **answers**. After achieving that step she could then plot their next actions accordingly. *No matter what those may be…*

Izuku followed the floral scent of birch and a calming cashmere. He figured white gardenia was in there somewhere too. It was an incredibly pleasant scent, strictly warm and welcoming, very fitting for his sweet-hearted mother. He found this to be the first scent that didn't cause him to instantly recoil and gag upon first introductions. That was a bit gratifying, knowing that beautifully comforting scents existed too. Not just the horrid smells he now associated with death and excruciating pain. He ignored the concerning voice at the back of his head that reminded him that he liked the smell of fresh blood... but we don't talk about that.

A happy sign of contentment left him as he took in a deep inhale of the scents in the apartment. He could pick up a second floral scent deeply rooted within the fiber of the apartment. This one was more crisp and fresh smelling than the warm, white gardenia he recognized. This scent had a hint of freshly churned vanilla and a more potent musk-like scent of what had to be spruce, he smelt some green apple in there too. He guessed that had to be his own scent, even though he couldn't previously pick up any kind of scent of his own. He admittedly has tried an insane amount of times, just to come up empty-handed each time.

The teen plopped down onto the silken beige couch that was parallel to where Inko was seated, with little grace. Exhaustion seemed to creep up on both of them, but both mother and son knew now was not the right time for sleep. Talking about everything was obviously much more urgent than a little sleep deprivation. Inko watched Izuku's every movement, every subtle twitch, every breath, searching for something, though she wasn't exactly sure what. The boy noticed right away with each quick once-over she made but made zero attempts to start the much-needed conversation. After twenty minutes of silence, he sighed and bit the bullet, as it'd probably be best for him to go first anyway. He'd start out with something less serious first, then maybe get into the darker stuff floating around in his mind.

"Mom when did you pay for more hot water? It was so scalding hot that I thought I was going to burn up." Izuku asked, he wanted to start this thing off, but the light conversation seemed more desirable for now. Though with how Inko's face scrunched up in confusion Izuku thought maybe he said the wrong thing already.

"Honey I haven't, you know we don't have enough money to do that." She said, clear confusion in her tone. "Izuku are you sick? Maybe you have a fever?

A lightbulb seemed to go off in her head and she suddenly stood up and stopped right in front of her son. She raised a hand and placed it on his forehead. It took a second but she hissed in surprise and retracted her hand, her viridian eyes as wide as saucers and filled with worry. Izuku looked up at her, his own face scrunching up in confusion. Sure he felt hot but he didn't feel sick at all. He raised his own hand up to check the temperature, his reaction was much duller than hers. He didn't even flinch at the intense heat radiating off his forehead, it felt warm sure but nothing out of the ordinary. Or so he thought at least.

"Uh, what are you talking about mom? I don't feel hot at all and I don't feel sick at all."

"You can't feel how scorching your skin is? Are you sure you don't feel sick? Nausea? Any pain?" She kept asking questions right after the other in her typical mother-hen fashion. Izuku knowing it was best in these times to just raise a hand up and silence her, did just that. She blinked at him owlishly but stopped midsentence regardless.

"Mom please calm down, I swear I feel fine. I'm tired, like *really* tired but ***I'm not sick*** I promise. Please don't worry about me." He said quickly, hoping his words would be enough to placate her for the time being. He wasn't lying when he said he felt utterly exhausted, it felt as if his soul had been squeezed out of him in all honesty.

"Well…If you are sure. I trust you, you know your body better than me after all. If you suddenly start to feel sick or need help please tell me right away." She sighed, her eyes looking over him one more time before falling to the ground in defeat. She was concerned but she knew if he really was sick he'd look a lot more pale and sickly right now. He looked completely healthy, besides some intense bags under his eyes. Sleep would likely clear that up by morning though.

"I promise you'll be the first to know if something is wrong." He gave her a tired, but sincere smile nonetheless. She returned it with a small worried one of her own and a gentle silence surrounded them. Neither one wanted to break the moment and bring up the giant elephant in the room just yet.

The silence didn't last long before Inko decided to take the reins this time around. She didn't want to beat around the bush and just wanted to hug him close and never let him go ever again, but she

held back. There'd be time later she promised her insistent instincts. Instead of treading on the potentially sensitive and dark topic, she started with something she hoped was a bit more simple to answer. And a topic that wouldn't have her left melted on the floor in a bundle of static nerves by the end of it.

"Izuku I know you just got home after so long…but I need to ask you a few things. You've been missing for two weeks, almost three, and no one…" Inko tried, but halfway through the first sentence and she already had a vengeful frog in her throat, causing her voice to waver with each word.

"No one could find you…we were begging to think the worst…that you m-might be…" She trailed off, not having it in her to say *that* word. Izuku's eyes widened and his blood froze colder with each word leaving his mother's mouth. **He felt paralyzed.**

"T-two weeks?" He asked hesitantly, his voice ragged and his heart ripping at his insides in its attempt to flee.

Inko who had been looking down at her crossed hands and the floor, finally rose her head, tears freely filling her eyes. She looked **broken**. Izuku's heart nearly stopped beating at the devastated expression on her face. He hated to hurt *anyone*. *But* to hurt *her* made him utterly ***sick*** to his stomach. He felt the sudden lurch of his insides and had to fight off the urge to vomit with all his might. He felt **disgusted**. **Sickened.** He had forced two weeks of loneliness and of pain on his mother. She must've been worried to death about his whereabouts and sudden disappearance act. Not to mention all the other people who cared about him. The air felt suffocating and his heart felt too heavy for his chest.

"I-I had no idea…two weeks…oh my god." He whispered, aggressively pulling at his dark green curls like a maniac.

He had lost ~~two~~ three weeks of his life, doing god knows what in some place he couldn't *even* remember. *What in the actual hell had happened to him? Had he been drugged and kidnapped?* He had no idea. Anything could've happened to him and he wouldn't even be aware of it... He'd never even remember it let alone the faces of any potential kidnappers. The blood…there had been so

much blood covering his body, the blood he knew wasn't his own. Maybe some of it, but most of it was definitely **not** from his own body and that worried him much *more* than anything else.

*Had he **killed** ~~someone~~ **something?** Or worse **someone**? Was it for self-defense? Or strictly for pleasure? And if he had…**why?***

*Why would he do such a horrible thing…How could he **even** be **capable** of **ending** something's life? How would he **ever** live with himself if he found out he **had**?* The torrent of anguish and fear consumed him as all the worse possibilities washed over him like a silent and all-consuming ocean. He couldn't stop the thoughts, the inner demons voices were just too *strong*. He was *drowning* in an ocean of his own making.

"Izuku?" Inko suddenly asked as a warm hand landed on his shoulder rubbing soothing circles along his shoulder blade. He'd never felt so undeserving of his mother's love...If he had taken someone else's mother...he...he wouldn't know what to do with himself...

"M-mom I-I don't know w-what happened and….and I m-might've killed s-someone." Izuku sobbed, his word just flowing with the burst of emotions overcoming him.

Traitorous tears fell from his eyes, landing with a soft 'splash' on his bare knees. The scent of burning salt and moisture filled his nostrils, causing even more tears to fall. Inko's heart buckled and she pulled her son as far into her lap as she could, cradling him as he came back to her again. She ran her hands through his curly mess of hair with one hand, while the other rubbed thoughtful shapes on his back. His sobbing racked his whole body and hers as well, they stayed like this for an hour or so just holding and comforting each other. Both Midoriya's missed this form of intimacy. The Bakugou's had been a wonderful support system, but nothing felt as comforting as her own son's very much *alive* beating heart against her own. She had to remind herself a few times that he ***was*** in her arms and ***safe*** finally.

Maybe he wasn't okay and maybe she *wasn't* either, but she knew that they ***would*** be with time. They both were incredibly strong people and they ***weren't*** alone, they had each other no matter what this future looked like. It was heartbreaking to see her son so vulnerable, *so fragile*. She herself felt the same way and wanted nothing more than to sit there and sob into his arms as well. Cry about all the pain and loneliness she had been suffocating in for weeks, but she **didn't**. She couldn't serve as counsel for both of them if her dam of emotions burst forward too. She had to be

the unpenetrable wall right now, for both of them. But that didn't mean she wasn't crying just as hard as her son, or that she was holding him in an unbreakable death grip either.

"Izuku listen to me. If something happened…no matter what I ***will*** always love you. **Everything** is going to be *okay*, I promise. We'll figure this out together." Inko whispered calmly into his unruly hair. He gave a sniffled *'okay,'* but was still just as worked up as before.

"We won't rush this okay? So let's watch your favorite All Might movie for now. I can make us some hot cocoa too." Inko offered, stroking the small curls as she threaded them through each finger.

"W-with marshmallows?" The teen asked hesitantly, Inko had to strain to hear his soft whisper but gave a small nod before answering.

"Mhm, just for you I'll even add whipped cream and some sprinkles."

"T-that sounds nice." He whispered against her chest, she hummed in agreement, not in a hurry to get up just yet. Maybe in another minute or two.

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They were halfway into the second All Might movie and the third serving of hot chocolates when Izuku suddenly sat up, uncurling himself from Inko's side. He had a wild look in his eyes and Inko blinked up at him in surprise. He had calmed down more or less, they both had in the last few hours. Izuku gasped, before snapping his eyes to meet Inko's. In the darkness of the room, his eyes seemed to abnormally glow, glistening from the light of the moon encompassing his normally emerald eyes into a brightening seafoam. It was beautiful, if not for a little startlingly to see. The boy looked possessed with a stern look of determination that came with a look of clarity.

Inko was intrigued about what had been running through her son's head for a while now, as his quiet mumbling was obvious from their close proximity. She let him work through his own thoughts first before he shared. He took a deep breath and Inko turned away from the tv hitting pause as she did, as her son deserved her full attention.

"I remembered. *Well,* bits and pieces." He elaborated, rubbing the back of his neck nervously. Inko held her breath in anticipation of what his next words would be. He froze after that.

"And? Did you see anything?" Inko prompted after a minute of silence. His dark eyebrows knitted together, as the cogs in his brain seemed to look for the proper words.

"And, I didn't kill someone. At least I don't think I did. I think it was from a water deer." He closed his eyes and blew out an unsteady breath. Inko gave one of her own in relief." I- I think she was pregnant too..."

"I'm sorry Izuku. I know how hard that must be on you. I'm glad it wasn't a person, but I know how much even killing fly tears you up." The short woman sighed, reaching out to clamp a supportive hand on her son. He just sadly nodded, looking very intently at his hands. A clear snarl of disgust on his lips as he did such, it was obvious how much he blamed himself. He looked as if he might cut his own hands off to erase the memory, Inko's brows knitted in a pained motion.

"I don't **feel** *guilty* and that *upsets* me even more ma. I can't remember much other than intense feelings of fulfillment as I watched that poor creature take its last breath. I don't even know how or why I did it either. It's like I wasn't *even* ***myself*** mom." He whispered as a single tear rolled down his face, disappointed in himself and his actions. Inko whimpered at the sadness radiating off her boy.

Inko gave him a sad smile, she knew what he meant, never in a million years would she have thought her son to have a sadistic side to him. It was a little *frightening*, but she was sure it must've been a random fluke and wouldn't happen ***again*** so she didn't dwell on it for long.

“Well, Izuku it was a one-time thing, a *fluke* caused by a moment of hunger or weakness. You **aren’t** a *monster* because you harmed an animal for once in your life.”

“I-I I want to believe that mom I really do, but I have a feeling it wasn’t the *only* one and won’t be the *last* time either. I don’t know how to describe it, but I feel *different*. I feel changed and that completely **terrifies** me. *What if I really am a monster?*” He confessed, his hands were beginning to shake again but he wasn’t crying, he just looked conflicted.

“That- If that’s true then we’ll handle that when we cross that bridge, ***until*** then we can’t dwell on the past. We have to look towards the *future* and learn together, how to face each hurdle. Okay?” She offered with a stern, yet caring voice.

She left no room for his qualms, but that was exactly what he needed. She was right, after all, no use dwelling on a past he can’t prevent or change. But rather a *future* he can ***change*** and *better* for himself and everyone else. He’d be a selfish asshole if he let this break him down when so many other people *needed* him.

“You’re right. Of course, you’re right, you’re my mom after all.” He quietly teased, giving her a slightly more normalized sunshine smile, though it still wasn't as bright it was more sincere than any previously. A good sign.

“Yes, so you should always remember that.” She grinned making a ‘champion’ gesture with her fist.

“I'll keep that in mind. But regardless…I want to make a grave for them. I can’t change what I did, but I can at *least* **remember** the life I *stole*.” Izuku declared, his voice becoming less shaky and more confident again and Inko felt proud.

“I think that’s a very good idea.” She smiled. Izuku nodded before a warm feeling returned to his eyes, with it the unnatural glow seemed to fade back to pure emerald.

Her heart swelled with *pride*, her little boy was growing up into a *good* man. A damned *good* man and she was one of the biggest reasons for it. That brought bittersweet tears to her eyes. She was happy and overfilled with pride that she'd raised him well, but with it came a great sadness, with how quickly time had gotten away from her. It was just *yesterday* he was a little four-year-old that she’d play cops and robbers with. ***It hurt***, *but in the best kind of way. They really had made it so far.*

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Shortly after Izuku’s declaration, the mother and son duo fell asleep on the couch watching All Might movies. They woke up the next day still in a cuddled heap of limbs and old All Might-themed blankets. Surprisingly Izuku was the first to wake up. He had never *once* in his life been a morning person, let alone a fully functioning person so early in the morning, but today he felt ***different***. He felt *energized* as if he had drunk a dozen black coffees. That was really saying something, as it only took one cup to have him bouncing off the walls like the energizer bunny in all those pre-quirk commercials on tv.

Without even a single cup and he was already up and feeling like getting a kick start on the day. It was strange and made his stomach tangled in knots with nervous excitement, but he wasn’t about to waste any more *time* than he had already ***missed***. *Two, almost three weeks* had been a **long** time. He couldn’t even imagine how much homework he’d have to make up or how many lectures he would get from officers, teachers, and neighbors. The list went on. He didn’t have an explanation for his disappearance, nor a real clue of what he had been doing for the last few weeks. No doubt many people would *not* be happy about that, especially those in the reporting unit. Maybe he was suffering from short-term amnesia? That didn't seem right wither though.

He wasn’t looking forward to that *snowball* of a situation, he wasn’t *even* sure how he was supposed to tell them his mind was ***blank***, *besides* a very vivid image of him shredding an unsuspecting water deer. That imagery still *haunted* him. How he didn’t have nightmares about it last night he didn’t know. He figured his mother’s warm and safe embrace around him mixed with her calming scent kept his demons at bay for a night or two. *Those images…those memories* would be sure to come back to him with a fury ***eventually***.

No longer wanting to think about it, Izuku shook the thoughts away, tucking the anthem in a metaphorical box in the back of his mind as he refocused on his current task. *Brushing his teeth*. He couldn't imagine how gnarly his breath must've been last night, as he had been too worked up to remember to do it last night and probably for *weeks*. Big yikes and hence his very aggressive brushing at the moment, five swigs of mouthwash, eight repeated brushings, and aggravating flossing later and he felt satisfied enough with the sparkling white teeth reflecting back at him. *Even if he couldn't control many other things in his life right now, at least he could control **this**.*

Looking at himself in the mirror like this gave him pause. He hadn't opened his mouth in his reflection last night, but now looking at it today he noticed his incisors on both the top and bottom rows seemed a little sharper than he remembered. It was a bit bizarre, but they didn't scream out abnormal nor did they look all that different, but he just felt that something had once again *changed*. It had taken him a whole twenty minutes of staring at them to realize it too. Maybe he was truly going ***insane***, because *why would something like this change without warning?* He shook it off as a **lack** of sleep.

Becoming a little hesitant to look at himself any longer in fear of finding something else abnormally different about his body, he wrapped his time in the bathroom up and returned to the main room. The scarred over bitemark went unnoticed once again. Soft snores from the lump on the couch let him know his mother was *still* deeply asleep, he wasn't about to wake her up either. She surely had had a rough time sleeping, that much he noticed. If she could sleep better now, all the more reason for her to replenish that loss of energy.

Instead of going back to bed himself, as he was virtually bouncing off the walls with energy, Izuku made his way into his room. He gave his room a look of longing as he realized he hadn't been in it for a long while. Everything was still the same of course, but he had a *new* appreciation of the quaint little room he had called **home** for so many years.

One change he noticed was that his newly singed hero notebook was laid out on his desk now. Looking at it brought back some unpleasant *thoughts* and *feelings*, but he didn't let it get to him. He had other things to put his attention on. Regardless he snatched up the notebook, unconsciously tracing the singed burn marks that littered the cover and the spine. He felt a great sadness at the state of his beloved journal, not necessarily for the recycled material, but rather for the hidden message the burns really meant.

The marks covering it were a clear sign of his current status with his childhood friend, or should he say, *ex-childhood friend*. **Kacchan** had made it painfully *clear* to the other teen that he wanted nothing to do with him anymore. Maybe he never did and Izuku had always been too blind to notice before. I mean basically telling him to just go ***kill himself*** sent a pretty *clear* message, one

Izuku would never have listened to in the past. But now looking at the sorry state of his journal, *a parallel to his life*, caused a few *feelings* to stir within him.

Maybe he really had been holding on to his first love for *too long*. Letting go would definitely be in both of their *best* interest after all. Things weren't going to change. Certainly not anytime soon and maybe *never*. He hadn't really understood the concept of *'giving up'* or moving on from someone he *loved* more than anyone else. But now he was beginning to understand what *all* those people had meant about the first love never being their *last*. He'd always scoffed at such claims, but something in him seemed to have snapped now. Maybe it was the red string that had connected the two teens together, or maybe it was simply Izuku himself. Izuku had held onto this string for so long that now just letting go seemed inconceivable, but he thought he had *no* other option. *Who was he to keep forcing something never meant to be?*

The feelings wouldn't fade overnight and probably not for a long time, but this was the first step in *letting go*. He'd given up on *so many* things in the past and allowed so many opportunities to escape him as he never felt worthy enough to stand up to a decision someone else had already made up. *Things* were going to *change* from now on. Izuku was going to ***change*** from now on. Honestly, it would probably be for the best anyway, he realized he was a doormat most of his life and a real *'yes man.'*

He never truly lived for *himself*, always to *please* others above *himself*, but maybe this time he would truly **live** for *himself*. **For** his mother that had worked so hard to get him where he was **today**, *alive, well-fed*, and *loved*. He'd ***live*** for *them*, *their happiness* and *he'd live* for all the people he was going to ***save*** one day. The world still ***needed*** him, just *not* with how he currently was. If he remained a *doormat* that *never* stood up for himself, *how would he ever have the capacity to* ***save*** *another?*

He had much to *atone* for, and would probably go on to make *more* mistakes, *even more*, ***unforgivable*** than the last, but he was going to do better. There in the middle of his room, Izuku Midoriya made a silent promise, one he would spend the *rest* of his life working towards. He'll more than likely *fail* some days and *win* others. No matter how *small* the win or how *great* the ***loss*** he was going to always do his best to *right* his wrongs. He couldn't <u>*promise perfection*</u>, but he could ***promise*** to always give it his all and follow in the steps he felt were *right*.

"Yeah. Mom was right, it really is going to be all okay. One day."

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Art For Part One: "Unravel"

Chapter Summary

Cover-style art I made with the beginning of the story in mind!

Because I am personally a very visually creative/inspired person I love using images to help tell my stories. I made some fan art the last few days to help keep me inspired and to help describe how my version of Izuku looks. You can visualize him as you wish obviously, but this is the image I use when writing and going forward. I hope guys like it as much as I do! This was literally my first time drawing both humans and fanart! Please be kind and gentle with me I am fragile haha.

This fanfic/story will fall into several parts, for example, plays that have 'part one/part two' etc. Part one of this fic is called *'Unravel.'* It will include the entirety of the interlude, which will be around 5-6 parts, and then will likely bleed over into part two around chapter 21. I already have the art/cover done for Part Two, but I figured I should wait to post that one. I'll be adding any art I make along the way relating to this fic as well, for example, I already have Izuku's 'scar chart' and his character sheet finished as well. Please let me know what you think and if you'd like to see more further along the line!


When
The
Moon
Starts
To
Fall

Prelude 03: The World Crumbles At Our Feet

Chapter Summary

Izuku notices a few obvious changes in himself, Inko tries to look the other way but ultimately realizes something is seriously wrong after a few incidents. Izuku meets someone from his past, though he doesn't know that just yet.

Chapter Notes

My Spotify list has drastically grown since I last shared it, so I'll be adding it here again! Link -> https://open.spotify.com/playlist/1HQJ4C2IfX5Ld5B8j5qJzO

I also added art relating to the '1st Part' of the series! This chapter came out very different than I had originally planned in the drafts, but I like it for the most part. Writing Mitsuki has been so much fun, she and Inko make my heart happy haha. Please be sure to leave your thoughts, theories ideas, likes or dislikes, etc anything in the comments! I love to hear everyone's ideas and may even find inspiration in your ideas! Plus it helps keep me motivated, as classes can be quite the downer sometimes and it helps me gauge if I am doing something right or wrong with this story! It's my first MHA fic so there are bound to be things about it that people love or hate, being quite a canon divergent can be a lot to take in as well! And the length oh man haha, but anyway thank you to everyone that takes the time to read my work or show any interest in the story, I really love it and have so many plans moving forward!

~Warnings~

This chapter contains violence and violent scenes of animal death that could be upsetting, body horror, cussing, dark themes, and inaccurate medical reports hehe.

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Prelude 03: *" The World Crumbles At Our Feet "*

Part 4 of 'The World In Which We Live'

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(Early February)

By some miracle or perhaps a curse of sorts, Izuku Midoriya came home from being missing for two, nearly three weeks. He somehow survived a vicious and ravenous wolf attack entirely undamaged, though he had no recollection of that tidbit. He might have had a minor case of amnesia, likely caused by intense trauma sustained to both body and mind.

Just hours prior to returning home, the boy was sure he had died and been eaten by some abnormally sized wolf hiding out in the woods. *Woods*, he now couldn't for the ***life*** of him remember where they were located. The world outside was just as blurry as the world inside his head. He felt hypnotized and in a stagnant daze. Nothing seemed to make *much* sense to him, *not* his mother's words, *not* his own, and certainly *not* how fucking *fantastic* his body felt. The best part about it, he *wasn't* even being sarcastic, he seriously felt as if he was soaring high above on some cloud nine.

Walking around his own house, the one he'd lived in with his mother for the majority of his life, felt *strange* and *new*, *unfamiliar* even. It was ***home***, he knew as much, but something felt so ***off*** about it. He felt *off*. After what could've easily been hours of just blankly staring at the singed notebook in his palms he figured he should actually do something. He opened to a blank page, the notebook groaned at the sudden invasion. Seeing as it had been a long while since he had the luxury to truly use it. Izuku sighed biting his cheek in hopes he'd calm down a bit, he felt high-strung and *disconnected* from ***everything***.

Maybe a little doodling would give him something to recenter himself, get a reign on his inner turmoil. He wasn't sure what he wanted to draw and sat staring at the lifeless pages for a few minutes. He scratched his pencil against the page a few times, just to erase the uneven and unsightly lines he'd made each time. The act of using his hands felt strange, *foreign* as if he hadn't used them in who knows *how long*. It took him back to the memories of when he was learning to write for the first time, but only in a passing moment. He really didn't need to be thinking about Kacchan anymore than a normal person and a trip down memory lane wouldn't do him any real good. It would probably only bring more bad luck into his life if he were honest. Kacchan was *far* too *distracting* for his own good. He definitely needed to *reevaluate* his center of focus all of the time. Obviously, an explosive blonde's carmine eyes had to be off the table now.

It took a little longer to feel comfortable in his craft again but soon an idea struck him. He had promised himself, even going as far as to declare to his mother that he would take the burden of

what he'd done very seriously and that he'd properly grieve the lost life. No better place to start than with burial preparations. A few ideas flashed through his mind, as he lazily sketched them each time one appeared until one caught his eye.

It was rather plain, pretty *mediocre*, but he felt it was oddly sentimental with just enough care given to it. It was a bare tombstone, similar to what'd you see in someone's backyard to remember a family pet. What made it stand out as more personal was the small neatly drawn greenery wreath laid over the top. The floral greens were all common plants and flowers one would see in a nearby park, or forest, with the exception of the white lily of the valley placed in the center.

Lilies of the valley, a flower whose meaning was as beautiful as they were sad. Their meanings varied but always lead back to two things. **Hope** for a new life and an **apology** for what could've been. These flowers symbolized 'rebirth' and 'forgiveness,' two things Izuku hoped would find the lost creature and guide them back to somewhere better. He still felt rather guilty about not being capable of crying as much as he thought he would for doing such a horrible deed, but his eyes remained dry. Maybe his humanity was finally catching up to him and withering up along with everything else in his life. Maybe he really was becoming numb. Desensitized to everything that happened inside and outside of his vision. It was an awful thought. Losing his sense of humanity and lack of a better word, *empathy*.

Looking down at his design once again, Izuku felt proud of the drawing and hoped Inko liked it as much as he did. He'd go buy the materials as soon as he could and start with finding a good final resting place for the stoney column. It is not as if he truly had anything to physically bury, but he wanted to do right by himself. Maybe it was selfish, *but when had Izuku Midoriya ever truly been selfish?* Until then he'd start working on making up for all the lost time he'd missed. He did after all have a lot of amends to make up in the coming days.

He could start by cooking his mother breakfast. He was sure that she had lost weight since his absence, he'd noticed as much the night before. That wasn't the worst thing in the world, as it would no doubt be better for her health. However, the reason behind it was traumatic and could cause feelings of anguish later down the line and that alone was enough to pull Izuku into overprotective son mode.

Determination ignited within his veins. Despite not being the best chef out there, Izuku was confident enough in his ability to cook decent eggs and a side of cinnamon toast. It was a sad combination, but he hoped the thought was enough to make a statement rather than the bland taste. He placed the notebook back onto his desk, left open to the page that contained the drawing of the grave he'd worked on previously. Even the pages hadn't been spared from Katsuki's wraith. The sight was clear as day, the small singes where the flames had licked at the paper obvious and *glaring*. *Just like Kacchan's eyes every time he looks at me.* It made Izuku's heart clench for two reasons. One, he was all too familiar with *hurt,* and the other he had very rarely felt, a wave of deep and all-consuming *anger* washing over his heart. A new type of *fire* was beginning to ignite within Izuku's veins.

This felt like the **beginning** of the ***end***. Something *volatile*, *explosive*, squirmed rigorously beneath his skin, hissing curses and feeding the feelings of darkness that threatened to seep into his veins. It was *alive* and it very much wanted to be let out. And it surely wasn't *happy* with crimson-eyed blondes. This landside would no doubt lead him on an entirely *different* adventure in life, one he'd never even thought possible previously. The *scariest* part of this discovery, he ***found*** that he didn't completely ***hate*** the idea.

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Now that he was awake for the day he figured he should probably attempt to dress more appropriately in case they had a flood of visitors later. It was still all foggy how he even arrived home the previous night, hence he wasn't sure if anyone had seen his little breaking-and-entering scene. He fought the urge to pray to *some* invisible god that the Bakugou household wouldn't be among the guests. He loved his aunt and uncle to the moon and back, but he also knew if they were here so would *Katsuki*. And that was a battle he was not yet ready to fight. He still had a lot of mental baggage to dissect from his epiphany earlier in the day, he didn't need any more added stress relating to it.

With a deep sigh, he stood up from his desk and made his way to the small closet on his right. He yanked the door open with more force than he intended and flinched as he heard the metal creak as it bent from the force behind the action. *Well, that didn't seem very normal,* he thought. His eyes widened in shock at how easily he nearly snapped the whole thing in half.

Had his closet rusted and deteriorated while he was away? It seemed too unlikely for that. Their apartment had never been five-star, but it wasn't a low two-star establishment either.

He didn't feel any stronger than when he left though. Was it simply a fluke? He had a feeling that definitely wasn't the case, but in his typical fashion, he put that *little* problem on the back burner of his mind as well.

More *gently* this time he finished pulling it back, revealing his less-than-appetizing wardrobe. Looking over everything hiding inside, he started to understand that maybe, just maybe *everyone* had been ***right*** about his absurd taste in clothing. It was a little overwhelming just how many shirts with slapstick humor he owned. What weren't ill attempts at cringe humor were All Might fanboy shirts that looked as if they belonged in a seven-year-olds closest rather than a 15-year-olds. He blushed a little in embarrassment. If being quirkless wasn't enough of a crime to society having *this* wardrobe definitely was.

“Oh boy here we go.” He whispered under his breath, reaching for the first handful of hangers. The top shirt was a light grey tee with the characters that read ‘Work Shirt.’ Shaking his head at that one and moving on to the next, he didn’t feel much better about his options.

“Favorite shirt, *colorful* shirt, *shirt*, t-shirt, long sleeve shirt, the list goes on forever, *party shirt*.” He murmured. His favorite from the growing pile had to be ‘fancy shirt.’

“Shirt it is.” He sighed, tossing the rest of the duds on the middle of his bed. He pulled his ‘night shirt’ over his head, roughly throwing it to the nearest corner where he figured his laundry basket likely was.

He quickly threw on the fresh and more bearable replacement and grabbed a pair of fresh boxers, along with one of his favorite pairs of charcoal-colored sweatpants to complete the look. Right away he noticed that certain areas *felt* tighter than he remembered. Puzzled he looked down at his waistline, where the tightness originated, and noticed his hips seemed a little thicker. They almost seemed to tease muscle mass now. They even had more shape to them rather than being stick built among other areas.

But they weren’t the only thing, his sweatpants which had been baggy as far as he remembered were now snugger and hit his ankle instead of hanging over the back of his heel. *Had he grown an inch or so?* He thought, writing it off as a growth spurt, he wandered out of his bedroom and into the bathroom directly next to his room. He did what he remembered to be his daily routine, everything seemed fine until he got to the actual brushing his teeth part of the routine. His gums and teeth alike seemed incredibly *sensitive* and even sore in parts. He was sure it wasn't due to cavities or some gum disease, he was a psychopath when it came to personal hygiene. This feeling felt all too familiar to growing pains, the reason why this could be happening was however unexplainable. Upon closer inspection he noticed *nothing*, everything seemed rather *ordinary*.

Finishing up his usual business, aside from the soreness he chose to ignore, for the time being, he exited the bathroom in near record time. He had a lot of energy to share today. Feeling a bit nostalgic again Izuku let his eyes linger on childhood photos of both him and his mother alike. Of course, several pictures included Kacchan, but we don't talk about that. A specific photo however was nearly impossible for Izuku not to fawn over, the adorable faces of a smiling Kacchan missing his front tooth and in an AllMight onesie matching Izuku standing beside him, had his stomach swarming with butterflies. This picture had always been incredibly dangerous, for Izuku's heart of course. With a deep sigh, he turned away for the last time and reentered the living room on his way to the fridge. He had an entirely different mission to accomplish next.

In the kitchen the teen pulled open the fridge, letting the various scents of fresh and old food enter his senses. He recoiled at the scent of a rotten roast beef sandwich on the second shelf. With a

disgruntled sneer, he grabbed the horrid thing and immediately threw it in the trash bin, before the thing could come to life and attack him more. Though as soon as he opened the lid he regretted it, the putrid scent of decay and rot assaulted him much stronger than the little sandwich had. He immediately dropped the sandwich and threw both hands over his nose in a protective stance.

As the scents of moldy food and spoiled plates overwhelmed his sensory glands he released a loud and choked gag. At the same time as he did, the ***loud*** sound of his mother's snoring entered his ears. The ***loudness*** of the sound startled him, causing him to jerk his head in the direction of the couch. She was *just* sleeping soundly he discovered and returned his attention to the disgusting mess before him. He felt disoriented by the sudden onslaught of an abnormally deafening world and the stench of decay. For a solid minute or three Izuku just rapidly blinked, holding his head for each unpleasant throb that festered within him. His breathing quickened each time a new spike of pain overwhelmed him. It had never felt so painful to be alive, physically at least. The sounds seemed to let up when he attempted to focus on his breathing again but the scents never allowed him any relief. His eyes shot to the source of the death pit which was the rotting organic material, he glared at the trash can as if it had wronged him worse than any person ever could.

After an unproductive glowering contest with the inanimate objects disturbing his peace of mind, Izuku made a hasty decision. Knowing full well he couldn't handle the stench for long and had little desire to cook food in a place that smelled so *foul*. He took it upon himself to round up all the worst-smelling foods and condiments within the fridge, the stale crackers in the wooden cabinets, and the rotten bunch of bananas on the counter. He **tossed** them all. Along with the dropped sandwich into the damning trash bin, that would surely become in his mortal enemy from now on. When he found the courage to open the dreaded thing, he made sure to rapidly tie up the bag before his nose somehow exploded from sensory overload. It seemed to do wonders to contain the ugliness that came from within what could be the literal bowels of the underworld. He had a newfound appreciation for scent-blocking garbage bags.

As silent as a mouse, he crept outside the apartment and threw away the ungodly thing. The scent still lingered even when he returned inside, but it was much more bearable than before. Even more so when he sprayed some of the apple cinnamon air fresher in the surrounding area. It did its job a little too well, but Izuku ignored its richened aroma. He'd prefer that faux apple scent over the literal scent of decay any day of the week. He made a mental note to invest in some sort of nose plugs if faced with this problem again in the future.

Once he finally got over the previous problem he was faced with another, actually making the food. Thankfully, the eggs turned out to be as easy as he remembered them to be. *However*, when the toast was up next, he felt a little strange about everything *again*. The bread smelt fresh and fine, but the cinnamon made him want to hold his nose up at it. The essence of it seemed to be lacking and that *annoyed* him. Upon further inspection and sampling later, he determined it was just him being

overly sensitive. The flavor was there and wasn't dreadful like he had expected it to be. It wasn't until he thought about it that he realized that cinnamon, *real cinnamon*, just didn't smell the same as its less authentic version did.

With that knowledge, he didn't know how to process the discovery. He wasn't even sure how he could tell such *subtle* differences between the two all of a sudden either. The world around him appeared to be expanding with each passing second and he'd be lying if the thought wasn't a *bit* intimidating. So much was suddenly changing and he held no reasonable explanation for it. *Was it **him**? Was he the **weird** one all of a sudden? Or was the world around him just growing **bizarre**?*

Clearly, the scent of the air-freshener cinnamon and the baking spice kind were different and separate entities. That wholeheartedly bothered him and probably still would for the foreseeable future. He felt like he was overanalyzing such a silly thing, but considering how many other 'oddities' he'd been feeling this one naturally set off some red flags of its own. The reason for so many changes still escaped him. He had no proof of these changes, yet he felt he wasn't *wrong* in thinking about them so much. Something was becoming very clearly wrong with him. He just hoped whatever it was, it wasn't terminal. After his near-death situation, he realized he really **wasn't** ready to die just yet. More than anything he wanted to **fight** against his *fate*, no matter what *that* meant for him later in life.

Now that breakfast was complete, if not a bit sad to look at, Izuku returned to his sleeping mother. He felt bad waking her after she so clearly needed the sleep, but seeing as the clock read 11:50 he figured she'd be madder at him if he let her oversleep than undersleep. He wasn't sure if she even had work right now, but in case she did he wanted to make sure she was up and around for it. He set the plate of eggs and toast on the end table closest to the couch. Then he crouched down and lightly shook her shoulders. She didn't stir right away, yet she immediately reacted to Izuku's presence. Her grip on his hand was fierce, as a small frown covered her face.

"Mom it's time to wake up." He whispered quietly near her ear, but still far enough away that she wouldn't accidentally swipe at him like the rabid morning cat she could be.

"I-Izuku p-please come back home. I- I can't do this without you." She cried out in a muttered whisper, his heart clenched and ached with each stuttered word. The wounds he left were indeed *deep*.

Her reaction however was unexpected, rather than angry like he had half respected, she looked completely *broken*. Her bottom lip quivered and shook with obvious anxiety and fear, Fat tears rolled down her cheeks a few at a time and her whole body began to violently shake. It was at this point that Izuku panicked and shook her more roughly, his own anxiety coming to light.

"MOM!"

He shouted rocking her back and forth, her emerald eyes shot open a second later, staring into his with wide doe eyes. She looked exactly like a deer in headlights, shocked and unsure of everything her eyes could see. The clouded look disappeared from her pupils and she sobbed harder as she leaped up, wrapping her arms around Izuku. He was so surprised that he lost his balance and fell down on top of her. The couch groaned at the abuse. She was hiccuping and sobbing into his neck, the tears rolling down his back and soaking his shirt but he cared little about it.

After a few beats he held her back just as fiercely, he figured she needed this just as much as he had. He felt *unforgivable* for allowing his mother to suffer so much ***alone***, all simply because of his foolishness. *His own weakness*. How could ***he*** of all people leave her behind like this… as *he* had. The feeling of his heart being squeezed to death was heavy and unsettling, causing his insides to become tangled and tight bundles of self-hatred and disappointment. He swore he'd never ever be like *him*, yet he was hurting his poor mother just as much. Even though Izuku came back and the *other* would never, the scars were already left and the road to recovery would no doubt be a rough one all over again.

"I-Izuku…you really did come back…I was afraid…*so* afraid that when I woke up you'd be **gone** all over again. I-I couldn't handle that *again* Izuku I just can't." She sobbed, even louder than before and Izuku felt his heart constrict even more. The weight of her words was ***heavier*** than steel and more *crushing* than any rock.

"I-I can't promise I won't leave you, because I already broke that promise. But please believe in this new promise, I swear that I will never intentionally leave you behind. No matter where life takes us. T-this was something I'll never do again. Not without telling you. I swear." Izuku soothed, running his hands through her long and tangled bedhead. She didn't say anything else. In all honesty, she couldn't with a confident voice so instead, she nodded vigorously against him.

The heavy invisible chains held his heart hostage, enveloping him in a sea of darkness and seething regret. His heart felt as if it were shrinking from the weight of the guilt overtaking him. He swore he heard the *very* moment that his heart broke. The sound rang, haunting his head and mind, tormenting it as it pleased, the 'crack' was as horrible a sound as shattering glass.

Instead of it being outside, it was all happening inside. It seems Izuku was truly carved from glass, he hadn't felt truly ***this*** *fragile* since his father had left them years prior. Now it felt so much ***worst***, the entire world as he knew it was collapsing in on him. And he was sure if he made it out of those shadowed depths this time he'd never be who he once was. When the world changes, so do you. It is a human's most powerful attribute, *adaptation.*

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Inko and Izuku remained in close contact, letting their emotions run raw and saying what was on their minds with everything but words. It was what both needed and it helped them cope with the whole ordeal. It was a lot to take in at once; the fear of accidentally killing someone, a missing son you worried you'd never see again, a flurry of nightmares that blurred the lines between dreams and forgotten memories, and the all-time high of rampaging emotions.

Izuku was calm through most of the exchange, this time silently assuming the 'unmoveable rock' position that Inko had taken on last night when he had needed a good sob. Returning the favor was no concern to him, he didn't mind in the slightest and even reveled in the feeling of protectiveness and reassurance he could give to his mother. Because at least in time like this he felt useful, if he could make just one person smile it was worth all the risk in the world. This feeling was a reassurance of this second life he seemed to have been **given**, he swore to *use it well* this time around.

The surprise breakfast was cold by the time Inko was able to control her inner turmoil again. Izuku was a little sad, but he shook the feeling off when he realized that this had been much more important than some subpar breakfast he'd made. Inko's eyes began to roam the room and landed on the small platter set off to the side of the end table. The first time she truly took note of anything around her. Her heart rate increased as she felt her heart squeeze at the gesture before it turned into guilt, her son's efforts having gone cold after her outburst.

“I’m sorry Honey, you went out of your way to cook this for me and I *ruined* it because I let my emotions get the better of me again.” She sniffled, wiping the tears from her eyes.

Izuku picked up on this instantly and reassured her that it was fine and that if she still wanted it later there was always the microwave. He jokingly commented that it would probably taste the same either way considering his ‘skills’ in the kitchen. His mother couldn’t help but silently agree when memories of all the times Izuku nearly burned their kitchen and apartment to the ground more than a handful of times surfaced.

Eventually, Izuku stood up and the plate was placed into the microwave and heated up after a quick sniff test that caused the inside of his nose to tingle. Once the plate was safely secured within the microwave Izuku let out a kitten sneeze that took Inko by surprise.

“Izuku? Do you have allergies?” She asked, her brows knitted in a confused manner. Her son had *never* been one to have allergies so why would he suddenly be sneezing so many times in the last few hours? If it had only been once she wouldn’t have batted an eye but now that it was a daily occurrence and happened multiple times she was growing suspicious.

“

Huh? What mom no, of course not. It's the cinnamon... it’s been messing with my nose lately.” He joked, wiping his nose with a tissue and hiding his small grin underneath.

“Hmm, okay if you say so.”

Inko didn’t grimace this time or flinch at the taste or texture so Izuku took this as a win. A few happy tears and watery smiles of thanks later and the pair found themselves back on the couch going over a few other important details they hadn’t gotten to the night prior. Izuku notebook in hand and a head filled with excuses as to why he didn’t want a certain blonde to come over.

“I know we have *stuff* to talk about, but before that mom, I want your thoughts on this grave. I woke up early and felt a bit inspired and your opinion on it would be great.” The teen breathed out, suddenly a bit more nervous to hear what his mom thought of his idea. He thought it was good, but what if she hated it?

“Oh, that was quick. Sure, you know I love seeing what goes on in that big brain of yours.” She giggled, happily grabbing the notebook from his hands. She looked down and her eyes widened as her gaze fell over each of the delicate details covering the page.

“What do you think?” Izuku fidgeted, nervously impatient. Her widened eyes did little to soothe his racing heart.

“I think it’s beautiful Izuku. I almost forgot how gifted you were when it came to pencil and paper.” She hummed proudly, her dark green nails grazing each of the curvatures the pencil had created. “I really like it.”

Izuku physically deflated in relief, his heart starting to return to more human thrums. His smile was small, but still so bright. With his half-lidded eyes and unruly curls, he looked like a deity straight from the deep woods. Inko’s heart warmed at the sight of the sun highlighting her son’s figure so elegantly. It was at that moment that it all really clicked into place, *Izuku was home*. He was *safe* and he was *here smiling* equally as bright as the sun covering his freckled face. *What a wonderful day to be alive.*

“Thanks, mom, I really tried on this one. It would feel dishonest of me if I hadn’t given it my all.” The boy admitted, looking at the drawing with a saddened fondness. Inko understood that look all too well.

“I’m **proud** of you. Being able to forgive is a *gift*. It's never easy to forgive others, but forgiving ourselves can be nearly impossible.” Inko smiled, Izuku froze up at her words, he *still* couldn’t forgive himself *yet*.

“And I know you aren’t ready for that just yet, but this Izuku…” She paused for a second to gesture to the notebook. “ Is the first step towards finding the redemption you seek.” She finished, putting a supportive hand on his shoulder. He gave her a nod in appreciation, then agreed.

“Yeah.”

“Okay. Next order of business would have to be talking about telling everyone that you are back home.” Inko piped up, clapping her hands beside her head in glee. Izuku gulped, he knew this couldn’t be avoided but damn was he anxious.

“Ah, yeah.”

"Hmm, let’s see. Who to tell first? I want to tell Mitsuki first and I honestly think she’d ***kill*** *me if I didn’t…but I should really call the officers on your case. Then there’s Mr. Yagi who was a big help throughout the whole process. He was so passionate about finding you Izuku, it really made me* ***happy****. Knowing that there were still good people out there that weren’t pro-heroes and still so adamant and passionate about helping the people. It kinda restored my faith in humanity if I’m being completely honest. Oh then there’s the Kaneki’s down the road and there's-”* Inko rambled on, listing off names here and there.

Izuku listened, though he zoned out at times. He almost forgot how much alike he and his mother really were. It was a bit eerie hearing her words rolling off her tongue so quickly. He wondered if he sounded as haunting when he mumbled on about any and everything as well. While listening, he couldn’t help but notice the soft blush of pink that tinged his mother’s cheeks every time she mentioned this ‘Mr. Yagi,’ character. His brows furrowed.

Seeing that reaction was ***more*** than enough for him to give her his full attention and make his metaphorical hackles raise. He was very protective of his mother. Overprotective he figured, but after everything that his ‘father’ had put them through he wasn’t the easiest to please when it came to suitors. He would be supportive of course, but before that he’d have to test the person who dared to approach his mother, seeing if their intentions were truly pure or *impure*. Really either way he’d be **cutthroat**. He was lenient with most things, but when it came to his mother’s happiness that was never something he’d cut any kind of corners on.

Though that would be a bit difficult this time, considering it was his mother's reaction to a potential suitor versus an actual suitor's obvious feelings. This was a new face he'd never seen on his mother. *She must really like his guy. I wonder if he's a creep or a good guy?* Izuku mentally asked himself, not expecting an answer from anyone else within his consciousness. But rough incomprehensible rumbling in the back of his mind seemed to have other plans. It was startling but short-lived and he soon forgot about the yet again strange reaction within his body.

"Izuku? Izuku are you even listening to me?" Inko huffed, clearly perturbed. Izuku flashed her a smile before reiterating her own words back at her.

"Of course I am mom. We should tell the officers first, I agree. I don't know who *this* Mr. Yagi is though. Is he a detective or something? I mean you seem to know a *lot* about him with the way you kept talking about him." Izuku teased, sending a playful smirk to his mom. Inko's pale face exploded in varying shades of reds and pinks.

"I-IZUKU!" She shouted out in embarrassment, a small pout on her lips. The teen had to fight the urge to snort at her reaction.

"Jeez, Mom no need to scream for all the neighborhood to hear. I was just asking a question." Izuku snarked, rubbing his eardrums in an attempt to soothe the burning ache growing in them from the piercing sound.

"O-oh right I'm sorry. Inside voices from now on." Inko whispered slapping a hand over her mouth, a new wave of embarrassment washing over her face.

"That'd be great. Thanks, Mom, sorry if my teasing was too much. I am genuinely curious though, especially after seeing how flustered my mom got talking about this *mystery* man." Izuku sighed, still rubbing comforting circles along his ears.

“Umm, *well* I met Mr. Yagi two days after you went missing. He was very nice, very kind and he has the *most* interesting electric blue eyes. Unlike any, I’ve ever seen before.” She confessed almost dreamily and Izuku knew his face screamed bewildered, his mother seemed to notice she was getting sidetracked as well.

“Aa-anyway, he’s a consultant for the local police branch. He’s close friends and partners with Detective Tsukauchi. Obviously, that means he’s a *very* good man, but besides that, he was especially passionate about helping with *your* case and that already had my gratitude. But he went above and beyond Izuku. He comforted me a lot while you were gone and he was very adamant about finding you." Inko smiled lovingly, slowly placing her hand over her heart. A giddy smile on her face. "It really touched me.”

“Oh? That was very nice of him. Did anything else happen?” Izuku asked with a sly grin disguised as some something innocent, Inko still in her own little world didn’t notice the fox-like smile.

“Mr. Yagi took me out to dinner a few times as well…b-but it’s not a date if that’s what you’re thinking! It was simply to go over your case and all the details.” She muttered quietly, if Izuku didn’t have incredible hearing he’d have missed it. His fox grin widened and he fought the urge to whistle, as he was sure his mother would be even more flustered if he did. He wasn't sure where these playful reactions came from, as he normally was shy and respectful to a fault, but he suddenly felt like *teasing*. Something he *very* rarely did. He kinda *liked* this new change though.

“That sounds very lovely Mom. You’ll have to introduce me to him. I’ll have to personally thank the man that took care of my mother when I couldn’t after all.” Izuku cleared his throat to swallow the merciless snickers that wished to escape. He felt the familiar tingle of excitement and pure happiness for a few short seconds before it grew into a cooling melancholy. He had missed such a monumentous moment in his Mother's life, physical proof of her healing heart and where had he been? In some damned cursed forest feasting on some natural fauna like a savage beast. These feelings sat heavily on his chest, but he choose to ignore them for now, not daring to voice out such sourness in favor of simply sharing in his mother's happiness and giddiness for a new love.

He had to play it *cool* and let her have her moment. This was important and probably took a lot for her to so *openly* admit. She **never** mentioned *any* men before. She had previously always been *very* uninterested in pursuing anyone after everything, but it seemed *this* mystery guy was **something**

out of this world. He must be quite special to capture her attention like this. Guess that means Izuku has to come to peace with accepting the guy into their lives. Rather that was for the short term or for the long term was yet to be decided. He made a silent note to be open to both options.

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After a much-needed and very exhausting discussion later, Izuku was shooed off to his room as his mother had said ‘put on something more presentable.’ Mr.Yagi, his detective partner, and who knows how many other officers stormed the house would be here in a few minutes. Izuku could practically hear the silent sirens wailing down the street, the screech of rubber tires beating against the pavement was as obvious as night and day.

Something Izuku was realizing he was struggling with differentiating, the various colors of night, day, afternoon, and the morning dawn were all beginning to blur together. The only way he could easily tell a difference was an innate clock residing somewhere deep in his suddenly *much* larger consciousness. He would just simply know what time it was, or at least a very closely acute version of the time.

As if to prove this point to himself Izuku looked out his bedroom, eyes drawn to the sky and the light emitting from behind the fluffy clouds. To him it seemed bright, maybe a little more so than it had hours prior, but the difference in sight was so subtle that he was sure he wouldn’t have even noticed had he not been strictly focusing his sight on the scene. He made a mental note to test this theory around 10 p.m. tonight, just to be *sure* he wasn’t completely losing it.

With a flustered huff, he lazily threw on the red flannel that had been hanging off the front of his bed. Flannels, ironic comedic shirts, anything he deemed comfortable, and gym shorts were what made up the majority of his wardrobe and throw in a couple of fancier shirts. He really didn’t feel like wearing a gaudy tux his mother had picked for him right now. He figured the flannel, while not much better than the wide array of other shirts seemed the better option. At least the option that was less likely to promise a lecture from his mother later.

He was amidst throwing on his black skinny jeans when a loud knock against the wood echoed through to hallways and met his ears. They twitched uncomfortably at the sudden incursion, he assumed it must be their officer friends and one *Mr. mystery man*. The last thought had him perking up and standing a little taller, not that he was anywhere tall enough to be intimidating. His genes hadn’t blessed him with the body of an Olympian god, like Katsuki’s had. He *wasn’t* jealous, ***absolutely not***. He was simply *aware* of how **nice** the Bakugou family genes were. He felt rather subpar compared to their unbeatable genes, but honestly who else didn’t? They were gods among men in every sense of the word ‘unearthly.’

Maybe he was a tiny bit jealous of how *lucky* Katsuki's genetic lottery had been, but that *wasn't* important and mattered little to him. He promised himself to distance both *head* and *heart* from him, yet here he **was** still yearning for the explosive blonde. He would take baby steps and leave it at that. No longer would he allow the other's harsh words to hit him in any of the places that used to matter. The less he cared and the *more* he distanced his heart the faster it would *pass* and the *sooner* he could keep his promise wholeheartedly. Time would heal it all in no time.

"It doesn't matter. I have to go greet Mr. mystery man right now anyway." Izuku whispered under his breath, tilting his chin to the side as he eyed his reflection. His skinny jeans definitely looked a *lot* tighter than before and even his ass seemed to have developed overnight. It made him flush in slight embarrassment at the tightness *of everything*. He hadn't really been trying, but it seems that he had accidentally cleaned up rather nicely. He admitted he looked more than decent. Maybe preened a little because he felt like it for the first time in his pitiful existence. He steeled himself to face the motley crew of officers downstairs, despite his slight embarrassment he still wore the skinny jeans. They made him feel pretty for once, *so why not just let himself have this for once?*

Feeling as **ready** as he'd ever been, he shut the bedroom door behind him and followed the voices coming from the front of the house. He could make out a total of three voices and four presences. He didn't recognize any of the scents that wafted throughout the hall. However, one scent that carried a subtle smell of the ocean, a light musk, and what he could only describe as *power* caught his interest. It felt vaguely *familiar*, but from where he had little to no idea.

"Thank you all for coming over and for helping to find my son over the last weeks. I *really* appreciate it and am *so* relieved that he is finally **home** safe and sound. I just told him to go change, so he should be right down."

"Of course Mrs. Midoriya, it was no problem. After all, it is our duty to its citizens to help in any way we can. I am quite surprised that he came home himself." A gruff, almost monotone voice responded. The ' *Mrs* . Midoriya' had Izuku's hair bristling. Both he and Inko hated that title. Inko liked their last name, just *not* the Mrs attached to it. *While* Izuku just flat-out *detested* his last name and everything it stood for, the *reminder* it **left** behind.

"Oh Mr. Tsukauchi, please it's *Ms*. Midoriya. I have been divorced for well *over* a decade now. It's not a title I have *any* appreciation for these days. Please just call me Inko." His mother responded

gruffly, clearly miffed but still retaining her politeness.

Izuku's chest rumbled in approval at his mother's response, even more so when he heard the tell-tale signs of another man doing his best to contain his own laughter. An awkward clearing of his throat and a quick apology later and Izuku thought he'd better announce himself now instead of creeping in the shadows. He found he'd honestly prefer to just stay there, but he knew *that* sadly wasn't an option.

"Sorry if I kept you all waiting for too long."

Four heads all turned in his direction, he didn't bother looking over the others yet instead focused his sights on his mother, who gave him a satisfied nod of approval at his choice of clothes. Her eyes gleamed with happy mirth, Izuku knew his eyes looked equally as playful. A sudden cough and a deep sonorous voice brought his attention to the three other men in his house. Knowing there were so many strangers in ***his*** *home*, ***his*** *territory* made his skin itch in an uncomfortable way, but he ignored the need to chase them all *off*. *When had he been reduced to a territorial dog?* A thought for another day he supposed.

"Ah! You must be Young Midoriya in the flesh. I can't tell you how relieved we all are to know that you are fine my boy." The man who spoke was lanky. Yet he towered over everyone else in the room. No question this man was well over 6 feet. He had wild blonde hair. It looked wavy in appearance, yet upon closer inspection, it almost looked spiked.

"I am Izuku Midoriya. It's nice to meet you Mr...?" The curious teen asked, temporarily stopping his assessment of the tall man. He couldn't be sure he was the right one. Well *until* he noticed the icy electric blue eyes. Then he was pretty sure this was the mystery man his mother had apparently been hung up on.

"Oh! How rude of me, my name is Toshinori Yagi. I work closely with Detective Tsukauchi and have for *many* years actually. I was helping his team with your case." He paused to give the teen a

blinding smile that seemed to have a way of making everyone around him blanketed in warmth. Izuku thought for a second he saw the tendrils of guilt in the corner of the man's eyes.

“It’s very nice to put a face to the name, your mother has told me so much about you that I feel that I have already known you for years.” The blonde man said with a sad smile. It was *nearly* unnoticeable but Izuku swore he *could* see deep-rooted guilt flittering in the icy depths of the lanky man before him. The man obviously had a story to tell, but Izuku wouldn’t question him too harshly, at least not *yet*. There'd be a *proper* time and place for that.

“It’s an honor to meet you as well Mr. Yagi, my mom has told me *quite* a bit about you as well.” Izuku smiled, it was bright but laced with a hidden venom.

A **warning**. One that was sent to any man that wished to pursue or exploit his mother. Judging by his gulp Toshinori immediately picked up on the signal. Izuku was *pleased* that he passed the first test. He looked scared, *really* scared, and that secretly made the teen thrilled.

“I see. I hope all good things,” he awkwardly chuckled attempting to feel less uncomfortable. A glare from his mother told him to silently stop harassing the poor man, so he relented… temporarily.

“Of course. I don’t think my mom is *even* capable of talking ill about another living being. I wanted to personally thank you for taking care of her when I couldn’t. I appreciate it more than you’ll ever know.” Izuku said reaching out his hand to shake the older’s, sincerely grateful for the man’s efforts.

The blonde looked down at the offered hand in question, meeting viridian eyes that gleamed just as brightly as his mother’s. These eyes even had the same hidden impish charm to them he realized. It made the older man’s heart beat a little faster than it should. This was a big moment for him. It was equal to the moment you meet your girlfriend's parents, but this time it’s her apparently volatile and mysterious son. The suddenly friendly and gentle attitude towards him, as if a switch had been

flipped was almost worrisome. The sudden contrast gave everyone but Inko a case of mental whiplash.

With a gulp the man drew in a sharp breath and took the younger's hand, they shook a second later and the secret hero realized that this boy had quite a solid grip. Not to mention he noticed he had abnormally warm hands. A lot of power came from that handshake. And that made *even All Might* shutter at the intensity. Between this boy's gaze and the raw prowess that radiated from him, the hero felt intimidated. It was unlike anything else he had ever *seen*. It was as beautifully entrancing as it was terrifying.

"The honor is all mine Young Midoriya, Inko has been a true joy and I hope we see more of each other in the future. If our paths are to cross of course."

"I think she'd really like that." Izuku chirped happily.

Toshinori looked unsure as if he couldn't believe what he was hearing. The blonde-haired man glanced to the side where the short emerald-haired woman stood. They briefly locked eyes, ending with Inko nodding in approval of a promised date, not without a small blush painted across her cheeks.

"I would as well." Mr. Yagi confessed, bringing his eyes back to meet Izuku's, a sudden seriousness filling his eyes. Izuku wondered why. "That being said... Young Midoriya I would equally like to get to know you. That is if you would be okay with hanging out with an old man like me."

Izuku's heart did a little backflip at this man's words. He was a mere stranger, someone new and a possible *threat* to him and his mother. Yet **here** he was, the first of Inko's suitors to say such a surprising thing. Never had any of the previous cockroaches *ever* asked *anything* about Izuku. At least not more than a few simple questions that everyone asked out of politeness rather than with actual interest.

Yet this man, he had so easily included Izuku into his bubble. Into his space. Into his heart. So sincerely that Izuku thought he might sob. It was one of the most thoughtful sentences he had heard in a *very* **long** time. At least from someone that wasn't his own mother. He felt appreciated, he felt loved, and more than anything else he felt *noticed*. This man had returned a piece of Izuku's humanity to him, handing it back to him so delicately and with so much care that Izuku felt a piece of him break all over again.

But not because he was heartbroken, but because his tattered soul was slowly regaining shape. A shape that had long been lost in the haze of self-hatred and suffering inflicted upon him for simply being alive, existing in a world that wished for nothing more than for him to completely *disappear*. He felt a little more alive than he had in the following years of his life. It was invigorating and made his heart rapidly flutter under his ribcage. If he didn't know better he'd have thought he ate a butterfly, damning the creature to an eternity with him.

At this moment Izuku wondered if maybe, *just maybe* **this** was the feeling of warmth many got from their fathers. He felt delighted, excited and most of all hopeful. Hopeful for a relationship that had yet to bloom but had all the potential to grow into something truly beautiful. He wasn't about to completely open his heart to this man. That would be incredibly foolish of him, but he was *willing* to give him a temporary pass and *maybe*, just maybe accept that offer.

"Sure! Now would anyone like some tea? I have a feeling this is going to take a while." He offered with a fox-like grin, he felt a little giddier than he'd ever like to admit. Might as well ride this brief high out while it lasted, right?

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"*I am* ***exhausted***." Izuku cried, as he all but fell onto the couch, faceplanting into the darkened cushions. Inko's amused giggles filled the air around them.

"Oh Honey, c'mon it wasn't *that* bad was it?" She asked, poking him in the side with the tv remote. He only gave a weak groan in response. He loved people, he really did, but he'd never been all that adept in social settings. His social skills were lackluster and left much room for improvement, a childhood of near isolation and bullying from peers would do that to anyone.

“Technically yes, but they asked the same question in a *million* different ways, Mom. Seriously why did they think I’d answer it any differently just because they changed the wording? It made me feel ridiculous.”

“Ah Izuku, it’s protocol, and to make matters more complicated you don’t remember what even happened to you for two weeks. Anyone would worry about it, most cases of temporary amnesia happen because of a traumatic injury or a mental trauma. You have no signs of injuries let alone anything fatal. Mental trauma is more likely, but even that seems unlikely. Even if they think so. It’s overall a weird case and new to everyone involved Honey.” Inko hummed threading her short fingers through his fluffy curls, he hummed in appreciation of the attention.

“I am beginning to really hate how right you are all the time,” Izuku grumbled into the pillow. Inko having heard his snark slapped his butt with the tv remote. He yelped and pushed himself up to a sitting position leaning on his elbows, his face contorted into a pout and scarlet with embarrassment. **“Mommm!”**

“Now hush up Izuku before I invite Mitsuki over right now to make you *even* more exhausted. You know she’s gonna have my head and then yours when she finds out *you are home* and **neither** of us has told her yet. Oh gods and don’t even get me started on Masaru, that man terrifies me Izuku.” Inko sighed, dramatically throwing a hand over her eyes in woe.

Izuku wanted to roll his eyes, he *really **did*** but he knew she was right. They’d be dead when the sun comes tomorrow. Mitsuki could smell gossip miles away and was quick to chase it once she caught the scent. She was a *deranged* bloodhound, Masaru was a *docile* toy poodle with the secret dark side of a feral raccoon and then there was Katsuki. Mr larger than life and better than anyone and better at anything, his personality equally as fierce as his quirk. However, despite the bravado, he was definitely an angry ball of fluff, a grumpy pomeranian at best. They *were* quite the unit, each with wild and exciting personalities and secret quirks to the personalities that they hide from most people. They *would* definitely be the most exhausting people to placate. That however was thankfully a battle for *tomorrow*, and not **today**.

Although he wasn’t sure what goddess was smiling down at him, this luck was welcomed. He wasn’t sure how he managed to convince his mother to put off telling the Bakugou’s for another day, but he was grateful for whatever unnatural force had intervened and saved his ass tonight. He felt dead on his feet and even his eyebags felt like they ***had*** *eyebag*s at this point. Everything attached to him ached. Even his All Might socks felt like they were acid against his skin. He felt

weak and vulnerable and that annoyed him more than it ever had before. He really felt like biting someone's face off, but that seemed way too morbid to think about, so he *settled* with punching in their teeth.

A mental battle with himself later and he thought it best to excuse himself for the night and retreat to his room for the time being. He didn't like how frighteningly aggressive his train of thought was right now. He felt *too* much like Katsuki and that in itself was *enough* to worry about. Sleeping off these chaotic thoughts along with the aches and pains seemed like the best option right about now. He knew he must've looked pitiful and sick because not even the All Might movie was keeping his attention. He just wanted to *sleep*.

"Mom I'm not feeling so great, I think I'm going to turn in for the night. I love you and I'll see you in the morning kay?" He said, stretching as he stood, various snaps and pops entered his ears and he cringed at the sounds his body was making. It *didn't* sound normal, **far** from it actually.

"Honey, are you feeling sick? Do you need to go to the doctor after all?" Inko stood up, immediately placing herself on his left side. Her eyes filled with worry, Izuku listlessly shook his head, feeling like all his energy was being bled out of him the longer he stayed.

"No 'm just tired." He mumbled, turning away from her and stumbling over the rug as he made his way to the very *alluring* sight of his bed. He plopped down and the minute his head made contact with the pillow he was out, the voice of his mother completely fading from his ears as he was taken into a world familiar, yet unfamiliar in every way.

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Deep into the night, a wolf awoke to an *intoxicating* scent. It was earthy and pumped with freshly brewing blood, the peak of production. The scent of warmth lay just under its skin, the fur smelled of greenery and herbs. It was delightful. The soft pitter-pattering of small footsteps screamed for the wolf's immediate attention. It worked and the wolf stirred from within its den. It licked its lips, a blue and black forked tongue lingering on the edges in hungry anticipation of a promised hunt. The world around the wolf was distorted and dizzying, static and reality blended together in a faithless dance. Crackles of static lightning and shifting colors left the wolf rapidly blinking awake.

Even though the wolf was calm his heartbeat wouldn't quiet, as he was far beyond excited. He hadn't had fresh meat in a few days, and *that* had felt very unpleasant. An innate itch he just

couldn’t scratch without the thrill of hunting, the lure to bountiful prey high in the mountains was *too* tempting. Too far of a hike for him though, he’d rather be closer to his den, his homestead. Then there was his already small pack, he didn’t want to leave her behind again. Luckily a stray hare had wandered into the park nearby. A park he vaguely remembered, yet the image was blurred and he couldn't recall its importance to the host. It didn't try hard to recall the faded memories either, as it frankly didn't care, it was simply *hungry*.

Perhaps this was a wild rabbit that had left in search of greener pastors or even a pet that had lost its way and had *unfortunately* ended up in a local park. Neither option triggered a sense of hesitance, he was far too hungry to think about anything other than finding that furry treat. Petty emotions were *currently* unimportant.

A sonorous rumbling left his lips as he crept to the nearest window. With careful paws he caressed the edge of the windowsill, pushing it up as gently as he could. His blunt nails fumbled against the glass, though made no alerting noises much to his relief. He wasn’t sure how he remembered such a human habit, but he was thankful that he was able to easily unlock the cursed thing without alerting any onlookers, inside or out. Any witnesses would be *rather unfortunate*, especially considering how desperately ***hungry*** the beast was.

The window made a small whine at the sudden breach of contact, but the wolf was out the damned thing just as fast as a flash of lightning. With the grace of a well-versed ballet dancer and the stealth of an assassin, the wolf leaped onto the cold concrete below. A storm of black and white static greeted the beast outside the window. He landed on the tips of his toes with a soft thump, one that was nearly silent but he still hated that he made even the *slightest* of sounds. If his quarry had been any closer he’d have long alerted and lost the little creature by now.

Toxic green drool fell from the beast’s jaws, hissing as it hit the pavement with an acidic sizzle. He chose to ignore it and pressed onward, silently tailing the hare’s gluttonous scent. The night was pitch black, filling the sky and everything below it in a foggy and hazed void, though the wolf didn’t notice, his vision was exactly as it had always been. The infrared shadows casually greeted him, beckoning and leading him to the prize which he so desperately sought. The hare's red outline was tantalizing and a careful reminder to remain patient. He could see nearly miles ahead, the details all crisp and vibrant as they filled his irises. His reptilian eyes blinked a few times as the static began to clear and be replaced with shadowed timestamps of the rabbit's exact pathing.

He glanced down at the near-invisible traces of small herbivore paw prints in the loosened dirt of the park. The scent trails hung heavier in the air around him, painting him a beautifully detailed mosaic of the rabbit's recent activities. He gave a silent growl in approval, his fingernails suddenly felt inconvenient and useless to him. A small and unpleasant burning sensation later and an organic *pop* left him feeling much more prepared for what came next. He was *more* than ready to **Devour.**

There, straight ahead about fifty feet ahead lay the apple of his eyes, his precious quarry. The white and beige hare was mindlessly gnawing at a particularly green patch of grassland, completely unaware of the beast lurking far behind it. The wolf stopped shy of the hare, carefully analyzing the

furry creature. The creature was deliciously plump and seemed to be the perfect snack. The wolf's hunches prepared to launch at the rabbit before he caught his foolishness of being so impulsive and impatient in such a place. Glowing teal eyes briefly checked the surrounding area for any unwanted onlookers.

Once he realized they were happily alone, he went for the most efficient strike. A simple hand around the tiny neck and a snap later the deed was done. This hunt wasn't about pleasure, but rather scratching that invisible itch that was unyielding hunger. It wasn't his method of choice, he much preferred biting his prey to its death, but he didn't have the leisure to stick around the suburbs for long. Doing so would be dangerous and could result in getting caught. He absolutely didn't want that. The reason as to why alluded him though.

The rabbit's body twitched a few times as the muscles reacted for the last time. The back legs kicked for a few moments before the light left its wide dark eyes. The wolf waited patiently, his flattened and dull teeth growing sharper and more defined as he waited. Fangs and an extra row of incisors on both top and bottom proudly displayed themselves. With them came an overwhelming instinct ready to devour.

Now that the rabbit had ceased all motion it seemed now was indeed time his efforts paid off. A happy grunt escaped his lips as he bit into the small creature's tufts of fur. A few mouthfuls of thickened fur and he was growing rather annoyed. He'd already spit a good amount of white and brown fluff to the side, but there was still so much to remove and that was frustrating. *All* he wanted to **do** was eat and the universe seemed to be heavily working *against* him.

He thought it in his best interest to begin clearing out the fur from a suitable area located around the neck. This action would be both the most efficient and save time. Thankfully his work was enough and an available spot to feast on the white meat was found shortly after. He bit down with enough force to snap any bones or muscle visceral that dared stand in his way. Once the tedious part was over, all that was left was to enjoy the sensations and tastes.

The freshness of the meat was *everything* he had been *craving* and ***more***. The night was peaceful and the fireflies glowed beautifully nearby. So much so that he found himself passing to watch the beautiful displays of light. The gentle whipping of the winds and the scents they carried in their bows was incredibly relaxing. Warm crimson dripped down his chin, coating his second skin and leaving a wettened coldness behind anywhere it touched. The feel of something constricting his movements and so closely layered against his skin felt *nauseating* and **wrong**, but he bore with it allowing the feeling of peacefulness to fully compose him. He was a second away from howling a song of victory before he thought better of doing so in such a public place. That would be asking for more trouble than he wanted to deal with tonight.

Two more bites and the rabbit would be little more than a bloodied heap of fur, not even bones remained when he was done. The marrow was nearly as satiating as the meat itself, the silken

texture and hearty flavor of what he could only describe as ***life,*** was revolutionary. He was left with a buzz of energy each time he consumed flesh as fresh as this. He was about to swallow the last mouthful of meat when his ears twitched, picking up the sounds of something moving nearby. He growled under his breath, mentally cursing with every word that he could remember. *Something* was nearby and *disrupting* him. **Worst** of all it was a *human*, not another delectable prey for his taking. That fact was just as annoying as being interrupted because regrettably, he was still *starving*.

The wolf turned in the direction where the sounds of kicked-up gravel were strongest. This person... whoever they were, was clearly on their way to the very same park. The footsteps weren't all that heavy, so this was likely a child or a teenager. Or even a small adult female, but the scent carried the faint traces of undeniable musk, informing him that whoever this person was they were male. The beast raised his lips in a snarl, his still elongated teeth poking out of his jaw. His teal eyes glowed furiously before they began to dim in recession.

His heart rate slowed as he focused on the heartbeat and scent of the intruder. They seemed calm more or less and smelled like fresh caramel corn and vanilla waffle cones. Somewhere under the surface scent of something fiery and spicy lingered as well. It was a *disgustingly* nice scent, but it innately pissed him off and made his fur bristle in discomfort. As the footsteps grew closer the wolf looked down at the bloodied mess covering the ground below him. Remains coated his hands, his face his neck, his second skin, and the now darkened grass around him. He wanted to growl but held it in. Looking down at the fur remains and then back in the direction of the interloper, he made a disgruntled huff and picked up as much of the bloodied evidence he could carry. Which was all but a few tufts of white fur. He hopped no one took much note of a few bloodied puffs of fur.

A soft curse later and he was turning tail back to the house. He couldn't make a straight run for it just yet, as the figure was now standing directly under the towering street light and blocking the wolf's main exit back home. *Sure,* the figure would never be able to see him coming, but the risk of having to be *so close* to someone in ***this*** *state* had him hesitating. Killing a rabbit and a deer here and there was one thing, but when it came to killing humans...there were just *too* many other factors he'd have to deal with. A *subpar* meal like a human wasn't worth all the pain it'd bring, let alone the hammer of justice for murder, accidental or not. He wasn't the type to risk more than he knew himself capable of. *Survival* ***was*** *above everything else.*

He rapidly looked to the side a few times, checking for a quick solution for a successful escape. Sadly his only option was a large shrub to his right. A disapproved grunt and he launched himself and the remains into the bush. The shrub was big enough to cover his upper torso, but not his backside. But there was no reason that this human would have to look over the shrub at this time, so he deemed it *safe* enough. He'd just wait for the menace to walk past him, nice and simple.

The figure was walking directly past his line of sight now, the all too familiar whitish-grey sneakers registered in a far part of his brain. It was as if a sudden floodlight had been forced upon him, leaving him frozen on the spot. His abnormally hot body temperature dropped to freezing cold and his body ceased any motion, even his heart seemed to stop for a few seconds. A sense of internal panic began to overtake him, holding his heart and breaths hostage. The pressure was so intense that he swore his ribs were about to pop through his fleshy outer coat, or worse, that his lungs would burst at the seams.

The wolf *recognized* this figure, though he couldn't see the crimson eyes he just *knew* soared just above the foliage. He unintentionally let a growl seep out of his throat right as the blonde was passing by. *Of course*, the bastard above him just had to have froze at the sound. The blonde tyrant seemed to be searching for something deep within the darkness but remained completely silent as he did as much. Something the wolf would have praised him for, had it been anyone but the ever-frustrating blonde, that was always above him. No doubt this jerk would be the *sole* survivor of any horror movie, he was much *smarter* than the average bear after all. That just made him even more *dangerous*.

The beast bit the inside of his mouth, his tongue thrashed impatiently across the darkened plum roof of his mouth. He held his breath no matter how pointless, an innate and instinctual reaction to the other's teen's startling appearance. He knew the other wouldn't be able to hear regardless of his efforts at remaining silent, no human without a heightened sense kind of quirk had the capability to hear such silent signs of life. But an instinctual habit encouraged him to do so anyway. This blonde was just as dangerous as he, but for an entirely different reason and that was enough to cause the wolf to sober up in an instant.

With the bloodlust long since passed and the anxiety levels rising, the wolf nearly fled, wishing for nothing more than to break out in a dead sprint back toward his den. But doing so would expose himself and that was something both sides of the wolf agreed to avoid wholeheartedly. This foe was no easy adversary and had enough power with his words alone to break them. *A weakness*. One that he was growing towards snuffing out at the first chance given. Even a *single* weakness could result in the *loss of life* and that was not a bet he would **be** willing to make any time soon. ***Survival*** *was all that mattered.*

The figure gave the surrounding area a few more seconds before he lost interest. A disgruntled 'tch' and the whitish-grey shoes started to move in a direction opposite of the hidden beast. Although the threat was removed, he still waited. *Caution was an important friend.* As the footsteps grew smaller and less dense, the beast lay in wait, not willing to risk a hasty escape if it wasn't 100% guaranteed to work in his favor. Another minute and the footsteps were at a distance far enough away that the beast was confident enough to leave the shelter of the bush.

Hastily, he gathered up the remains of his meal, doing a brief double-check of his surroundings and any other possible obstacles. Nothing to be found, *good*. The wolf gave himself a brief once over, pausing when he remembered the bloodied remains...*maybe leaving them in the bush was the best bet? I mean where would he put them back in his den anyway...* He dropped the bloodied pelt and stealthily crawled out from behind the cover of greenery, keeping a low profile with every step he took. A glance in the direction the figure wandered off to and the wolf could see the faint silhouette of them sitting on a swing.

The blonde's body sat limply on the worn and leathered seat, listlessly rocking back and forth with his head held up to the sky. He was simply staring with eyes filled with a longing the wolf didn't recognize. His lips whispered a name that the wolf barely caught *'Deku.'* The wolf bristled, sneering in the direction with malicious intent that he hoped the other could feel. Though the ash-blonde seemed completely unfazed.

The wolf gave a low threatening growl and a last glance before he took his leave. Maybe the reason the blonde hadn't felt the heated gaze, was because *secretly* there was no true malice in his sneer, *only* a deep-rooted sadness. But if one were to look for it deep within his turquoise pools they'd never find it. It was far *too* deep in the seafoam ocean to correctly discern and he planned *to keep it that way*. It would all be over if someone else noticed that he held no **true** *hate* for the stupid blonde.

"What an idiot you are Izuku."

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Prelude 04: Some Days I Just Feel Like Dying

Chapter Summary

More strange habits and feelings manifest in the Midoriya Household. The Bakugou's get suspicious and a sudden doctor visit later and everyone has more questions than answers.

Chapter Notes

~ Howdy! ~

Some of you may have noticed that I split the previous chapter and this chapter into two separate parts now! I know some of you may have also previously read parts of this chapter when it was still a chapter insert, but I just wanted to tell you that this is now the full chapter! I really want to apologize for that, before I had to post it before, as AO3 kept deleting and not saving everything I had written down for this chapter. Hence this shiet has been rewritten five times cries! Anyway, enough of my whining haha after careful consideration and lots of changes later I finally have this chapter complete and in a place, I am happy about! I hope you all enjoy and please let me know what you think so far and any theories/ideas you have for this story going forward! Thank you all for the support and patience!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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Prelude 04: Some Days I Just Feel Like Dying

Part 5 of 'The World In Which We Live'

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That next morning Izuku woke up to an alarming sight to behold, once again waking to blood coating his skin. Blood that he *instantly* knew ***never*** belonged to him, the blood of some other *life* form that he had apparently taken yet again. This time he didn't *cry*, instead, he made haste with removing the *offending* shirt covered in darkened blood that had long grown cold and stiff. His bloodied and tattered night shirt that read 'Sheets' was hurriedly thrown in the waste bin in the corner of the room, his hands shook as he did as much. This undeniable *evidence* of ***his*** crimes, this *physical* reminder left him *burned.* A constant *reminder* of what a *horrible* person he was ***becoming***.

The teen's first few breaths came out ragged and uncomfortable, as his grasp on reality started collapsing in on itself. His vision swam the more upset he allowed himself to get, static lines and livewire charcoal scribbles crawled across his vision, tainting his sight and poisoning his mind. He forced his eyes closed, no longer wanting to see the imperfect nightmares floating around his senses. His hands continued to shake as he clenched fingers deep into heated palms, small droplets of blood were drawn on all sides. The hasty breathing became slower over time as his heart rate decreased, and his breath was returned to him once again. Blinking several times to clear the remaining static livewires that remained, his eyes glimmered unnatural teal for a few steady seconds.

Without much thought and wanting nothing more than to seek out what brought him the most comfort, he focused solely on his mother in the living room. She was still deep asleep and his internal clock told him it was around seven in the morning, yet another early morning. The longer his focus remained honed in on her the more details he was able to pick up, the speed of her calmed heartbeat, the gentle gasps that would live her lips when as if she was surprised or attempting to talk in her sleep and the steady thrum of a million veins pumping vicariously deep beneath her skin. It was strange, absurd, and disorienting, but oddly calming, knowing he could so intimately hear the proof that she was sleeping so happily, that she was alive. It brought a certain peace to him.

Once awareness came crashing back to him and he didn't feel as if he'd fall over the minute his feet touched the floor he bolted. Izuku threw himself out of the bedroom as if his body was on fire, he felt his heart hammering in his throat and his eyes water in fear and regret. Though no tears physically fell. This tornado of emotions whirled strictly internally, his mentality decaying like a rotten corpse left out to bask in the sun for *far* too long. The trek to the bathroom barely ten feet down the hallway was torturous as the only sounds of his own suffering filled his ears like a raging and uncontrollable ocean. He felt guilty, he really hoped he hadn't been loud enough to disrupt his mother's much-needed rest.

He probably shut the bathroom door just a little too hard, or maybe it was simply Inko's motherly instincts becoming on high alert at the feeling of her son's sudden anguish. It was *unexplainable* and completely *instinctual* but Inko just knew Izuku was ***not*** *okay*. Izuku was too far in his own head to notice the shift. He was spiraling all over again. His eyes glanced at the large and glaring mirror before him. Upon realizing that something was terribly *different*, He felt his breath escape him at the sight of the ***imposter*** greeting his glare in the mirror. Inside the walls of the mirror stood a figure he could ***no longer*** *recognize*.

His features weren't the only thing that had morphed into something anew, sure that was *surprising* in itself. But the clear *lack* of baby fat in his face and the luminescent glow of teal with fiery golden

flecks wasn't too alarming. What truly *horrified* him was that unfamiliar *feral* and *devilish* glint that was lurking under the surface of his seafoam depths. The flecks of tattering golden stood to attention when the light caressed them in the most perfect of ways. The sight was breathtaking, leaving anyone who was daring enough to steal a glance in a frazzled haze. Previously untouched viridian pools were now filled with frigid teal that bled into the melting emerald, creating a beautiful and unnatural flurry of seafoam with golden freckles throughout. His large innocent doe eyes now appeared more defined and held a sharper edge to them, mimicking the presence of a feral beast hidden behind the forests of emerald and jade.

Beside his striking eyes and more developed features, a pained spread of anger and silent observation covered every shadow of his face. His once innocent and naive face looked more scared by the world than ever, he looked cautious and downright domineering. A hesitant gulp later and he tried to smile, testing the depths of these new and untraveled waters. The motion in itself caused a typhoon effect when the glistening white of near-perfect teeth with tiny muted fangs made their appearance. On any other day, he wouldn't have noticed, but here in this moment, he could see that his incisors held a stronger presence than ever before. They almost looked intimidating, if not a bit cute, having gained slightly sharper tips to them. The sight made his heart stutter as flashes of Kacchan's own perfect little fangs flooded him. That had always been one of the most alluring things about the blonde, though he guessed not even had the same appeal.

A startled huff later and he'd seen enough for one day. He threw open the shower doors open in a fit of terrified rage, aggressively pulling the faucet to the coldest setting possible. He hurriedly stripped out of his sweats before throwing himself headfirst into the icy alcove. The pipes groaned and wept as the freezing waters filled them to the absolute brim, Izuku ignored the sounds, intending to solely focus on the beating of his own heart. He just wanted to lose himself to the world for a time, he needed to recollect himself from the floor. He forced his eyes closed for several seconds as the water rolled down his back and left his unruly curls flattened and heavily waterlogged.

Memories of fresh and mountainous rivers from a time long passed entered his waking thoughts and filled his lungs with invisible fluid. After the sound of his own blood gushing from within him sickened him, he directed his focus instead on the waterfall encompassing him. As the faint scent of muted blood entered his other senses, his eyes snapped open, almost instantly falling to the pinkened water pooling at his feet. He squinted at the color, feeling a strange atmosphere overcome the small space.

A morbid fascination washed over him as he watched the pink-tinted water swirl around the drain in a mini whirlpool. He watched for what could’ve easily been hours as all the water swirled and swished at his feet. The water had long run clear, yet he still watched the drain with an intense focus. The scent of rabbit and now cold fur lingered, the smells causing his stomach to rumble in anticipation all over again. He felt that ***all-consuming*** type of *hunger* again.

He felt entranced and enchanted by the steady flow of water as clear as the river, the river he now vividly remembered stumbling upon in that mysterious forest. It had been beautiful, *so beautiful.* It

had tasted incredibly fresh and perfectly chilled, and the air had been aromantic and cleansed. He had felt *cleansed* just existing in the same space. Even the familiar sounds of nature bursting with life and vitality vividly stuck with him. *He wanted to* ***return.***

Feeling an urge overwash him he closed his eyes and focused on the memories, exploring them in depth the further he went. Flashes of bountiful trees, flourishing plants and leaves, the softness of the ground beneath his bare feet, the tearing of thick hide in his jaws, the scent of fresh blood and fur, and the dampness he felt within his fur as he rushed through a few dozen puddles as he ran so freely. *He had never felt so alive.*

“Izuku? Honey where are you?”

A voice whispered, reaching out to him from somewhere above the water. He ignored it until he heard the familiar *'Izuku'* again, the image of his mother's worried face entered his thoughts, at first she was smiling down at him so brightly, he was once again back to his four-year-old self. Then she was looking at him around the age of 12, they were the same height then, both were laughing so happily and with equally as silly faces. The next image was of Inko smiling so brightly at him, tears in her eyes as she looked up at him, he was older now, taller. She was whispering how proud she was of him and other things he couldn't quite make out clearly under the crashing waves of the tide.

The last image he saw was of Inko's smiling face as reality cut back and forth, she continued smiling so bravely even as blood coated her face and fell down her cheeks as she cried crimson. They were laughing, both of them before the sounds of guttural sobs being ripped out of Izuku's chest was all he could hear, all he could feel. He gasped. Izuku's eyes snapped open, and his trance suddenly lifted. He had been so encaptured by these memories, these feelings of freedom, that he'd violently startled at the sound of his mom’s voice. Not to mention those sudden and twisted memories... Those terrifying images his mind had force-fed him, for what reason he didn't know.

He was so caught off guard that he neglected to notice that he'd lost his balance from the sudden shock. Before he even had the chance to catch himself, he was already plummeting and slipping on the deepened puddle below his unsteady toes.

“ACK!”

He shouted as he went down, falling hard against the dense bottom of the tub. He painfully groaned a saddened whine left him shortly after. On the way down he’d hit his head pretty hard, enough that he already felt fuzzy. His judgment didn't seem to be doing any better, every one of his senses felt broken, hidden behind a hazy fog within his brain. The deafening crack and thunderous sound of bone meeting pavement had Inko bursting through the bathroom door in a second.

Once inside she gave a hesitant pause behind the closed curtain, fidgeting anxiously as she did. Izuku groaned and rubbed the back of his head, where the brunt of the fall had been. A hot and sticky substance covered his palm, and as he pulled his hand away to chance a peak at the severity of his fall, his stomach curled. His entire hand was coated in blackened crimson. He felt his eyes roll into the back of his head, too overwhelmed and too tired to keep them open.

“**IZUKU!** Did you fall? Are you okay?”

“T-towel.” He mumbled, his tongue feeling a bit too heavy in his mouth suddenly. His world was spinning, but he felt *too* tired to say as much.

“R-right!” Inko hurriedly thrust a clean towel through the shower curtain as soon as she heard the shower click off. Izuku’s vision teetered but he grabbed the towel, at least he hoped the blurred white blob was indeed a towel. He pulled the thing around his waist as quickly as his body would allow, but he felt a bit sluggish. He wasn't sure how successful he had been however as his body felt a constant breeze.

“Talk to me, honey. Are you hurt? Is anything broken?” Inko asked frantically, not liking how long it was taking her son to simply wrap the towel over himself.

“M-my head. T’ hurts.” He mumbled almost incoherently. Inko not being able to take it any longer tore the curtain back and cried out in shock at the sight that greeted her. Izuku was lying on his back in a clumsy motion with his right hand lazily holding his head while the other was lying limply at his side. His towel was loosely wrapped over his midsection, just barely covering himself, while a pool of blood freely flowed down his neck and shoulders. The blackened crimson blood was heavily flowing and pooling around her son's stilled figure.

“OH MY GOD IZUKU! YOUR HEAD!”

She screamed rushing over to his side, frantically looking for something, anything to stop the bleeding. A peach-colored hand towel caught her eye, she snatched it up and held it up against her son’s rapidly bleeding head. The blood flooded into the peach, Inko noted that the crimson was *so dark* that it was nearly as black as tar.

She recalled that blackened blood was a *very* terrible sign. It only appeared in critically ill patients and generally was caused by deceased oxygen saturation, meaning he wasn’t getting enough oxygen in his bloodstream. She started to panic, but scolded herself for being unhelpful, she needed to keep the pressure on the gushing wound.

Izuku’s blood didn’t seem to be clotting properly either and his blood flow seemed almost infinite. Inko had tears threatening to stream down her cheeks but bit her lip to keep focus, drawing blood as she did. Her son’s pupils were wide and unfocused, a blankness filtered through them. The sight utterly *terrified* her. *She feared she was **losing** him all over again.*

“Izuku I need you to very slowly get up for me. Do you think you can do that?” Inko pleaded, her voice low and growing hoarse with worry. He looked at her blankly for a good minute before he responded by slowly standing up, nearly toppling over as his foot caught on the spilled blood at his feet. Though Inko was quick to notice and caught his shoulder a second before it was too late. She held him as tight as possible as she helped him to regain some semblance of balance.

“That’s very good Izuku. Everything’s going to be okay sweetie, I’m going to take you to the hospital.” Inko said slowly, holding the boy to her side to act as an anchor for both of them.

Izuku seemed *very* out of it and unresponsive, Inko herself was barely holding it together. They slowly made their way into the kitchen, she guided him to the nearest seat. After he was gently

seated and didn’t look like he was about to topple over she grabbed his right hand and forced the bloodied peach towel into his hands. She guided it to the still bleeding wound, adding a little pressure to both the towel and his hand to show him what to do.

“Izuku honey I need you to hold that right there while I get you clothes. Whatever you do, don’t move around okay? I promise it’ll just take me a minute.” Inko was already rushing out of the room and beelining towards his dresser before the entire sentence was finished.

Without looking she grabbed a pair of basketball shorts and a random top, rushing back to the dining room. Thankfully Izuku was still sitting upright and even looked a little less deathly pale. A light pink had returned to his cheeks, but his eyes were still unfocused and his gaze lifeless. Or maybe just distant, Inko couldn’t quite tell the difference. Inko gulped, gently encouraging him to stand up again, he did so all but very slowly and stiffly. She held him against her, shoulder to shoulder for support as she opened the door to their apartment.

It was freezing cold outside she noted but pressed forward with little care. The distance to the Bakugou residence was short and she knew they’d be able to make it there. At least she was hopeful. Izuku’s condition seemed to finally be stabilizing but that didn’t mean he should really be up and walking when his skull was split open like a split-open watermelon. She swallowed her guilt of forcing him to move, knowing it was the only way to get him to the nearest hospital quickly. They didn’t have a car of their own, but the Bakugou’s had two and she honestly didn’t trust herself to drive them safely.

Surely Mitsuki would know what to do when they arrived, she'd dealt with her own fair share of split heads with Katsuki and his overly adventurous childhood misendeavors. Not to mention Mitsuki was much more of an action-than-feelings kind of person, she'd keep a level head much better as well, even if she was explosively loud. Inko really needed that rock-solid support of her best friend right now. She was shaking too violently to drive and her heart was beating so loud that she feared she'd need to check herself into the hospital right alongside Izuku.

Inko nearly cried when they finally reached the front porch of the Bakugou residence, never before had she seen such a beautiful and welcoming sight. Immediately she started slamming her palm against the door, calling out for Mitsuki to hurry and open up. A few colorful curses could be heard shouting something about ‘who the fuck dares to disrupt my beauty sleep.’ The large glass and wooden door was thrown open with aggression, as the still half-asleep disgruntled blonde answered.

“Who the fuck is bothering me at this hour, huh?!” She growled looking over the porch before her carmine eyes fell on Inko and her very bloody son. She gasped, her half-lidded eyes nearly popping out of their sockets at the sorry sight of the two viridian-haired wrecks on her porch.

“HOLY SHIT! Inko what the hell happened!? OH MY GOD is that Izuku!?” She shouted out in shock.

“Mitsuki please, I promise to explain but *please* drive us to the nearest hospital. I-Izuku’s lost a l-lot of blood and I-I d-don’t know what to do anymore.” The short woman sobbed, finally breaking down at the sight of her best friend. She couldn’t be strong any longer, but she hoped that her lifelong friend could be the stronger of them right now and take action.

“I-I Yeah, I’ll get the car keys.”

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The ride to the hospital had been *hellish*, filled with despairing silence and nervous electricity buzzing off both women. Izuku was ‘awake’ if you could really call it that, he was looking at the roof of the car with a dazed look bared in his eyes. Inko noted that he hadn’t even blinked in the last five minutes, just dully staring at something only he could see. Mitsuki was shocked into silence for once in her life, carmine eyes flickering back and forth between Izuku and the road. She carefully watched for any changes through the rearview mirror, as she raced through red light after red light. The night was long and dark.

They arrived at the hospital not even five minutes later. Once they arrived a nurse was already gliding toward them with a wheelchair in hand. They loaded the dazed teen into the seat while Inko did her best to explain what had happened and what she’d already done up to that point. The nurse nodded, as another started wheeling Izuku away to be assessed and hopefully helped. Inko and Mitsuki were told to wait for further instructions and to do their best to remain calm in the nearest waiting room.

Two hours passed by with no word of her son’s condition, and no words passed between the two best friends either. Just silence as each was lost in their own thoughts and conflicted feelings. A few nurses would come out with startled looks on their faces, whisper something to the other nurses on

hand, then the receptionist where they'd all share a horrified and concerned look on their faces. Each time it happened both mother's stomachs would plummet even further.

Somehow Inko just *knew* they were talking about her son, her Izuku senses were tingling. The nurses would always be sure to keep their voices down, leaving any potential eavesdroppers completely in the dark, much to Inko's chagrin. The universe was actively working against her tonight and for the love of whatever god she just wanted to know if her son was still breathing. For all, she knew he could *already* be long since placed in a body bag. The constant *'what if's'* were terrifying.

It wasn't until another hour later that an actual doctor *finally* emerged. He had a look of deep confusion knitted across his brow. Inko's heart dropped even deeper to the floor if possible, he didn't appear to be bringing good news with him and that was more than a little alarming. He looked up from his clipboard, scouring the room for someone. *For them.* Chocolate eyes met emerald. After a second or two a look of recognition entered his toffee eyes. Inko's voice hitched as unwelcome nerves came back with a heated vengeance.

She gulped, not realizing the loud rattling she was causing as the metal chair scraped the concrete beneath her feet. A soft and delicate hand wrapped itself around her own, Inko flinched and looked to the side to see Mitsuki offering her best supportive face. To anyone else, it would no doubt look like an unhappy scowl but to Inko it was obvious that she was just as worried for Izuku.

"Ms. Midoriya?" A low and honeyed voice called out of the blue. Inko didn't have to look up to know who it had come from. But looking at him right proved to be a difficult task, she was far too worried about what his face would tell her before his words could form.

"It's okay Inko. You aren't in this alone." Mitsuki whispered giving Inko's hand a comforting squeeze, her voice hoarse from stress, but gentle in tone. A rarity among the Bakugou's.

It was calming and gave Inko enough strength to bring her eyes up to the young doctor. She would not allow herself to break again until she knew what was happening with her son, he always took priority over everything else, including her own emotions.

"Right…That's me." Inko piped up in her best customer service voice.

"Ah, I thought so. You and your son do look *quite* alike. Anyway, my name is Doctor Waybranch and I'd like to first apologize to you Ms. Midoriya. Leaving you in the dark for so long was not

very kind of us.” The young name gave a curt, yet courtesy bow. Inko’s eyes widened, as did Mitsuki’s.

“M-my son is he okay?” Inko whispered, hesitantly wanting the answer but also deathly afraid of what it could be. The man’s toffee eyes lit up, but his eyebrows knitted in that same confusion again.

“Your son is fine, his injury is no longer a concern of ours. *However*, his condition itself does have us a bit concerned and rather confused if I am completely honest.” He hummed tapping his index finger to his cheek, lost in thought.

“What do you mean his injury is no longer a concern but his condition is? I don’t understand that seems contradictory.” Inko cried, her voice cracking in the middle. Mitsuki’s hand froze up against her own.

“Ah about that…would you mind coming with me. I’d like to show you something and go over a few things." He paused, his eyes meeting carmine. "Both of you are welcome to follow.”

Inko and Mitsuki looked at each and nodded in silent agreement. They stood up, still holding the other's hand in quiet support as they followed after him.

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The hallway was a blinding white, feeling endless the further within the corridors they got. The flooring was a light grey title that blended with the bright white and the scent of disinfectants and other medical fluids wafted throughout the entirety of the halls. The whole place gave a feeling of claustrophobia and Inko started twitching in discomfort. The doctor didn’t say anything else as they walked, though Inko could feel the tension rolling off her best friend's shoulders. She obviously felt just as uncomfortable as she did about this place. Some ominous sinking feeling followed them with each turn, the space frankly felt dangerous and unnatural. It was almost haunting how quiet and lifeless it was back here. Did they not have other patients?

Or was it always as quiet as a morgue here? Inko really wasn't sure she wanted the answer to that specific question.

Eventually, they arrived at a room, much to everyone's immediate relief. Dr. Waybranch opened it quickly with his identification card. He held the door open for them and gestured for them to enter. They did, taking a seat on the two grey chairs in the room. Just like the hallways, the walls were a blinding white, and the same grey tile floor with the exception of a portrait of a red *Lycoris radiate*, otherwise infamously known as the *'Spider Lily.'* The flower of death and rebirth, clearly a questionable design choice, but who were they to judge?

The metallic silver of the exam bed glistened under the LED fluorescent lights and the soft yellow glow of a computer screen could be seen. On the X-ray scanner, lay what had to be twenty or so images, though they were impossible to identify seeing as how many were overlapping each other.

"Ms. Midoriya first I am going to ask you a few questions, please answer them as honestly as you possibly can. I apologize in advance if some may come off as insensitive or offensive."

"O-okay I'll do my best." She spoke up, more than a little confused and slightly intimidated by just what this doctor had in mind to say such a thing.

"Very well. Thank you for your cooperation. My first question would be, *is your son truly quirkless?* "

"**Yes**, Izuku has been quirkless since he was a baby, though we didn't find out until he was four."

"Very interesting and he's *15* correct?" The doctor asked, not looking up from his clipboard, his pencil scratching at the paper.

"**Not quite**, he will be in July."

“Oh, I see, my mistake. How *strange* indeed. Do you know if he’s recently started puberty or went through a *sudden growth spurt* ?” He hummed, pulling his bottom lip between his teeth, deep in thought. Inko had to pause and think about how to answer that question.

“**Well**, I can’t be sure, but I just realized that he has seemed to have grown an inch or two since I last saw him two weeks ago.” The doctor stopped scratching pen to paper and looked up.

“Two weeks? Was he staying with someone?” The doctor asked, the wheels clearly turning in his head.

Inko’s form crumpled and Mitsuki rubbed her back in comforting circles as she shot a fierce glare at the doctor, he gulped but didn’t show any sign of changing the question. He needed every tidbit of information he could get after all. She growled under her breath, seeing as Inko was one word away from sobbing like a newborn again, Mitsuki took over the questions for this round. It wasn't like she didn't know the answer to most, she and Inko had raised Izuku together along with Masaru. He was as much her brat as he was Inko's.

“Izuku *had* been missing for two weeks. No one saw him and while I don’t know what he told Inko, I do know that he just came home a night or so ago.” The doctor's eyes widened and then he started viciously scribbling on the paper again.

“I see. I am sorry for being so insensitive, but if what you just said is true then that could very well be the cause for *everything* we have noticed.”

“Are you going to keep asking us shitty questions or are you finally going to explain what the fuck is going on with ***our*** boy?” Mitsuki snapped, having thought herself patient enough. She did her best to behave, but now she was growing pissed at this insensitive quack, mixed with her extreme worrying and she was done waiting around with bated breath. She wanted some fucking answers already.

The small unimpressive man jumped out of his skin, nearly cowering at her stern and angered tone. He readjusted his large round glasses and cleared his throat. He looked back at the small woman barely holding herself together and a look of empathy crossed his face. He sighed and pulled the clipboard back into his lap.

"I need to ask two more questions before we move forward with your son's medical report. The more questions get answered the better equipped I and this hospital can be to help *properly* diagnose your boy."

"Please bear with it just a little longer, I promise there is a reason for so many seemingly irrelevant questions." The man paused looking down at Inko and locking eyes with her, waiting for the go-ahead. She blinked away tears and gave a stiff nod, he continued and Mitsuki quietly grumbled beside her.

"To your knowledge has Izuku ever had any allergies or come in contact with any potentially dangerous poisons or toxins? I know he has been…away for two weeks, but in his time back have you noticed anything rather strange about his behaviors? It could be something as large as not enjoying things he previously did or as minor as scratching at his skin?" The doctor encouraged, tapping the pencil against his chin in a thinking manner.

Inko thought deeply, repeating each of his questions in her head. A few red flags came to mind at his words. Ones she'd previously ignored because she was just thrilled to have her son back home…but now if these new behaviors have anything to do with his condition she'd properly dissect each behavior this time. A look of determination crossed her face.

"Izuku has *never* had any allergies before, *however* after returning home I noticed that he kept sneezing whenever he got too close to flowers, heavily scented or not. The same thing with cinnamon, he'd sneeze once or twice and then grimace while cupping his nose as if he was in pain. I didn't think much of it, because it's pollen season, but *now* looking back he's never been affected before so he *shouldn't* be now either."

"I see. *Fascinating*, a heightened awareness of certain scents, particularly strong ones I assume. But maybe more than those, maybe his *sense of smell*, in general, has *increased* …" The doctor

mumbled under his breath, aggressively scribbling down each of Inko's words like scripture, adding his own notes and observations as he went.

"Anything else?"

"**Yes**, several actually. Izuku's always been a late riser, I'd have to fight him tooth and nail to get up in the morning usually. But now he seems to always be up and wide awake before me and I, myself wake up early. We're talking like four or five in the morning, maybe even earlier I'm not sure exactly. I get up around six or seven, but Izuku is just always up and already showered these days. It's strange, cause I don't see him sleep early or late either. Really I don't think I've seen him sleeping but once since he returned three days ago. And that was the *first* night. Despite that, he seems *full of energy*, more so than before even. He has always been a naturally energetic boy, but now it's almost like he's buzzing with unused energy."

"Hmm, not sleeping much but still wide awake huh? *Nocturnal and Diurnal maybe*? Boundless amounts of energy…"

"The last thing is well…I promised I wouldn't tell anyone but I feel like I need to, especially if it has anything to do with him being sick." Inko mumbled removing her hand from the blonde's, to fiddle nervously with her fingers. She could feel Mitsuki's stern glare to her right.

"Izuku…he…when he came back home he was covered in blood and I was extremely worried. I was ready to take him to a hospital right away but…after he washed the blood off I realized none of it had actually belonged to him." She paused, avoiding everyone's eyes as she steeled her resolve.

"Izuku was terrified and thought he had murdered someone, he couldn't remember anything that happened those two weeks. He still can't... so he says anyway. He didn't even know that he had even been missing for more than a day let alone two, nearly three weeks." Inko took a deep breath before she started up again.

“Though later he had a flash of memory return and he realized that he hadn’t hurt anyone, well any *human*. He ***however*** confessed that he recalled brutally killing a deer in some forest he couldn’t remember. That was all though.” Inko finished feeling incredibly guilty for ratting out her son’s dirty laundry but maybe this all was *connected* to some bigger picture. This doctor seemed to have a better idea of what was happening to Izuku than she did anyway. And he seemed reliable enough. She couldn’t be sure, but maybe a doctor could shed some light on it for them.

“This deer …did your son tell you anything else? For example **why** he *did* it or...what he *did* with its corpse?” He hummed, not looking surprised in the least. Mitsuki looked confused and mildly concerned but said nothing.

“I-I uh I don’t think so, but he did tell me that he himself had no idea why he did it. Izuku said that something *inside* of him, an *instinct* of sorts *overcame* him and before he knew it he had already killed the deer.” Inko finished with a sad sigh.

“Thank you very much Ms. Midoriya for your honesty. It’s very clear that your son is your world and that you are incredibly worried about him. While I can’t promise you that everything’s going to be alright right away, I can say that your son is alive and well, more than well actually.” He reassured an amused smile reaching the corner of his lips as if he was recalling something that truly fascinated him

“But before I take you to see him I’m going to go converse with a few colleagues of mine about this new information. I will return shortly.” Inko sniffled at his words, Mitsuki released a breath she had been holding for who knew how long and the doctor gave them a small supportive smile before he left the room with a small wave.

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“*Fuuuuuck*, that was crazy.” Mitsuki drew out, slumping in her chair. Her eyes lit with a new fire as a look of bewilderment overcame her crooked figure. “Did your brat *really* take down a deer with his bare hands?”

“Yeah, he felt so *horrible* that he even started making a grave for the poor creature.” Inko sighed, following Mitsuki’s lead of melting into the floor. The stress of the evening really was overwhelming.

“What a sap. Of course, he would.” Mitsuki smirked, a mischievous, yet thoughtful smile crossing her features under the blinding white light.

“Yup I raised him right, didn’t I?” Inko asked looking over to meet the familiar carmine. Mitsuki gave a devilish grin.

“You raised a damn fine brat. Don’t ever let him *not* be a sap. Sappy men are a diamond in the rough, I still can’t believe someone like me could find some sappy ass like Masaru.” Inko hummed in agreement, closing her eyes to rest before they shot open.

“*Oh god* did you tell Masaru you left?!” Inko shouted suddenly very worried for her best friend's life. Masaru was unforgiving, a literal devil. It was always the quiet ones that are the most dangerous afterward.

“*Ah, fuuuuuuck* … **I forgot**. He’s gonna kill me.” Mitsuki growled, slapping a hand over her face.

“Don’t worry I’ll come to your funeral, right after my own.” Inko cried, giggles overcoming her. Mitsuki sighed dramatically.

“Good, at *least* you know he’s gonna kill you first. Especially when you kept Izuku from him. Not *very* smart of you Greeny.”

“I think we’re going to need that grave Izuku’s working on, for ourselves. Glad I’m not the one that has to call him. You’ll face the wraith first and that’ll give me enough time to run and hide from the lion that is your husband.”

“**God dammit**, he’s gonna be *so* pissed I don’t even want to go home. That damned brat is gonna be just as pissed as his dad too.”

“Ah poor baby, having people that love you is *so difficult* isn’t it?” Mitsuki just sulked and gave a spiteful growl.

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Once Dr. Waybranch returned thirty or so minutes later everyone had a hell of a lot more questions than they did before. Twenty-plus photos of varying x-rays of bones and muscles filled the lit-up board in front of them. There were many shots of various locations and varying shapes, many that looked *absurd* and *abstract* to anyone who was certainly no doctor. Inko was no *such* doctor, nor had she ever been interested in the medical field.

Staring at these images was the equivalent of staring at a bottomless ocean with a tiny flashlight. She had *no idea* what she was looking at. The only thing she somewhat understood was that for some reason the doctors had really focused on capturing her son's spine. She counted at least thirteen photos alone relating to the spine and everything surrounding it. Mitsuki *on* the other hand was growing moderately more horrified the longer she looked over the images. If *these* were what she thought they were, man were they *fucked*.

How was one supposed to fix so many disjointed and misshapen bones within one small teenage boy's body? How was he even alive?

Mitsuki's heart was beating loudly in her throat, to the point she felt as if someone were strangling her with their bare hands. She reached out to gently stroke a few of the images, shaking more with each image her fingers grazed. Despite her inner panic, she kept her cool from an outside point of view. *Well*, until she reached the varying image's labeled ‘Izuku’s spine.’ She had to do a double-take with those ones, as she thought herself to really be losing it. Blinking about a dozen times and pinching her skin a few hundred times before she truly let herself *believe* the *curse*d imagery. In the location of the boy’s spine sat *something* that looked straight out of a horror film. It looked *foreign*, *alien* even, and damn did it look razor *sharp*.

The spinal cord looked *abstract* and *disfigured* in such a menacing way. The lumbar vertebrae, rather than a dull knot were spiked and jagged, jutting out in ways that Mitsuki was reminded of a ***centipede***. Not only *were* all the vertebrae misshapen, but they seemed to wrap around the torso much more than any human spine could possibly. The bones almost appeared *lively* and *flexible* in ways no *human* bones *ever should.*

If that *all* wasn't frightening enough as it *was*, how *excessively* long the vertebrae were. They were so elongated that she swore they looked reminiscent of a tail. She was *positive* that some of the bones shown in these e-rays could only be found in *canine skeletons*. Caudal bones were then connected to a thin tailbone that got increasingly smaller the closer to the spine's end they got. The spine itself seemed to fall under the pelvis and was **very** *inhuman* in appearance.

" *What the actual fuck.*"

She finally breathed, a gasp leaving her at the same time. Inko jumped and brought her attention to whatever it was that had Mitsuki so rigid. The doctor didn't seem shocked in the least. Mitsuki's crimson eyes were bulging out of her sockets in an exaggerated panicked state. She didn't know how to make heads or tails of this crazy shit laid out before her. She wished it was all a nightmare, but the constant smell of chemicals told her otherwise. This young doctor even had the nerve to look amused by her reaction. Inko on the other hand was just confused.

"What is it?" Inko asked meekly from behind her, oblivious to any of the obvious red flags in her son's many x-rays. She had *never* been a woman of science, she'd always been more of a liberal arts type of person.

"I'm guessing you see the main issues here as well?" The doctor gave a brief pause, continuing after he saw Mitsuki's stiff nod.

"That's pretty incredible most people have no idea what they're looking at when I flash these bad boys." The young man smirked, jutting a finger out towards the illuminated board.

*"I still have no **fucking** clue **what** I'm looking at.* There's *so much* extra *shit* that doesn't *even* belong in a human body. I don't know what the fuck to think." She growled in frustration, her go-to response when feelings of intense fear or vulnerability enveloped her. The doctor gave a considering sigh.

"Yeah that's the problem, *neither do we* ." The doctor pushed off the wall and walked over to the two women, who were intently looking at the strange x-rays.

"You see this, right here there's the implication of a tailbone. That's probably the *least* concerning thing compared to all the extra bones. There are *eight* extra phalanges, shared between both hands and feet, *two* extra joints on each to be precise. Though it looks like the toes are now *three* extra joints compared to the fingers. This is explainable, probably the only thing. It's naturally because Mr. Midoriya is quirkless, *hence* he *naturally* has an extra joint or two in his toes." Dr. Waybranch continued, pointing to each location and bone misplacement as he went with his stick.

"Then we have the *most* **concerning** and downright *horrific* sight of the spine. As you could probably see the spinal cord is **heavily** misshapen, and the disk placements are all wrong. We even counted a full *eight extra* disks hiding in there. And that's not *even* counting the ones in this supposed 'tailbone' he seems to be developing." He paused again, briefly meeting both women's eyes before continuing.

"The *sharpened vertebrae* …we truthfully have *no idea* why they became like this. Or really ***how*** they could even possibly change so drastically without having *killed* Mr. Midoriya by puncturing not only his flesh but any internal organs." Inko's knees buckled at his words, and as she fell, Mitsuki caught an arm with the Dr. catching the other before the green-haired woman could fully collapse and risk injuring herself. They made a collaborative effort and pulled her back to her feet as she then quietly sobbed into her best friend's sturdy shoulder.

"This was one of our **biggest** concerns, *however* upon numerous tests, we found that he is completely healthy. All organs, veins, arteries, and muscles are intact and functioning at surprisingly the *highest* optimum possible. It's really a medical wonder *how* **all** this works, but somehow it *does* ."

“I honestly can’t explain any of this through medical terms. *What* I can say is that ***this*** is nothing short of a miracle. The mere fact that Izuku Midoriya is still alive and so healthy at that with such bothersome damage to his inner skeleton...er skeletons is truly *inconceivable*."

"Wait hold the fuck up! What do you mean by 'skeletons?" The blondeshe bristled. Inko flinched in her arms when the weight of the question hung heavily in the air.

"Ah, right, in our x-rays we also noticed that he has *nearly* a complete <u>double</u> skeleton within *his* ***own***. It seems impossible, but it's as if his body is harboring a whole *other body* within his ***own***. We don’t know what to *expect* or ***how*** to move forward with these discoveries but we *will* **do** our best going forward.”

“O-oh my god…how could this even *happen* …he was only *gone* for two weeks and he c-came back like *this* …” Inko sobbed into the blonde’s chest, she threaded her long emerald hair in her best attempt at comfort. "I just want to k-know what happened to my l-little boy."

“Ms. Midoriya I hate to hurt you more than I already have, but that is <u>not</u> all that we discovered in your son’s body.”

"How the HELL is there *even* <u>more</u>?"

“Y-you found m-more?” Inko whimpered, knowing her heart can’t take much more of this.

“Yes…We also discovered traces of toxins and acids much more fatal than twenty gallons of straight cyanide. Not to mention the implications of toxicity ranging at the highest levels. A Category 5 means that radiation doses are dangerously high and in most cases lethal. When ingested high doses of radiation can cause massive damage to organs, permanently disable those in contact, and in most cases kills whoever is unfortunate enough to come in contact with the substance. The exposed person loses white blood cells and the ability to fight infections. Even with treatment, most cases will still be fatal, when this happens the person may lose consciousness and die within the hour.” The doctor took a brief pause, locking eyes with Inko’s tear-stained ones.

“*However*, **despite** this Izuku is <u>not</u> ill and ***<u>only</u>*** became ill when we attempted to *treat* him for radioactive poisoning. It seems that removing the toxicity within him is what **truly** harms him. This is completely unlike anything we have ever seen.”

He sighed as he finished, Inko was too stunned to talk and Mitsuki was too busy trying to hold in her own tears at this man’s harrowing words. They hadn’t realized how *close* they had *truly* come to **losing** Izuku and the reality of it was *crushing*. Now he was alive...healthy even... *but at what cost?*

“Although we don’t have any complete answers and we can only speculate, my colleagues and I believe that perhaps this is a manifestation of Mr. Midoriya’s quirk. Though quite late and previously thought impossible...it's the only answer we currently have to even begin to explain all of this. Because of how volatile it seems along with the physical changes, we estimated that he must’ve gone through something truly terrifying and traumatic to ***force*** such a drastic *metamorphosis* of the body so *suddenly*.

"Though that doesn’t *quite* explain the many canine-like features found within these changes. Though we figure all will be revealed in due time.”

“D-does all of this mean that my s-son was brutally drugged? Was t-this all f-forced on his body by someone else?” Inko stuttered, her voice as wet as the tears cascading down her face. She absolutely **didn't** *want* to think *about* what that *could imply*.

“Well that had been one of our thoughts, but all of his tests came back negative on drugs, and bodily fluids not belonging to him, among other things. We can’t assume much, but we know that *whatever* happened to your son it wasn’t caused by another *human* .”

“I-I see. I s-should be relieved b-but I just c-can’t be. W-what if my son is in excruciating pain and I-I can’t do anything for him.” She cried, rattling the blonde's shirt in her raising panic, her grip growing into a death hold.

“There is no need to worry about that Ma’am, his tests showed no signs of pain. Besides some moderate itchiness and irritation of the skin that has been caused by incessant scratching at the spine and neck. Though we can prescribe four days' worth of painkillers just in case something else

comes up. It should hopefully help to ease your minds and is a necessary precaution in a time of so many uncertainties."

"*Oh thank god.*" Both Mitsuki and Inko breathed out, nearly melting into a puddle with relief.

"That brings me to our next point. Seeing as your son has *quite* the medical transformation happening, we'd feel much safer to keep him here for a few more days. Just to monitor him and ensure he isn't getting any worse. Though wounds seem to have little effect in his current state. Really his healing is *quite extraordinary* ." The doctor hummed with a thoughtful expression on his face. He was very intrigued by Izuku's condition, to say the least. There was just something so *invigorating* and *dangerous* about tiptoeing the line of the *truly unknown*.

"**Wait!** His wound **Oh my god** how could I ***forget*** about it! His head, he cracked it open and there was s-so much b-blood. Were you able to treat it?" Inko shouted suddenly remembering the very reason they had come here, to begin with. Realization entered the toffee eyes across the room before it was replaced with playful mirth.

"Oh yes thank you for reminding me, with *everything else* I had nearly forgotten. No more than ten minutes after you brought him in, his *entire* wound miraculously healed on its own. No need to worry, he no longer has any open wounds and certainly no internal bleeding. That *very* reason was *why* we had *first* started to run an assortment of tests, just for us to find out about ***everything*** *else*."

"The brat's entire wound healed? How is that possible his head was as split open as a damned watermelon earlier and you are sitting here tellin' me it's just *gone*?!" Mitsuki snarked in disbelief. The doctor let out a chuckle and readjusted his glasses.

"That's *exactly* what I am saying. His case is sure an *interesting* one. I'll give you both a few minutes to collect yourselves before I take you to his room. I know this must be a lot, but please know we are *here* to **give** you both all the support you need."

He gave a sincerely bright smile and a nod before he excused himself from the room. Both women sighed out the breaths they'd long been holding. *'A lot'* was a damned understatement, they both felt like they were going to combust from *nerves* and *fears*. Utter **exhaustion**, that's all either could truly feel at that moment. Relief and happiness could come later. For now, they just needed their hearts to stop thumping so aggressively against their ribcages.

"What a **fuckin** *shit storm* am I right?" Mitsuki sighed, throwing herself into the nearest chair and pulling Inko down in the one beside her. The blonde was trying to lighten the room in her own way, all but a bit rough around the edges. Inko appreciated how truly kind her best friend could be. She was beyond blessed to have her by her side. That Bakugou loyalty was something else, the literal meaning of one's 'ride or die.'

"You can say that again. I think I *need* to be admitted myself. This heart of mine is about to give out." Inko sniffled closing her eyes, feeling the complete exhaustion overtaking her.

"You and *me* both sister." Mitsuki pinched the bridge of her nose with the hand that wasn't holding Inko close. "I thought my brat was ***enough*** of a pain in the ass for both of us. And now here's **yours** in the spotlight. That little shit isn't gonna be much happy about that."

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(Early February)

Izuku's stay at the hospital was uneventful for the most part, besides the occasional yelling fits he was bared witness to, curtsey of one Mitsuki Bakugou and one slightly miffed Masaru. Not even his own mother was completely safe from the aggressively wound-up blonde. They weren't *true* fights of course. Rather Marsaru was upset over the fact that his wife *hadn't* called him sooner, let alone filled him in on her sudden disappearance act in the middle of the night. Fights with Inko revolved around Izuku's sudden reappearance and her lack of knowledge on the subject. They may have sounded *harsh* and *insensitive*, but that's just how the Bakugou family expressed themselves and how you knew they *truly* cared for you.

Izuku *truly* loved his aunt, his uncle, and his mother, but right now he was *quite* miffed himself. Between the *deafening* and *irritable* sounds of constant beeping, unwanted poking and prodding every ten minutes, and the ‘hungry’ look on that eerie doctor's face he was *very* much *over* this whole being tied down to the bed thing. His emotions seemed to be running all over the place, one second he was *fine* and *relaxed even*. Then in his *next* breath, he was fighting the urge to ***rip*** the face of anyone that dared look his way. The whiplash from said emotions was *exhausting*.

He just wanted the *voices* in his head to stop. Having the voices *outside* his mind stop though didn’t seem all that bad either. *He wanted* ***silence***. But then again he *alway*s **hated** the silence. *Everything* was confusing. Izuku didn’t even know what he wanted right now, especially when his moods were switching quicker than any light switch. *Maybe* he just wanted the whole world to *cease* motion. Or even better yet, for time to freeze and give him some *real* breathing room to work with.

His body *ache*d like never before, he was constantly in a state of being *pisse*d *off*, hormonal, and just downright frustrated with life. He wanted **to move**, to get *som*e fresh air for fuck’s sake. But seeing as he was *strictly* forbidden to leave his room and the hellish assortment of wires, needles, and a bunch of other medical junk attached to him like unwanted leeches, *he couldn’*t. The longer he stayed trapped here, the *longe*r he felt like a caged animal going feral. An animal that had *bee*n caged after living its entire life out in the wild, just to be forced behind silver bars the next.

He felt *devastatio*n like no other, a sense of complete and *utte*r loss, *ange*r. *Disappointmen*t and *grie*f for something that he knew he’d soon have in his grasp again. Though his heart erupted in pain the longer he was forced to stay, that sentiment felt *so* distant, *so* far away and out of reach. It was ***terrifying***. It hadn’t helped that *his ski*n was so disgustingly itchy that he wanted to downright fillet himself just to feel clean.

Hospitals were *disgusting* hotbeds of germs and disease. He could practically see the floating amoebas in the surrounding atmosphere and he felt like he was in his *wors*t nightmare. The **only** bright side to this whole ridiculous situation was that despite both his aunt and uncle being here nearly every waking minute, their troublesome son, his forbidden torch, was *nowhere* to be seen. The ash blonde either didn’t seem to *care* all that much that Izuku was back home, or he was **too** *cowardly* to walk in here and face him after everything. *Obviously*, Izuku knew it wasn’t the latter, the blonde cared about him about as much as a spec of dirt on his shoe. But at *this* moment instead of sheer disappointment, the green-haired teen felt *nothing* but inner peace. A sense of relief had bloomed in his chest and he wasn't about to *question it*. Maybe this was what 'moving on' looked like?

He should be happy about that right?

It was surprisingly a lot easier to deal with his fatal attraction when said teen was nowhere within his sights. With Katsuki not *tempting* him by simply breathing within his sight, like a dangling carrot, his chest felt just a little lighter, and boy was it a welcome change. Unlike everything else Izuku realized was changing around him, *this* **one** he all but welcomed with open arms.

Well, they would be open arms had his arms not been tied up in all different directions and weighed down by a trillion medical instruments. His situation was unfortunate, to say the least. He just wanted to get out and never come back already. He innately knew he *wasn't* sick. **Hell**, he was *floating*. Though it's not like when he told those doctors this, they did anything about it. They didn't even seem to believe him. Instead, they'd just look at him like he was some zoo attraction, a pet or specimen that only they could see. It was disturbing and uncomfortable. Everyone and everything was frustrating he realized.

He was so utterly *sic*k of the despicable scent of antiperspirant, sanitizer, and some weird-ass bags of mystery fluids that stunk of 'hospital' and narcotics. *Said* bags *that* were filling him up to the point he was feeling *bloated* and *overhydrated*. As if that was the end of it, **don't** even get him *starte*d on that smell of what he could <u>*only*</u> describe as *sickness*. It smelt of ***dea*th**, yet not as strongly, and was innately different, two distinct and varying scents he summarized.

The sounds of coughing and sickness filled the corridors, though they sounded so far away he could hear them as if they were coughing right next to his bedside. That really left his skin crawling, he hated sickness more than anything else. Diseases and a weak body were always some of his greatest fears, growing up and now. He guessed he'd learned to feel that way from none other than that explosive childhood friend of his, Kacchan had always been a bit of a germaphobe. He hated physical contact, sickness, weakness, and apparently him.

It was heinous, waiting around and simply lying in wait for something to happen. It made him feel very disgruntled and uncomfortable. The blinding white walls made him nauseous and he swore the longer he sat in this horrid room the more brain functions he lost. He felt like he was just *waiting* around for death to finally come and claim him. It had *only been* **two** days. He felt *clinically insane*. *And* ***maybe*** *he was at this point.*

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Katsuki *neve*r once came to visit Izuku during the entire five days he was held prisoner in those accursed white walls. And Katsuki ***sur*e** as hell *hadn'*t cried, **no** he *did not. M*aybe his eyes felt a little more damp than usual at times, but he *absolutely* **hadn't** cried. Well to Izuku's knowledge at least. In fact, Katsuki *had* visited, multiple times at that. Though when he did he *never* actually made it into the other teen's room, very unbakugou like he was afraid. He felt **guilt**. It suffocated him in an all-consuming chokehold, disguised as a blanket of warmth and comfort. It kept him up every night since the incident and during the day haunted his every waking thought, actively or subconsciously, Izuku lived rent-free in his mind. It pissed him off, but the thoughts prevailed regardless of what he wanted and soon he lost the will to fight the encroaching thoughts off any longer.

And most of all he **felt** *sick* with a bunch of feelings he **didn't** have the capacity to understand. He was *very* emotionally stunted and at times like this, it heavily showed. Not one to embrace anything new, let alone any emotions that made him truly *question* himself, Katsuki ignored these feelings and bottled them up. This sudden string of unexpected events had caused a lot of unpredictable emotions to bubble up within his stone-cold walls. Hence he *had* a frightening amount of *secrets* to **hide** away in the depths of his damned soul. *It was all Izuku's fault too*, and *fuck* it was always ***his*** *fault*. There was never any question about that shitty nerd and the influence he had on Katsuki, nor the shitty things *only* he could make the blonde feel. It was disgusting and frightening, a **weakness** he had no reason to pursue any type of relationship or future with. ***A distraction.***

This *distraction* held **too** much *powe*r. A power that Katsuki wasn't about to *ever* give to **any** shitty person. He fucking ***hated*** the nerd and that was the end of the story. The *one* he swore to himself and everyone else that would listen of course. *Was it the truth?* **Hell no**, but that revelation *wasn't* about to be discovered anytime soon, let alone see the light of day for as long as Katsuki *lived*. He'd take that fucking secret straight to the *grave*, along with that *horrible guilty pleasure* of his.

The thing about him *bottling up* every emotion he *ever* ***felt*** besides his default anger, was that he was *incredibly* more *fragile* than anyone would imagine. He was ***quite*** literally a ticking time bomb. He was one explosion away from *nuclear devastation*. So instead of reading into *anything*, he expresses himself through bouts of anger and hatred outwardly aimed toward *everyone* but **himself**. Because he was *positive* that if *anyone* were to *truly* look into his eyes, the depths of his soul they'd see how *disgustingly fragile he was.* They'd be able to see how much ***hate*** was aimed at none other than *himself* and that was a secret that no one could ever *know. Especially that fucking shithead Deku.*

Not ***even*** his nosy ass parents or that shitty Nerd knew his *dirty little secret*. *He made* ***damn*** *sure of it*. In his set goal, **no one** could *hold* enough power to **break** him. Never enough to ***ever*** *truly* bring him to his knees. *No* damned extras who *thought themselves* ***better*** than him, *no* villains would be able to pick a weakness from him and ***certainly***, *no* allies could hold any kind of ammunition

against him. The *reason* for such extremities was *simple*, you never know when **anyone** could turn on you, *allies or not*. **No one** *could* be *completely trusted* with such power. Not even his own parents, or the handful of people he admitted to *somewhat* caring for. He would never give himself away for such a ridiculous and frivolous reason. He ***wanted*** to be the number 1 hero *more* than anything else and he *wasn't* about to give the villains a ***weakness*** to exploit.

A *weakness* after all was a **weakness** and *having* any emotions that left him feeling *vulnerable* were fucking **useless**, a *real* waste of *his time*. He had better shit to do than cry over spoiled milk like fucking Deku did all the time. He was *going* to be #1 and heroes ***sure*** as hell didn't *cry* when the going got tough. Not once had he *ever* seen All Might cry, let alone any of the other extra B-lister hero-wannabees and he **wasn't** about to be the *first*.

Though despite his *misgivings*, Katsuki was ***still*** *human* at his core, and *humans* were ***fucking*** *emotional creatures* of habit. Three weeks without knowing the status of *someone you* ***knew***, *someone* you ***cared*** about was not easy no matter *how much* he brushed it off to be. Katsuki ***hated*** liars. *Hated t*hem more than *anything* else in the world really. To lie ***was*** to *betray* someone. Whether it was for *their* own *good* or not, he was ***disgusted*** by it. Katsuki was *honest*, *he said* ***what*** *he* ***wanted*** *and* ***did what*** *he* ***wanted*** with little thought of the *consequences*. His arrogance was a disease but was also his *first line* of ammunition in a fight because *words hurt a lot* ***more*** *than bullets.* He *knew* this a bit **too** well.

Katsuki was a *liar*. He *lied* to *everyone*, about *everything,* and most of all he lied to *himself*. He woke up every day, *just to* ***tell*** *himself* another shitty ***lie*** that somehow he has convinced himself to be **true**. He *lied* on a Wednesday, on Friday, on a Sunday, and on ***every*** *other* day of the year. ***Not*** *even* his dreams *were* saved from his lies. *Katsuki was honest*.

Katsuki just never realized how much of a *liar* he truly was and how *many* secrets he kept locked away. One of these *secrets*, one he'd sworn to ***lock away*** for the entirety of his days was coming *unraveled*. If this sudden change had been any indicator, his 'permanent lock' on this hidden chest was about to ***break***. It was *only* a matter of *time*, and *time was unforgiving*. No one would be spared in its wake. Certainly, Katsuki Bakugou was *no exception*.

One day or another he was gonna break the bows and all hell was going to come out to play. He *wasn't* **ready** for that day. *Really no one was*. Izuku's return was but one of the last straws that broke the *lying camel's back*. ***Karma*** was about to come take *her* pound of flesh and ***dammit*** he *wasn't ready for it.*

At the end of the day, Katsuki really really hated hospitals. They were disgusting and filled with so much unseen bacteria and sickness, and sickness meant weakness, of his mind his body and he was vying for number one, he couldn't take any type of risk when it came to his goal. And getting sick and allowing his body to feel weak was not a risk he would ever willingly take. His body was his strongest asset and without it in peak condition, he'd never get where he knew he was always meant to be. So visiting that shitty Deku in a hospital several times a day for three days, that was *disgusting* and so ***very risky***. Yet somehow he couldn't find it in himself to stop.

And that was the end of it, you'd never live to see him admit otherwise, because dammit Katsuki wasn't a liar ***~~to anyone but himself.~~***

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Izuku officially returned home three days later, *though* with the *promise* of Inko keeping a close eye on him and any ***changes*** he may experience. Ever since he's noticed a few new oddities within himself. His collection of misfortunes were only *growing* with *each* passing day. The ***most*** worrying being a carnal craving for flesh and a taste for *molten blood*. He wasn't *even* ***concerned*** about *what* unlucky creature it would come from if he was honest. It could be an animal or worse *human*. He *wouldn't* mind a ***taste*** of either...

Honestly, both sounded delightful. He was thirsty for the hunt, hungry for the thrill of freshly pumping adrenaline. Maybe he had grown *addicted* to the sensations of living *boundless*, free of the shackles of society, and long-passed the *line of morality*. Nothing ***else*** mattered, all he **knew** was that this constant *pull* at the back of his mind was going to be the *death* of him. The nightmarish phantom sensations of endless irritation were embedded deeply into his *very* flesh. It was all very *conflicting* for him. He was ***always*** *hungry*. *Starving* even, no matter how much meat he swore he consumed. *It was never enough.* ***Nothing was.***

His moods all felt *unstable* and ***dangerously*** *unpredictable* at the tip of a hat and without a moment's notice. His skin ached and had been scratched raw, it was just so terribly *itchy*, unlike anything he'd ever thought possible. He contemplated melting his own skin off at least twenty times a day. He felt as if a million ants were eating and tearing at his puny flesh, all the while feeling as if he were being burned alive from bathing in lava all at once. The insistent feeling of a colony of ants taking root within his flesh-covered crevices, marching along the tops of his

epidermis and leaving a bloody trail of melted flesh behind their microscopic toes. *Hell*, even the keratin under the surface cried out in bitter agony at the overbearing sensations. There was even a time he swore something was *squirming* right below his skin. The filthy beast was *mocking* his faltering sanity, of that much he was sure. It was *disgusting*. At *least* it *should've* been but *instead*, the feeling caused a *distorted purr* to rumble from deep inside his chest.

*He **was** disgusting*.

*And he fucking **loved** it.*

His own skin felt like the *enemy,* ruthlessly ripping and tearing him from the seams with its firey claws. Everything felt *traitorous*. It messed with his mind. He felt possessed by some fictional demon. In a split second, a horrid visual flew through his mind, as he remembered an alien movie he'd watched years back with Kacchan. After that passing thought appeared, he was ***convinced*** that he was *somehow* about to give birth to *some* alien babies *ripping* out of his chest cavity. Though *those* thoughts were fleeting when he realized *how ridiculous **he** was* being. Yet his body seemed to take all these *very* strange occurrences in stride and with a certain air of happiness to them, it was alarming but Izuku *chose* to ignore all *these* impending red flags in hope of savoring what *little sanity* remained.

He didn't notice any physical changes, at least any obvious ones. Then again he had become quite negligent of his body as of late, hence he was bound to miss a few things. One of them being how his teeth suddenly felt sharper or how his eyesight seemed to fluctuate between thermal vision and something else. His mental state however seemed to readily change in a very short amount of time. He found himself getting *increasingly* frustrated with *any* and *everything* for no real reason other than just being a raging *hormonal beas*t.

Doing what he did best, brushing constant problems in his life under the rug, a trait he acquired firsthand from his own mother, he continued to add to the growing dust mound he was oh so good at hiding away. He reasoned that *everything* that was *happening* to him was *pretty* **normal**, right? Puberty had never hit him all that hard so it was difficult for him to distinguish properly, but he assumed it had to be that. For that **reason** among *many* others, *he was an idiot*.

I mean what other reason would he have for wanting to rip his obnoxiously loud neighbors in two?

Do they not deserve it? *A small malicious voice whispered in his ear. A quiet mumble later proved he agreed with the voice.*

Or what about his sudden distaste for the smell of his favorite body wash and candles?

Nothing smells quite as nice as fresh ingredients. The *fresher* the better.

They were all just *so smelly*, *artificial* and it **disgusted** him more than it should. When his mother had lit one of her favorite candles, pumpkin spice, Izuku quite literally gagged as he fought off the urge to sneeze. He'd always enjoyed fall scents, but that all seemed to lie in the past now, *among other things*. He hated anything that smelled *faux*, even his own polyester shirts left him *disgruntled* and *angsty*. The textures all rubbed his *insanely sensitive* skin *over* the edge in the ***worst*** *of ways*.

He wanted to ***cry***, he wanted to ***scream*** and most of all he wanted to ***break*** something.
Knickknacks? His ugly closet? His potted plant close to his bedside? ***Bones*****?**

His mother's curling iron? ***A neck*****?**

If so who's?

That red racecar he'd insisted on keeping for no apparent reason other than because it once belonged to Kacchan? That cruel and condescending ***smile*** *on Kacchan's face whenever he looked at Izuku?* ***His neck****? Or* ***hers****? Anything…*

He was contemplating murder a lot more than he really should these days.

So what if that little rabbit was in the wrong place at the wrong time? How is that our fault?

That crimson spring was so beautiful, wasn't it iʁɯkɯ?

Don't you want to see it again ɨʐʊʁʊ?

It's just so beautiful.  is such a beautiful color, it's the color of life, the beginning, and the end.

He hadn't ever felt so out of sorts with his body, everything felt raw, completely foreign, and *unknown*. An *unsolvable* mystery, that Izuku just couldn't put into words. Worst of all was his constant feeling of being a stranger in his own *body*, his own *home*. These feelings of dysphoria were constant companions. They hang off him most nights as he just blankly stared at his dull ceiling, looking for something. *Anything*. An answer to all the problems he hoped for, but it never came. Something he could never distinguish. His guts twisted and turned, and his spine *tingled* and *squirmed* as if he was *harboring* a **second** being within his organic flesh.

It was *maddening*, ***euphoric*** at times, and *horrifying* at others. The world was confusing. *Confusion*. A word that Izuku wasn't unfamiliar with, he'd felt it a majority of his life, but this feeling of deep-rooted confusion was *different*. Just like ***everything*** else. He just wanted it to all ***stop***. This constant state of build-up left him wanting and craving for *something* more. As if preparing for something else that was *coming*. The sensation nipped at him like a bittersweet

sneeze that couldn’t come to full fruition. It was an antagonizing feeling, one that everyone dreaded and experienced in one form or another. For Izuku, instead of being a one-of-time thing, this feeling sat with him as a constant companion, a parasite in his midst. *It never wanted to leave.*

That was exactly how he ***felt***, he just wanted whatever was happening to him to hurry along and get all this suffering over with already. He’d never been one to pray, but in these moments he grew a bit despite to cling onto some greater power to help him through whatever was overtaking him. Though the answer he **sought** *wasn’t* exactly what he *thought* it’d be. This gift from the ‘gods’ was nothing more than a horrific curse.

His apparent rabid behavior really came to a head when an unassuming family dinner with the Bakugou's. At that point, even those that had been continually sticking their heads in the ground had to acknowledge that something was very wrong with Izuku. It really was supposed to be such a nice night, too bad fate was never promised to be easy.

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(Mid-February)

In celebration of Izuku's official return home, both Inko and Mitsuki thought now was a great time to pay a visit to that new restaurant downtown. The place was a bit on the pricey side, much to Inko's charging, but after continuous nagging from Mitsuki and her reassurances that dinner was their treat, Inko finally relented. It wasn't hard to disagree with the blonde when she reminded Inko that it was indeed her turn to pay for their little lunch dates anyway. They'd always made time for each other and brunch on Tuesdays, taking turns paying and choosing new destinations. It was a tradition that the two women had carried over since they were little high school students. Over the years it had become one of their special rituals.

Each family drove separately to the restaurant Mitsuki had *heavily* suggested, it was well known and had a solid five-star rating even though it was a new addition, known as 'The Crystal Peony.’ Normally they’d carpool and go shopping afterward, but throw three men in the mix and there was *no* car between the two families that would carry everyone. It was regrettable sure but not too big of a deal as it gave each family more time to prepare for the night anyway. Inko was dressed and ready within the hour, Izuku however was struggling with finding an appropriate outfit.

He doubted his poor humor would amuse anyone *besides* himself and maybe Masaru, let alone at this so-called 'fancy' restaurant. ‘Fancy shirt,’ was definitely not it. He knew as much but still became a ball of nerves just roaming his closet for *something* decent. Nothing was catching his interest and what might’ve worked was too small now. How he’d outgrown his fancy dress slacks in a mere year astounded him. *Was his ass really that fat? Or had he just gained more weight recently?* He didn’t think as much.

Actually, he swore he’d even *lost* weight and become less flabby recently, instead becoming incredibly lean, almost *inhumanly*. Though this didn’t bring any worry to his mind, maybe a little wonder but not any concern. He rather liked how nice his build had become, he wasn't sure how it came to this state but looking at himself in the mirror was a little easier each time now because of it. He still felt rather plain, maybe even a bit dull, but at least he didn't want to shatter the mirror when he caught sight of himself anymore. *Maybe, <u>confidence</u>* ***would*** *look good on him.*

Much to his embarrassment, the Midoriya family arrived at the restaurant nearly *thirty minutes late* courtesy of him and his *inability* to properly clothe himself. Once he’d gotten the nerve to actually ask his mother for help in his endeavors relating to all clothing matters. She came in like a true hero and called up Mitsuki, much to his ultimate *shame* and *relief*. She was sure to *use* this against him in the future but it was what it was. Katsuki was taller than Izuku by a good few inches, four to be exact, hence his slacks were longer. Mitsuki gave Inko a pair of Katsuki’s older slacks that never left the darkness of his closet until today. They fit nicely, *too nicely*. Izuku will never admit this out loud because he *absoulatly* was ***not*** staring at his ass in the mirror for a solid ten minutes. ***No way*** *was he that vain.*

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The night had started relatively normal, though gradually the evening grew *uncomfortable*. Once they all arrived at the restaurant and were seated, the group ordered pretty average dishes. Well until the waitress had reached Izuku that is, his order took every single one of them by surprise with his fugu. Never once had Izuku ever shown a hint of interest in such *unique* dishes, however, he'd made up his mind the second they'd stepped foot in the *baroque* establishment. A bitter scent instantly caught his full attention, he wasn't sure why it smelt so tantalizing to him but he knew he couldn't live without tasting this mysterious dish. As he'd discovered, this scent was of the house special, fugu, aka pufferfish a poisonous and rather prickly creature. It sounded perfect and Izuku was basically drooling as he told the waitress exactly what he wanted.

Both women had given each other questioning looks, just to shrug after a few moments. They figured Izuku just wanted to try something new, who were they to stop him from trying new things?

It was of course strange, but nothing too alarming. Maybe he'd gained a new palette over the years. Masaru instead gave Izuku a supportive smile, just simply happy to see his second son again. His disappearance had been hard for all of them and the reality that he was really home still hadn't been finally realized yet.

While Inko and Mitsuki talked about random things relating to the restaurant's decor, Katsuki aggressively sipped his water, his vermillion eyes solely focused on the green-haired boy across from him. It wasn't lost on Katsuki that Izuku *hadn't **once** <u>even</u> looked his way*, let alone tried to speak to him. *Not that Bakugou wanted that shitty Deku to annoy him...* but fuck he was acting weird and that bothered the blonde a lot more than he'd like to admit.

As the women admired the art and various sculptures, Masaru joined in with his own thoughts on the architecture. Izuku stayed nearly silent through the entire interaction, something that the other teen found incredibly *disturbing* and ***wrong***. Their parents all seemed to notice as well and attempted to add Izuku into the conversation, he'd say a few words and give a few curt thoughts before he returned to silence.

Chalking it up to being tired from everything that happened in the last few days, Izuku was given the space needed. Katsuki too remained silent aside from several murderous glares and animalistic grunts, in his typical caveman fashion. He too was left to his own vices. The blonde parted his lips a few times, as he wanted to say something but would stop himself each time. He even purposely made a few obnoxious sounds or gestures, subtle trying to get the other teen to so much as look over at him. To his frustrations Izuku never once looked over at Katsuki, he obviously heard the blonde but never fully acknowledged him, let alone at all. *It was really pissing him off.*

"Who the fuck does Deku think he is ignoring me?"

"Deku you finally mute or some shit?" Katsuki finally growled under his breath, not being able to hold his tongue back any longer. Izuku's viridian eyes glanced over to meet crimson, just to boredly look away without so much as a single word. That reaction *may* have ***snapped*** Katsuki's *last* straw of sanity.

Dinner with the entire nuclear Bakugou family for lack of a better word was tense. Izuku and Katsuki hadn’t spoken a single word to the other, let alone even glanced in the other’s direction for

more than a second or two. It was incredibly uncomfortable, causing both their families to notice and suffocate from the after blows of hostility. Izuku had been biting the inside of his lip the entire night, trying with all his might not to break another fork before this dinner was over. The first time had been an accident, but the second surely wouldn't be if Katsuki gave Izuku one more look of disgust.

Izuku wasn't sure *why* he felt so ***annoyed*** by Katsuki's presence tonight. Everything that Izuku felt was *conflicting*. These feelings were *so horrifically harsh*, *so fiercely critica*l, and *dangerously violent* that he worried he might do something he'd regret later. So instead of responding like he normally would or talking everyone's ears off, ***Izuku for once in his life was Silent***. In his silence, he wallowed in these traitorous thoughts, ones he previously thought were completely *inconceivable* for him to ever have to face. He tried to distract himself in those beautiful rubies, the ones that always made him want to pull the other boy into his arms and kiss him fiercer than any storm. Though he found no *sweet relief*, he realized that he ***wanted*** to ***do*** *nothing* more than *strangle* the boy in front of him.

As he looked into those fiery irises, his ***own*** reflection staring back at him he felt ***enraged*** like never before. For the first time ever, he wanted nothing more than to ***hurt*** Katsuki Bakugou. *Sure somewhere* under that *molten* **anger** was a *freezing* **hurt**, but its shape and feeling were irrelevant to him. He *didn't* wish to touch on *that feeling* anymore. He'd **felt it** for *so many* agonizing years, *so why should he allow himself to continue to suffer from it now?* He could still be *civil* and put on that *fake* smile everyone seemed to adore, but deep beneath that smile lurked something *incredibly dangerous* and *monsterous*. A part of *himself* that would *soon* see the light of day, whether he liked it or not. *This creature* ***was*** *far from patient.*

Sure there had been times in the past when he'd been frustrated with the blonde, but this ***felt*** like *something else*. It was *as if someone else was controlling his emotions*. He *was* but a mere puppet without the ability to speak or move on his own. All he **wanted** to do right now was eat this delicious-smelling dish and go home and take one hell of a long nap. He just hoped he could get through ***this*** dinner without *killing* someone.

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He wasn't sure why he was so pissed and losing every strand of sanity he had left. All he knew was that *beneath his skin something* was aggressively *squirming* and *begging* to come out and 'play' every time the fierce blonde sent him a certain look. Eventually, Katsuki grew **more** and ***more*** frustrated, leading him to start quietly antagonizing Izuku, starting with a few subtle kicks under

the table followed by angry one-liners the longer Izuku ignored him. Izuku had to grit his teeth more than a dozen times. The taste of his own metallic blood greeted him after he'd bitten his lip a bit too hard one too many times.

As time passed Izuku too, grew *more* and ***more*** fed up with Katsuki and started giving the other teen his own murderous glares, even going as far as snarling a few times. It was completely out of character for the sunshine boy and their parents were left speechless. The tension steadily grew, to the point the surrounding area was blanketed in a treacherous fog. Other customers picked up on this uncomfortable smog and made a point to separate themselves from the group, some even so much as asking to be moved to a different table. The waiting staff was getting tired of their antics as well. Everything was reaching a treacherous boiling point. A single pin drop right now could result in a full-out war.

As Katsuki continued to taunt the other boy, he neglected to pick up the many warning signs Izuku was putting off, from the way he was slowly bending his metal fork in half, to the eerie teal glow that was starting to illuminate the boy's eyes, to the small drops of blood that were pooling in the other's mouth. It wasn't until a single drop escaped his readily tattering lip that the blonde startled, temporarily breaking eye contact to follow the sudden blood trail.

"The fuck is wrong with you Deku? Did ya fuckin' bite yourself?" Katsuki spits angrily, though he sounded pissed in reality even if he refused to admit it he was concerned. Izuku gave an amused chuff and casually wiped the off his chin with a finger. Green eyes glanced down at the crimson drop before he raised it to his mouth and licked it clean. Katsuki watched in some sort of morbid daze, confusedly feeling turned on. Which resulted in him being pissed all over again for an entirely different reason.

"Izuku honey? Did you hurt yourself again?" Inko fretted from beside her son, rapidly pulling his face into her hands and staring him down intensely as she assessed all damages. She of course found none, as the cut had already healed.

"Of course not mom, I don't know what *Kacchan* is talking about. You shouldn't worry so much ma, I promise I'm perfectly fine." Izuku sighed giving his mother a gentle smile. At the instant change in his attitude, Katsuki felt his heart clench at the sight. *Was Deku mad at him? If he was...how and when?*

This was the first time they'd seen each other in weeks, he'd thought the nerd would be all over him at this point and annoying the absolute shit outta him? What the fuck was his deal?

Katsuki was practically frothing at the mouth by now, he'd even stood up and leaned over the table in a defensive and ready-to-strike motion. Izuku catching sight of the blonde's shift in positions from his peripheral snarled as he glared up at the other with eyes full of hatred and unfiltered wrath. If Katsuki wasn't *so pissed* himself he'd have flinched from the intensity behind the other's unwavering gaze. Both boys looked completely feral, one step away from ripping out each other's jugular. Inko too began to slowly raise out of her chair in order to placate and calm the two boys before anything else could escalate, the Bakugou couple following her lead.

Though before anyone could blink or strike, the waitress returned to the table with her hands full of two dishes. Her chocolate brown eyes looked between the different members of the group in question as her auburn eyebrows knitted with concern. She gently set down the two plates before speaking.

"Um is everything all right here? I have the Fire curry and the house Fugu."

Izuku's viridian, borderline teal eyes sparkled as he caught sight of his dish in her hands. At the sight of his highly awaited food, all negative emotions washed off his face in an instant. With a blinding smile, he gestured to the empty space before him. His face returned to its normal innocent puppy-like face, Inko released the breath she'd been holding and slowly sat back down in her chair, as did everyone else.

"The fugu is mine. Thank you so much for your hard work!" Izuku chirped happily. The brunette returned his warm smile with one of her own, as she set the plate of fugu neatly structured into the image of a crane in front of him.

"You're welcome! Please enjoy, I'll be right back with the rest of your dishes." She smiled turning away to fetch the other meals. Once she was out of hearing distance Mitsuki shot a look Katsuki's way.

"Katsuki sit your ass down, it's rude to stand there like that." Mitsuki huffed, sending a motherly glare toward her fiery brat. Katsuki stayed standing for a few more seconds, blinking a couple of

times as if he couldn't process this sudden turn of events.

"Tch whatever old hag."

And with another annoyed 'tch, he sat back down, bitterly looking between Izuku and the fire curry set before him. His appetite was practically nonexistent right now, though the same couldn't be said for his table mate. Izuku had a predatory glint in his eyes as he stared down at the plate in anticipation. Katsuki couldn't help but feel bitter as he looked at the scene unfolding in front of him. *That damned nerd is eye-fucking that shitty fish. Like that shit would ever be better than me.*

"Sure he gives all his attention to a fucking plate, but can't look at me for a minute without ripping my damn head off. Seriously what kind of fuckery is this?"

"Who needs a shitty Deku looking at them anyway." Katsuki snarled in his mind, each thought going more negative the longer he watched the nerd. Not wanting to waste any more energy he decided to screw it and look away from whatever trainwreck this whole shitty night had been.

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The rest of the dinner was handled in mostly perfect silence, with a few occasional quips about how delicious their food was or small talk regarding the weather or plans for the next few days. The atmosphere was drastically better and more comfortable for everyone, except for one sulking Izuku. While everyone else commented on how good their food had been Izuku couldn't help but feel dissatisfied with his. His fugo left much to be desired, it wasn't as near as spicy as it had been advertised and the heavenly aroma that had first caught his utmost attention when he first walked through those gaudy doors was all but evaporated.

The special of the house was a specialty recipe of spicy fugu, something that was as hot as it was bizarre. Izuku had never been one to handle increased levels of spiciness, let alone anything like fugu, but tonight seemed to be an exception. He had a large enough serving of the dish to feed nearly everyone at the table, though even that much didn't appear to be enough.

He had been so hyper-excited about the flavor compared to the scent from earlier that he'd missed the same scent in his food. He'd had such a strong reaction to the scent, yet when the actual food arrived he detested the sudden tainted scent that wafted from the plate. It hadn't smelt anywhere as delicious as before, it almost had a deflated scent to it. The scent had all but vanished, just to be replaced with a far less exciting smell. He'd gone as far as to hope for at least the flavor to be delightful, yet once again he was left depressed with this turn of events. This dish wasn't anywhere near as enjoyable as he had fantasized about. It was bland, plainer than him even. Overall the fish left him feeling more gutted than it must've been.

Despite his disappointment, he shoveled the fish down, not wanting to alert anyone of how bland his opinion of the supposed five-star food was. He finished his entire platter, doing his best to keep his face from showing his dissatisfaction, though he suspected that Katsuki had caught on at one point if the confused quirk of his eyebrows were any indicator. As the group of five left the restaurant, said their goodbyes, and gave probably more parental hugs than any of them needed, the two families parted ways for the night. Izuku gave loving hugs and even brighter smiles to his aunt and uncle, but when it came to Katsuki he simply gave a stiff nod and a brief 'see you at school.'

Katsuki Bakugou was as far from a hugger as one could get, however as he stared at Deku hugging each of his parents so lovingly and with such a bright sparkle in his eyes, for once in his life he felt jealous. Jealous of his parents of all people. *How fucking ridiculous is that?* He grumbled to himself, kicking at imaginary pebbles on the pavement. Deku had barely even given him a proper send-off and that just further added salt to his pride. So instead of feeling sad like any normal person, Katsuki made sure to make up for such weak feelings by being even more of an angry pomeranian, baring his fangs at anyone that dared look at him right now. He *felt* ***weak*** and when someone looked at him in that state he swore to *gouge their fucking eyes out*, even if that person was his old hag.

On Izuku and Inko's car ride home, the two Midoriya's bopped out to some Ed Sheeran, horribly singing what lyrics they knew. Inko had many questions circling around her head but thought it better than to flat-out ask them until after this next song. Izuku's thoughts, however, were exclusively self-deprecating as he berated himself for not tripping up Katsuki in one way or another, he'd had so many opportunities too. Under the table, he easily could've given a solid kick to the blonde's chair and send him spiraling backward and that other time outside, he could've tripped him up which would end with him shattering his face on the cold hard pavement, yet he'd missed every chance. He was disappointed in his inability to truly give up on Katsuki. *Loving him was the worst disease he'd ever contracted.*

After 'Celestial' ended Inko sighed, before she rested a hand on her son's slightly larger hand resting on the armrest beside her. He was pulled from his sudden spiral by his mother's deep-rooted sigh.

Izuku blinked and looked over at her, raising an eyebrow, silently asking her what was up. She understood and brought up the first question.

"Izuku are you and Katsuki fighting again?" Izuku took a long pause before answering, Inko didn't press but waited patiently for him to speak.

"Not really. Kacchan and I... *we're fine*." At Izuku's unconvincing tone, Inko frowned a little. She took a pause, thinking out her next words carefully." Don't worry Ma we are *always fine*, it's Kacchan and me."

"Honey, is... is he being mean to you again? Don't lie to me Izuku I will Tell Mits-" Izuku cut her off immediately with a loud sigh of defeat.

"Mom, we talked about this. *It's fine* and it's just *how Kacchan is*. We both know that. Please don't hark on Auntie about something silly like this." Izuku pleaded, his voice filled with exhaustion. Inko wanted to argue, she really did but she also could see the tell-tale signs of Izuku being done with this conversation so she repeated. For now at least. Maybe tomorrow she'll try again.

"Fine. If you say so I'll believe you Izuku, but I don't want you to force yourself to act a certain way around him just because your auntie and I are so close. You know that right?"

"Yes, mom I understand. I'm ***not.*** I promise. It's just...complicated right now is all. Don't worry and gods don't heckle Auntie about this."

"Good as long as you know. Okay *okay*, I won't say a peep to Suki, but if I find out you are still having problems in a week I'm going to talk to her, understand?" Inko huffed.

"I got it, loud and clear. It's really nothing I just... don't know how I feel anymore." Izuku confessed tiredly, ruffling his dark curls.

"Izuku... You know you can tell me anything. I don't want whatever you are going through to be lonely, we can handle any problem better together than apart. Don't forget that Honey." Inko reassured, giving his hand a tight squeeze before pulling away. Izuku shot her a gentle look and a small smile.

"I know that better than anyone. You'll be the first to know."

Izuku promises as his eyes rake over the dark night around them. Inko silently nods as she pulls into the driveway without another word. What Izuku doesn't tell her is all the times Katsuki burned him. All the times Katsuki said irrevocable things to Izuku's face. Or how truly bad school is and how much pain he's always in because of hurtful words and broken promises. He certainly never tells her exactly what 'Deku' means either, because all she needs to know is that it's Katsuki's own childhood 'nickname' for Izuku. She doesn't need to know the intense malicious behind each word or those hateful smiles reserved exclusively for Izuku. No Inko doesn't need to know these things, they aren't important anymore after all and Izuku doesn't plan to be a submissive little lamb anymore either.

They still had a long way to go and a lot of things to still discover about themselves and others, but together they knew everything would be okay. Even if at times it felt like it would never be okay. Life was going to get incredibly harder and bonds would no doubt be tested, broken, and torn, leaving nothing but a single thread to remain. But if a single strand remained, then anything could be fixed, resewn to create something even stronger and more beautiful than before. Not all bonds are meant to last or keep the same shape they first begin with. But in time these strings will become indestructible, left forever in our hearts. New memories will take root in old and tainted memories, New flowers will flourish and the skies will return for another day. Love and hate aren't so different after all.

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FIN

For Izuku's spine I picture it looking very similar to this tattoo I found on Pinterest. If I was a better artist I'd draw it, but there's no way I'm making it look as near as badass as this tattoo! I hope this helps visualize some of the grotesque nature of his 'syndrome' now. I'm thinking of making a checklist at the end of each chapter of what we've learned about Izuku's new condition and what it all entails/leads up to. I think that'll help people learn of his abilities better alongside his own personal journey as well. Let me know if you guys would like to see that, as it might help you understand what we know and what is happening from a different perspective other than Inko's and Izuku's.



Chapter End Notes

~Hiya!~

If you have read this story and have been following it or been interested, I just wanted to let everyone know that several things plot-wise have changed in the back chapters of the interlude along with some stuff in this chapter as well! I have now completely finished revising all the previous chapters! I hope you guys like the changes and maybe things will make more sense! It will still be crazy and confusing in the interlude though as this is intentional because we are in Izuku's mindset and his head space. Which is incredibly muddled and murky at the moment as he experiences the first shift etc. If you have the time please consider checking it out!

Prelude 05: In My Dream Tonight I killed You

Chapter Summary

Welcome to insanity, here we welcome you with open arms. Izuku goes through some dire character change, going dark has its consequences and Katsuki comes to realize he may have a whole other problem when it comes to Izuku Midoriya. Meet cute with Cerberus the Beast of The Abyss. Can floofy doggos really be all that evil?

Chapter Notes

~Howdy people!~ I am incredibly sorry that this took so long to release I haven't posted in a long time but that doesn't mean I haven't been incredibly busy with this fic! Quite the opposite actually! I have been stocking up on material, plot points, character introductions, main events, and so so much art! Actually, I do believe that the next chapter will have an art cameo I just revamped a few days ago! I hope you all aren't too disappointed in my lack of content I'm trying to create a schedule, but honestly, I think that's impossible as I only write when I am inspired! I also hope you guys didn't forget about everything oops! 0-0

!!Warnings for this chapter include!!
Mentions of abuse (Kind of), angst, body horror, pain, gore, self-hatred, dark themes and violence.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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Prelude 05: In My Dream Tonight I Killed You

Part 1 of 'On A Path That Leads To Nowhere'

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~Welcome to the second part of the Interlude!~

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~~**“I think I hate my son.”**~~

“I love my son, he’s such a good boy.”

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The Monday after The Bakugou/Midoriya family dinner, two and a half weeks since Izuku returned home.

(Mid-February)

Returning to school turned out to be a lot more of a challenge than Izuku originally had been expecting. While sure he felt changed, that didn’t mean he’d expected the same to happen to his spineless peers and very obvious quirkist teacher, however, today was full of surprises. For the first time since he was five Izuku was able to get through a full classroom lesson without disturbance or subtle insults thrown his way by snotty halfwit peers. He hadn’t noticed the change at first, as he’d been far too distracted with his own thoughts, the ones that had recently taken up root in the forefront of his mind.

Lessons bored him, he’d always been a happy-to-learn type of student. Always one to focus and listen to each lesson with absolute attention and curiosity, soaking up each piece of information like an empty sponge. No matter how dull some of the lectures could be, he wholeheartedly enjoyed the stimulation that he lacked with other means. He loved learning, knowledge was power and he used his intellect as a sharpened blade.

If he didn’t have a quirk to defend himself with, he’d make sure his mind was his sharpest weapon and his greatest asset. Though as he sat here in this painfully dull classroom, listlessly listening to the constant droning of his teacher. A man who looked more rat-like than human, with a shifty look in his stone-colored eyes, he found himself underwhelmed.

Izuku had ignored actively listening to most of his new advanced senses since they'd manifested, as focusing in on them was incredibly overwhelming and caused him a great deal of pain. Maybe with practice, he'd learn to rely on his senses better in the future, but for now, such things were unreachable. So instead of suffering more because of them, he'd rather walk through his life with ears full of cotton. Maybe that made him ignorant, ignoring something that could end up saving someone down the line, but really he wasn't so sure he cared anymore. About anything really. Everything was just incredibly underwhelming.

Where had the excitement of being alive gone? He wasn't sure.

Though as his bored gaze fell on the current history teacher, he couldn't help the involuntary scrunching of his nose at the horrifically bitter smell of kerosene and maybe ammonia radiating off the man. Maybe cat piss? He couldn't fully distinguish the scent as at first sniff it reeked of a putrid faux sweetness, one that was almost floral. The really fake kind he recognized they used in most chemically engineered perfumes and poorly designed candles. A deeper second sniff was more revealing, the obnoxious and overpowering scent of gasoline and cat piss was distinct. The scents were conflicting and constantly at war with each other, causing an even more grotesque cocktail to form.

Izuku was really beginning to hate that dreadful scent, it wafted throughout the entirety of this classroom and even led down the hall to the teacher's exclusive lounging area and the men's public restrooms. The smell tickled his nose unpleasantly and taunted him, successfully distracting him entirely from the lesson. Not that he was listening beforehand though.

So instead he focused on keeping his stomach and gag reflex in check, he really didn't want to openly gag from the intensity of the stench. That would likely draw more unwanted attention to him. History was one of his favorite and strongest subjects sure, but how this man taught was infuriating and so subpar he couldn't bring himself to get any type of stimulation from the lecture.

Not to mention the constant and sporadic twitching of the ratty man's nose. The number of times he cleared his nose with an equally as distasteful hand rubbed at the underside of it was distracting. As his eyes drifted over his peers, he noticed he wasn't the only one that was losing focus from the lecture to watch the man's constant fidgeting.

With a heavy sigh, Izuku turned his attention to the world outside, as the people outside were much more interesting than the circus in front of him. The longer his gaze was focused outside the more intrusive thoughts and faint memories surfaced in his mind. First was the feeling of the wind whipping through that seemed far too thick to ever truly be considered hair, fur seemed like a better fit for the illusion creeping into his thoughts. The phantom feeling of his imagination felt so incredibly real as if the wind ripping throughout fur was something he'd actually experienced. It

was vivid and it was breathtaking. This stimulation was exactly what he had been missing, he realized.

There were no words and too many to describe the immense feeling that swelled within him with each pound of his feet against the forested ground, wind huffing and puffing at him as it whispered down his neck. The distraction was thrilling, embedding its freezing pins and needle sensations somewhere deep under his skin. The only real word that floated into his mind was, *free* .

The second phantom feeling his wondering mind fed to him was the earthy textures that were ground under the pads of his feet, settling deeply nestled into crevices of flesh he simply didn't remember ever having. Too many joints and feet far too big to belong to any mere human. These spaces in which the earth found themselves felt as wide as canyons and as sturdy as concrete. The varying feelings the earth gave him were enthralling, at points, the ground was moist and cool to the touch, causing ripples under his skin as muscles reacted to the natural and earthy chill settling in his bones. Another time it burned as hot as embers and stung his feet in such a relaxing way.

He felt a happy sigh escape the confines of his throat, it was quiet but drawn out in a boneless manner. These thoughts alone were enough to keep him thoroughly entertained for hours. Soon the beautiful memories of scenery he swore he'd never seen and maybe never be able to fully embrace left him, morphing into new images and even crueler fantasies. Though these new fantasies were just as invigorating, if not more so. The perspective of an agile and well-seasoned predator entered his mind, caressing him gently, yet with an undeniable force hidden behind this softness.

Blinding teal, that glowed brighter than bioluminescent algae danced around the otherwise dark world around him. If there existed a gem that could even compare to the blinding color of a hidden world, neon blue apatite would be the only gem to stand a fighting chance. Though even that paled in comparison to the bright teal spotlights trained on him, they kept him caged in a palace he didn't know even existed. The two gems blinked before they lurched forward in a jumpscare motion.

Neon green drool pooled deep in his throat, creating a small lake of acidic bubbles and a hotbed of poisons strong enough to befall a 7-ton bull elephant with simply a pinprick. The toxic fluid dribbled down his chin as the anticipation got the better of him. He was ecstatic, high on the adrenaline kicks invading his veins. As the green substance fell from his gums a series of small pops and sizzles followed closely behind. Each 'pop' was louder than the last as the tiny droplets burned through the hardened steel and the structured wood of both flooring and desk alike.

The sizzling wasn't loud enough for anyone else to notice, besides someone with a hearing enhancement. Though the last thing on the teen's mind was worrying over the opinions of sheep,

prey . Izuku couldn't care enough to be pulled out of his fantastical daydreams to investigate the frightful sounds he was creating outside of the realm of his own making.

Seconds ticked by and soon the illusion shifted to a large white hare, whose lifeblood seeped into the foreground, creating a canvas of bleeding crimson. Rapid flashes of bloody memories flickered across his plane of consciousness. None of the images were clear enough to remember, after each flashed by they faded from memory the second they were replaced with the previous images. His palms were as bloody as the visceral images fogging up his mind, though the visions of death lasted for only a moment.

'Don't you think we deserve so much better?'

As the beast approached the rabbit, fully prepared to claim the spoils of its efforts, the image of the white hare morphed once again. More acidic drool fell with each painfully slow step he took, leaving a path of destruction and decay in his wake. A Path of death was all that awaited him.

'Rabbits are no longer enough for us, now are they Izuku?'

This time the image of the hare glitched and flickered with monotone static, before it regained a solid form, albeit a completely different one. Instead of a mere rabbit, a woman took its place. *A very familiar woman.* Izuku's heart stuttered with a startling revelation. This figure. That face, those large doe eyes the ones that mirrored his own, were all so achingly *familiar*. The realization hit him like a bullet straight to the heart.

The acidic drool continued to pool down his lips, sliding down his chin like a wayward snake, slippery and sneakily. ***His heart*** ached and writhed at the sight, ***yet*** his stomach remained *starving*. His body and his mind were at war, each fighting for their own causes and attempting to take control. Neither was getting very far, as the true driver was asleep at the wheel, unable to make up his mind. Being unable to properly convey his orders and feelings to the body, naturally, the body

reacted violently and sporadic, with no direction or instructions the beast within was all that remained... Because of his incompetence, everyone was forced into a stalemate and constantly ripping itself apart at the seams of a war no one knew the purpose of. If he didn't make up his mind, the *beast* ***would*** *win*. ***Again.***

'What do you think about my gift ?'

Izuku's unsteady eyes, the ones previously fogged over with a cloud of unintelligent gluttony and desire cleared in an instant, just like those times the sun comes back after a fierce rainstorm, equally as shocking. His emerald eyes vibrated, completely overcome with fear and disbelief at what they were being shown. Dulled and lifeless emerald eyes that he knew used to look just like his, ***looked*** *right back.* Once darkened forest green hair was dyed crimson and so obviously wet as it lay listless against the cold hard ground. Izuku wanted to scream, but nothing came out until it did. Not even air. Not a sound.

'Do you like your present Izuku?'

Sheering anger filtered into his veins, replacing and reweaving each fiber of his being, taking with it every sliver of despair he'd felt but a moment ago. All that was left was rage.

"NO!"

"Midoriya if you disagree with what I am saying, raise your hand instead of shouting it and disrupting all your classmates." The rat-like teacher scolded. Izuku blinked once, then twice, his

vision of the lifeless emerald eyes and a voice with no visible body leaving him in an instant.

"What?" Izuku whispered, his voice coarse and gritty as if he'd been screaming. Apparently, he had.

"Well if that's all you were going to say, you might as well kept quiet back there instead of interrupting." The teacher snarled, his nose twitching uncomfortably again as he reached up to scratch it again. He stared the boy down as he did before his gaze eventually left and fell over his peers. "Now as I was saying before *Deku* interrupted…"

As the teacher droned on, a small droplet and then another fell on Izuku's thigh, the small cold spot easily distracted him. Before he could fully bring his eyes to look at it another drop of saliva fell onto his desk. It landed with a small sizzling pop, one that startled the teen out of his fog-filled haze. He flinched from the sudden intrusion of sound and then carefully examined the new and small hole atop his already far too abused desk. His eyes widened in curiosity, tracing the invisible path the drop had taken, he gasped slightly when he noticed the droplet had melted right through the desk. To his immediate horror, he noticed the path where it ended. Right beside the other cold spot on his thigh. The acid had no doubt eaten away at his own flesh by now, right?

He tentatively reached a finger out to touch the dampness, with curious hesitancy. If *this* substance did ***that*** to the desk…what would it do to his leg? His flesh? He was concerned for a moment, before he got his answer, *absolutely nothing*.

Not believing what he'd just seen, he ran another careful and exploring caress over his slacks, a few small holes were now present in the pants, the most recent one still quietly sizzling as it greedily ate through the material.

Though to his surprise, when the droplets made contact with organic flesh, nothing happened. He wasn't burned as he'd expected, not even a scratch could be made out. Truthfully he couldn't even feel it after the initial coldness. It was perplexing and he worried he'd been seeing illusions all over again. His mind hadn't given him many reassurances lately.

This too could be one of 'those moments he was beginning to dub any strange thoughts, memories, feelings, or sensations he'd been on the receiving end of as of late. For all, he could know he was one trip away from a grippy sock vacation. If he told his mother these violent thoughts…would she even… *still love him*? Was he even her little boy anymore? *Or the **beast** that had <u>eaten</u> him?*

The thoughts cleared after some time and three classes of autopilot later and he was ‘awake again.’ Izuku’s eyes became his once again, but for a completely different reason. He felt lost and after his brain officially came back online he’d no doubt feel shame over the attention he’d suddenly drawn to himself. Izuku would never notice the carmine eyes that lingered on his disturbed figure for the rest of the lesson, then the rest of the day, watching him with well-disguised concern.

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(February)

As it turned out, hearing random voices in your head wasn’t exactly normal for many people. Izuku knew something was wrong with him, no doubt mentally, but it wasn’t just that, because before he could blink his physical body had begun to become as corrupted as his mind.

Everything was on the decline. His heart ached most days, for all the horrible things would slip past his uncaring lips throughout the day, seemingly without any control of its own. That being said he never really fought against the corrosive and venomous words, he made little effort to control his traitorous snake tongue.

Maybe Izuku had been broken for too long, maybe he’d just finally snapped and that was all there was to it. Not even the most unselfish and infinite love given to him was enough anymore. Really he knew that despite his bitter words no one was in fact the problem except for *himself*. His *mother* wasn’t to blame for how sour a child he ***had*** become. The *kids* at school who he had always so badly wanted to be accepted by, weren’t to blame for his ***inability*** to make friends. His *teachers* weren’t at fault for how needlessly ***dark*** his inner thoughts had become. And as much as he *hated* to admit it… *Katsuki* wasn’t the reason he was so ***unhappy*** and so fucking miserable either.

Maybe to a certain degree, some could agree sure, but at the end of the day, Izuku chose to continue loving such an unkind person. He *could’ve* ***stopped***, could’ve *stood up* for himself against his childhood bullies or those uncaring and discriminative teachers, *but he* ***never*** *did*. He ***allowed*** his own *suffering* to continue in silence. He *could’ve* told his mother, or his Aunt, his uncle…he *could’ve told anyone* that had any ounce of love for him. But he *didn’t* and he ***never*** planned to.

That was a decision he’d ***made*** and one he didn’t plan on changing in the foreseeable future. He was as much a victim of society as he was a victim of his own abuse. Sure he’d been born with a

fairly shitty hand to be dealt, but he could've done more, maybe tried harder…but he didn't. He wanted to…at least that's what he'd repeatedly told himself every time he dared look at himself in the mirror, but *he too was a* ***liar*** . Birds of a feather do flock together after all.

What else was to be expected when he'd clung to the shadow of Katsuki for the entirety of his life? Fourteen, nearly fifteen years of love and admiration, that borderlined worship. He'd pick up a few of the blonde's traits eventually.

While his mental state wasn't as obviously seen as his physical traits anyone who knew the boy could sense the change in his veins. It started off subtle, a gentle wave washing onto a quiet shore before it evolved into crashing tidal waves, unforgiving and taking everything away with it. Hostility incarnate.

The first incidents came from school occurrences, nothing major if not a bit surprising, Izuku was finally defending himself. Not with fists thankfully, but rather with charged comebacks that stunned his 'enemies' into silence, allowing him to slip away without much effort and even less bloodshed. Inko was incredibly proud. Until she started to worry more than ever before. The scratches and bruises along her son's skin were scarce if not entirely gone now, but she knew the wounds inside his heart weren't so easily ignored. Clearly, Izuku was suffering, though from what she wasn't sure and with no way to press such information out of him, she was lost.

The first call came midday on a Monday, it was rare for the school to directly call Inko, even if some 'incident' happened at school. That had always pissed her off, knowing the school allowed her son to be harassed so easily and injured when she wasn't present. She'd wanted to remove him from that school for ages, but they honestly couldn't afford such a decision, if they had had the money she would just outright sue them for child endangerment and illegal quirk use, sadly empty pockets couldn't bring the change of tides they both wished would come. Izuku reassured her that 'he was fine and that nothing *too* bad happened.' Inko never believed him and had spent many a night weeping over her inability to truly protect her son from such an unforgiving world.

Hence she was already on high alert when she hesitantly offered a greeting to the principal. Right off the bat, his tone was angry and completely disrespectful, she bristled but refused to allow herself to get emotionally violent before she heard what the hell he was calling for to begin with. It was after that, that her heart sank to new lows. Izuku had been in a fight, a very brutal fight. According to the principal Izuku had started it, she highly doubted that but kept those thoughts to herself for the time being.

Apparently, Izuku was perfectly fine after she'd badgered him about her son's condition, he was completely unscathed, the other boy however…well he had three broken fingers, an unknown amount of scratches, several deep gashes running along his shoulders and down his forearms and minor internal bleeding in the stomach caused from repeated abuse to the gut. To say she was shocked was an understatement. Her entire world had come to a deafening stop.

Inko couldn't believe her ears, had her son really hurt another so badly? And if he had…for what reason could Izuku have possibly chosen violence? Not even minimal violence at that…He had never been a violent boy…never even had a sadistic bone in his body. He was always crying for others' pain for God's sake! She refused to believe her innocent son to be capable of such a one-sided beating…it was unnatural and left a terribly bitter feeling in her stomach.

She'd hoped this, like the whole fiasco with Izuku and that deer in the woods was a once-and-done type of deal. Though her greatest fear wasn't unjust, Izuku proved to be falling in revere, falling into a constant backward spiral. It got worse, so much worse before it got better if it ever truly got better. Inko wasn't one to lose hope and she wasn't about to start now, especially when her son might need her the most. She just hoped this was all a phase, a minor teenage rebellion that would end soon enough and with her baby boy back in her awaiting arms.

The day Izuku attacked the boy who Inko thought he *loved* the most shattered that illusion. Seeing how beaten up Katsuki had been by none other than her own son was heartbreaking in more than one way. *Love wasn't supposed to look like thi*s, it reminded her of the painful times Hisashi had used his own 'love' as a brutal weapon against her flesh. It was completely startling to see those kinds of parallels and she wasn't sure what to do anymore. For once in her life, Inko felt afraid of the boy ~~*monster*~~ her son was becoming.

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(Late February)

As he was coming to realize, Izuku's own decisions weren't impacting himself exclusively. No matter how much he argued with himself otherwise. His impulsive decision to attack those people… *to attack Katsuki* bore fruits of regret.

After seeing what he'd done, his aunt and uncle needed space, understandable but painful nonetheless. He understood he *really* did, but a small part of him couldn't help but be a little bitter

at their hypocrisy. After all their son had laid his destructive hands on parts of Izuku that to this day remained scarred, no matter how minor or significant they still existed.

It seemed all the more cathartic that he had broken the hand that had burned him so many times right? He didn't particularly understand why they were so upset with him, a broken arm would heal in no time with the Bakugou bloodline. They always healed faster than most. They were obviously all worried about the wrong things, a broken arm was *nothing*. ***Nothing*** in comparison to a broken spirit or shattered state of mind right? To Izuku that type of evil was far worse than some flesh matters.

Humans were so DELICATE, weren't they?

They cry about the SILLIEST of things too.

In his own bitterness, Izuku refused to see what wounds he'd forced upon his mother, sure they were the invisible kind, but just as festerous and painful. Mitsuki and Inko thought it best to distance themselves and their respective families. Something they'd never had to do before as they always referred to themselves as simply one and the same, not two separate existences, in favor of time apart to heal and calm the 'rising oceans.' Both women took it hard of course, obviously, the decision had been difficult but necessary. Inko took it in broken silence, while Mitsuki chose rather to ignore the problem and never speak about it. When in doubt refuse acknowledgment of the problem until the cooling period passes. It was a guilty trait she had passed onto her son, a terrible coping mechanism as Inko always said, but Inko wasn't here so she didn't need to listen to such advice right?

Tension was thick, in both households and between all parties involved. Inko did her best to act like everything was normal, though she was horribly failing and everyone knew it. She was an emotional woman who cried out every emotion, anger, hate sadness, happiness the whole shebang really. Izuku used to be that way too, but he had found himself unable to cry since those *nightmares* . Ah, the *nightmares* , the reason for all his recent fuck ups. Nothing really got to him, words filled with hate or love, all fell on deaf ears. He went through his life with an air of disinterest and aloofness, uncaring and detached.

At the Midoriya household, the mother and son tried to make small talk and retain their normal routines, watching their favorite series together each night a new episode premiered, they continued family game night every Thursday, drank their favorite teas with baked goods they'd made on Saturday and tuned into every recent hero-related news anytime it was on. It was *almost norma*l, if one ignored the tense silence, uncertainty escaping each breath and filling the air in an unbearable torrent. It went on like this, Inko awaiting each time Izuku would have a sudden 'snap' at something he'd heard or seen or even just out of the blue. It was hard to bear.

It was getting far too difficult to bear.

Izuku would disappear at random some nights, leaving without a word or even a note. Inko had tried to stop him from leaving and confronted him about his whereabouts and reasons for sneaking out. Though after the third time of Izuku's never-before-seen fiery anger in those verdant pools, she'd learned it best not to speak up about her worries because each time she did it always ended badly. She'd cried about it many times, she wished she could control herself and her sobs when Izuku was home but she never quite could and she was sure he'd heard her crying. Never once did he apologize or seek to comfort her. And that…that hurt worse than any other pain imaginable.

That lack of interest, that lack of warmth and care was incredibly cruel. Nowadays she couldn't bring herself to look into his emerald eyes anymore, seeing that frigid look in his eyes was excruciating and made her already weak heart nearly collapse. It was as if he was a wall made of ice, his heart long closed off to not just the world, but to herself.

She'd never once thought her favorite days, every day she was able to be with her son would be the days she dreaded the most. The days Izuku was truly home were the worst and she hated herself for even thinking such an agonizing thought. She was a terrible mother, to a *terrible* son. Saying such out loud hurt worse than anything else she'd ever experienced, it wasn't the weight of the words that hurt her so much, it was the *truth* she found in each word.

What could be worse than a mother's love turning to **hate**?

"I love my son, I love him more than I love myself. He's my entire world."

“And he’s my worst Hell.”

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Izuku once again found himself in that damned static-infested world, the trees phased in and out of existence at a frequency, his eyes could not yet perceive. This time around however he felt more aware, more *like himself* , at least the part of him he recognized as his more ‘true self,’ and not the *imposter* that had slowly taken over his life the last following weeks.

With each ‘visit’ to this mysterious realm, Izuku learned *true* ***fear*** , *true* ***regret*** , and an *unimaginable* ***pain*** unlike any other in existence. He’d been forced to watch copious amounts of nightmarish terrors that no teenage boy should ever be forced to oversee. He’d been stalked by mysterious blackened entities seemingly crafted from shadow alone, he’d been hunted by feral beasts with tongues that stretched for miles and rows upon rows of saturated and needle-pointed teeth. He’d been watched by dangerous trees with countless and ever-watchful eyes that were never filled with anything other than unbridled hateful, pure contempt, and worst of all he’d been unlucky enough to meet who he dubbed *the devil* himself.

Cerberus , a beast straight out of the deepest depths of purgatory with an insatiable desire to bring forth Izuku’s very destruction, by any means it deemed entertaining. A monster without a drip of empathy and morality in its entire morbidly deformed and demonic body. From the massive ram horns atop, its wolf-like head to the tip of its fiery shadow tail that seemed to have a hidden mouth of its own under all that darkened fur. The beast was chaos incarnate, with a matching chaotic and sadistic personality simmering beneath all that pitch-black fur.

Everything about the beast screamed ‘apex predator,’ and the creature made damn sure everyone was made aware of its eccentric tendencies. Its pure prowess was devastating and had caused Izuku to fall to his knees suffocating on his own lungs from the sheer power behind its mocking grin. Its eyes, all four of them, sparkled like fallen cerulean stars with their own beautifully unnatural allure. Though it was all a ruse because under those bewitching eyes lurked a bloodthirsty beast ready to rip out your very throat if you so much as breathed too loudly.

His head cleared of such thoughts, these accursed memories he no longer wished to remember. Even as he walked to his awaiting demise he felt much more weightless than he had for what felt like a few lifetimes, even though he knew what would greet him in a moment's time. He took in the somehow beautiful sight surrounding him, it had a certain appeal to it if he was honest. Despite its eerie and unnaturally silence, give or take the occasional crackle of electricity or static pulses. Despite being filled with ominous undertones, the place was artful and crafted in such a way that he found himself enjoying the sights.

The static clouds hanging above him glared down with a soft bitterness that seeped straight into his bones. The feeling bottomed out somewhere so deep, that he could no longer feel that part of himself. The feeling was sinking and had a cold and corrosive property to it, infecting his every pore with the poison of this realm. But he soaked it in with stride, he was in *far too deep* to even try to fight the inevitable anymore. He was a prisoner here after all, no matter how beautiful the scenery was to look at.

He knew of his cursed fate, he'd been educated on his disobedience immediately. The lessons were still burned against his cold skin, permanently etched deep into the fiber of his being. He'd only needed to be taught that *specific* lesson once before he learned to never disobey or resist Cerberus's will again. That however didn't mean he took it lying down either. *He still had some* ***free will*** *,* if but a sliver.

Anytime he found himself in this estranged 'dimension' of sorts he felt incredibly uncomfortable and disturbed, though he never dared to voice such discomforts for fear of upsetting the other inhabitant. Or maybe other inhabitants? He wasn't sure if all those trees with piercing crimson eyes and shadows that followed his every move were truly alive, or but a manifestation of the other *resident* here. Not like he could ask things that weren't corporeal or willing to respond to him anyway.

With each hesitant step, he took he feared another part of himself would be shed and reformed into something entirely *new* and more *monstrous* than before. Just as it always did when he was summoned back to his hellscape. He felt like he was signing his death warrant every time he breathed in this toxic smog. Between the unintelligible whispers caressing his ears and faintly stroking his face, the entire world just felt suffocating. And then he was ***drowning*** all over again, just in a *different cage* .

Despite his reticence, he followed an invisible path leading him to an undisclosed location. The location of their ill-fated meeting always changed, and never once did they return to the same place as the previous. At first, he'd thought the realm was as large as its own country, but it didn't take long for him to realize that the space itself wasn't to be *feared* , but rather its curator.

That creature was the one that allowed him to think such thoughts and have such speculations, it was all mind games with that demon. A personal mockery of Izuku's curious mind that the beast used to keep him obedient and 'tamed.' Nothing was ever a mere *coincidence* , every stone, every line, every tree, and every shadow held a carefully plotted purpose. All whose purpose was to keep Izuku trapped in this devil's own sick personal game. Izuku was its favorite pawn, it made that

clear, almost as clear as the obvious dislike it held for the teen. It never let Izuku believe otherwise nor forget who was really in charge.

He could never be sure where he was going or what he would find when he arrived at his set destination and the anxiety of such was enveloping him. The closer he walked to the end of the line the more the sounds of the once near-silent space began to pick up. The undeniable echoes of wailing women and crying mothers were all he could hear, not even his own breathing could reach his hollow ears. He wishes the sounds still bothered him, but he was so painfully used to them, that he was immune to the sounds of screaming women and wailing children. He really hated himself for not so much as twitching at the sounds, it was nothing but an average Tuesday for him.

How could he ever be a hero when he lacked so much empathy now?

What hero wasn't affected by the guttural wailing of women and sobbing children?

The trees were his only companions in the pitch darkness of the shadowy forest that seemed to live and breathe just as he did. They led him down each turn, each unsightly curve, guiding him like a lamb to the slaughter and he followed without needing much prompting.

With each deep breath, he made the forest seem to follow his lead, heaving and thrumming with some unexplainable life. The ground at his feet was pitch black in color, though it had what seemed to be silver spiderweb cracks decorating the surface the farther he walked.

Even the floor actively reacted to his presence, each time he gulped or his developing adam's apple bobbed with his increasing heart rate the floor mimicked the motions, even dipping dangerously in parts. These odd inconveniences caused Izuku to stumble and trip over the unexpected divots each time without fail. One time he even lost his balance completely and crashed face-first into the satiny cracks. The action caused a startling 'crack' to resonate throughout the realm and the static livewires above to flicker, in the same way, a tv that was on its last legs would. An electronic stutter in an otherwise perfect system.

Once he'd picked himself up from the small crater born of his own carelessness, with his feet back on the ground he resumed his possibly pointless journey to a land he didn't know. Though when he looked up again his heart itself stuttered when he noticed he was no longer the only soul within these plains.

Standing… no… towering over him, standing taller than any of the trees was a frightful figure. A familiar foe, one he wished he never had to see. Crafted of pure darkness, a creature from a child's worst nightmare. A beast with a crazed and downright terrifying look in its piercing teal eyes. Reptilian eyes that were completely trained on him and glowing with overt malicious content. All four blinked down at him in rapt intrigue, Izuku gulped, reminding himself to be still and contain his inner fear, as this monster could smell it leaking out of his every pore.

The shadowed beast, despite its monstrous size and infuriatingly intimidating presence, was not a clear image. Izuku rubbed his eyes a few times, blinking as he did in hopes his sudden bleary eye would be cured. Though the result was the same, the figure itself was vibrating at a frequency that Izuku could not keep up with, giving the beast a blurred and sloppy image and erasing all incriminating details other than those breathtaking pools of cerulean jade.

None of its other features were recognizable over the constant phasing in and out in the atmosphere, but he didn't need to see them, as he already knew each sculptured line, each tarnished freckle, and every little divet carved onto the creature. He made out the rough outline of the creature. It had to be well over eleven feet tall, its face though hard to discern looked akin to a canine, probably closest to a wolf of sorts with a languid tail that curled around its gnarly humanoid-shaped paws, complete with obsidian acrylic claws.

It had sharp and erect ears that reminded him of a Doberman, more so than a wolf, some impressively large muscles in every limb, and what he swore was an exposed ribcage, resting comfortably above a narrowed and almost delicate looking waist, though it was hard to say. What always stood out the most about this beast were its wicked eyes, the ones that watched his every move with practiced ease. Intelligence and amusement clear in its ethereal eyes.

Without a doubt, in his mind, this beast screamed 'predator' in every subtle movement, every twitch, and every long-winded stare. Whatever this thing was, Izuku was in no way making it out alive in a fight against such a sightly beast. He'd known first hand too, he'd tried and failed at least a dozen times by now. The ending result was never favorable and always ended in the same manner, with Izuku's bloodied and beaten body lying at its inhuman feet.

It had to be the most terrifying thing he'd ever seen and he'd witnessed his own organs be gouged out of him like yesterday's spaghetti. His body was shaken in regrettable fear, at war with itself about chancing a fight or risking a flight that could lead to the same stone-cold dead end. Escaping was never an option. And if he ever even thought about it, he'd be punished before he could blink.

This world wasn't his after all, because surely if it was he would be able to escape this forsaken destiny right?

The stare down between both sets of oceanic verdant eyes was tense, but Izuku knew he was on borrowed time. He knew if he so much as blinked wrong it would be all over. He'd be devoured again. Maybe he was already a dead man, from the look on the creature's face he'd already fallen perfectly into its well-weaved trap. It was already too late for him and both of them knew it. He was the prey, he always had been. That same sour acidity in his heart returned, nothing had changed even now, he reminded himself bitterly. As if reading his mind the beast chuffed in ill-intended amusement.

Right as he was planning to flee, run as fast and far as he could before the creature undoubtedly sunk its exceptionally long claws deep into his flesh, and a new string was added into the mix. The beast without breaking eye contact with Izuku for even a slight second opened its disturbingly inhuman mouth, stretching well past any human limits. With each forced movement more and more skin tore and peeled away from the creature's mouth and snout, revealing dark mauve-colored gums. A neon blue snake tongue that was decorated with zagged black patterns flickered out, tasting the air that was doubt filled with Izuku's disheartened fear. The sight was hypnotically alien, foreign, and absurdly addicting to watch. Izuku found himself unable to turn away and he honestly didn't want to. Maybe he really was a *sick* child.

Behind those exotic colors and that illogical bone structure, another hidden fascination presented itself once the creature's mouth was fully exposed. Inside lay three rows of needle-like teeth that were no thicker than a few millimeters in diameter, each of these rows was rotating and reshaping right before him in a monstrous typhoon of death. The creature made sure to openly flaunt its monstrous nature and killer attributes. A morbid, if not disturbingly alluring taunt.

Izuku gulped in morbid fascination, he was terrified and on the verge of pissing himself, yet he found himself filled with a bottomless pit of curiosity. The creature obviously picked up on such and made sure to milk this exchange in every way possible. It was taunting him. Taunting him with unknown and otherwise unexplainable knowledge, it knew everything about Izuku and used such exploits. Izuku can see it now, the sheer irony of his tombstone, 'Curiosity really did kill the cat.'

Clearly, the creature indulged in breaking its prey before actually striking them down, it was all about the mind games. Psychological warfare at its best, a trait Izuku had always been envious of. This creature wore such with a prideful and confident smile, to be jealous of a beast was a new low Izuku hadn't been prepared to face just yet. *How could evil look so beautiful?*

The creature watched with mischievous eyes filled with pure mirth and amusement, as its mouth stretched and groaned from abused muscles its tongue flicked out running along several of the needled teeth in a playful display. That simple movement seemed to do Izuku in as he gulped, and his legs buckled under him. He found himself falling to the ground all over again. In a moment he blinked and in that single second, the beast had moved, now towering over his even smaller form. Much closer, much more intimate than before. He wished he could stand up and run, to flee, yet his legs refused to obey, and lay there helpless and weak just like always.

Acidic green slime slipped out of mauve gums, and the occasional flicker of cyan could barely be seen from below. As the beast's laser focus was on Izuku, the boy shook as violently as a crumpled leaf under its fearsome gaze. Something akin to a chuckle penetrated the air around them, something deep and guttural, a sound that by no means could be created by a human. Silent tears rolled down izuku's cheeks, his heart screamed in alert, and cried out in desperation for the boy to run, to fight, to do something…anything other than sit there frozen. Too bad his body never truly listened to him.

The beast's mouth slowly closed, and jagged teeth peeked out from hidden gums as it leaned down, becoming eye level with the boy curled at its feet. The creature's body was much longer and leaner than he'd seen, it was abnormally tall with limbs that were much too long for its body and questionable proportions. A dangerous and downright devilish smile formed from its inhuman lips, the smile coming much closer to a snarl.

It blinked, and the glowing teal lights temporarily disappeared before they reappeared from behind closed eyelids, and the beast's grin only grew in size. A shadowed hand, seemingly crafted from hot tar was brought up to Izuku's face, caressing his bountiful cheeks. Its caress, delicate and purposeful, as a clawed and darkened finger, traced a specific freckle with its index finger. The nail gently sliced the skin surrounding the freckle that was oddly shaped into a figure similar to a heart. Izuku's breath hitched as more traitorous tears raced down his cheeks.

A strangely fond look swirled in the beast's terrifying icy eyes, it pursed its lips together bringing Izuku up to meet its snout halfway, before stopping with a few inches between them. Izuku would be able to touch the beast's elongated snout if he angled his head up just a little higher. The position between them was far too intimate. Being this close to a monster left his stomach fighting the urge to combust from the magnitude of fearful butterflies eating away at his insides.

The beast gave a deep and hearty chuff, blowing a soft breath in Izuku's face. The scent of fresh citrus, fanned across his face, brushing against each freckle painting his suddenly oversensitive face. He involuntarily flinched back from the beast's bold approach and the creature gave what sounded like a disappointed growl.

“You still haven’t accepted me yet, what a shame. Oh well, we’ll meet soon enough.” The beast’s gravelly voice whispered, its tone taunting and detached. Izuku’s eyes fluttered shut, another violent flinch overtaking him.

“Not soon enough though. I am not patient. *I’ll see you soon Izuku* .”

It growled lowly against the teen’s ear, and the boy’s form fell limp. Its voice stern and leaving no room for opposition. Izuku’s body automatically reacted to the quiet command and he was rendered boneless.

It was a near-silent promise. Somehow Izuku knew it wasn’t lying either.

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(Flashback to before Izuku’s first fight about 2-3 weeks from the Bakugou/Midoriya family dinner - ***Mid-February****)*

Agitation and exhaustion gnawed on Izuku as the days wore thin. Sleep became nearly impossible for fear of a new confirmation with the beast that taunted him anytime his eyes closed. Visions of horrible things danced behind his eyelids as his heart rate plummeted and skyrocketed all at once.

Somedays he’d grow so overwhelmed that he’d scream and shout, other days he’d sob endlessly from the grief of a visual that had not yet come to pass. Yet he feared it would happen any moment of any day. The beast’s assurance of future insatiable meetings and its cruel words of promised pain befalling those he loved haunted him like a second skin.

Paranoia was his new constant, his company most days along with those sudden shadows that seemed to move unnaturally each time he passed them. Some even blinked at him with hooded crimson irises that came with an unnatural and ominous glow. He couldn’t exactly prove it, but he just knew that the *shadows* followed him everywhere he went. He knew he was being watched, observed by forces unseen by the naked eye.

There were few moments he was ever truly alone, as somewhere something ominous always clung to him in one way or another. His own personal demons, likely henchmen for the beast that occupied his dreams and resided in every possible future.

Sanity was a fragile thing, so easily shattered if just enough pressure was given. Too much weight and even the strongest bridges would collapse in on themselves. Izuku's bridges were delicate, almost as much as his heart. He knew he wouldn't last much longer under this crushing pressure. He'd need sleep eventually and eventually was approaching much sooner than he'd like to admit. Because apparently even demons needed to sleep sometimes.

He could use his lack of sleep and sanity as a good enough excuse as any for his unforgiving change in behavior. He no longer enjoyed what he previously loved, he no longer held his core relationships so highly and grades were almost completely off the table. If he couldn't even find it in himself to love and care for his own mother, the person he always held in the highest regard, how could he even begin to care for something as unimportant as boring school studies?

His relationships took several hard hits, so much so that he had become the very person he swore himself never to be. He was detached, unresponsive, explosive, painfully impatient, and uncharacteristically cruel for no reason other than because he could. His voice no longer carried that familiar warmth to it, his verdant eyes always so full of a love for life and everyone in it was dulled and cold, uncaring and unashamed. His heart was poisoned, blackened tar coated every surface of it, but his own hate-filled heart wasn't enough for him, he made it his personal mission to infect others with the same malice he himself felt. It was detestable, deplorable, and unforgivable.

What really made him the absolute *worst version* of himself though was the day he allowed his bitter cold scorn to be aimed at his mother, his greatest supporter. He allowed his hate to spread forward and infect his mother, the woman who loved him without bound and wholeheartedly cared for him with every fiber of herself. He was the lowest of the low and worst of all he didn't even regret the spread of his depravity, he couldn't find it in himself to care for anything but his own anguish. He had become the very monster that had been keeping him awake for so many endless nights.

Izuku becomes something no one ever thought possible for him, *abusive*. It hadn't started out that way, not at first at least. Never towards his mother, or any other adult. Though the same couldn't be said for his peers. It had started with that winged kid whose name Izuku had suddenly forgotten, or maybe he just couldn't care to name the rat after a certain threshold had been breached. The boy hadn't done anything different than usual really, he'd thrown an almost harmless insult at the other teen calling him by what had all but unanimously been dubbed his name at school 'a useless Deku.' But for some reason, it'd set him off in a way he had never been before.

For the first time in nearly two months, Izuku had decided to get lunch in the cafeteria after having avoided such since he'd first returned home from being missing. He was feeling especially hungry and grumpy that day, agitation had been clear in his every feature, those creases in his forehead, that stiffness in his neck, and those tense joints in his shoulders. He looked a bit intimidating that day as well, yet this winged kid seemed to have missed the murderous aura surrounding the greenette. He'd regret that.

Izuku had barely even sat down when the other teen had decided to corner him. Not that he was really paying any attention to the teen interrupting his lunch, Izuku took a bite out of his mystery meat sandwich, it was poor in taste yet he was desperate to soothe that familiar ache in his stomach so he ignored the dissatisfaction each bite gave. The winged boy noticed he was being ignored and got irritated so he started shouting louder, throwing out a few especially colorful insults and tasteless jabs. None really landed, not until that last one, once the words left the punk's lips Izuku's gaze was locked onto the other and his eyes glowed fiercely.

"Huh? You finally listenin' to me Deku. You don't like that I called your mother a fat sow is that it? Well, she is, bet that's why your da-"

Before the rest of the sentence could escape Izuku had already jumped the bastard that dared to bring his mother into such a pointless squabble. Izuku was **livid** . *Feral* and *unhinged* as he landed hit after brutal hit onto the other's boy's ugly face. If he was being honest Izuku was doing him a real favor by punching in such an unsymmetrical face. After Izuku was done with him maybe the bastard would finally have a face that a mother would love.

The sound of cracking bones and tearing flesh was all that could be heard down the hallways of the school. The entirety of the school held their breaths as they all watched in rapt horror, as the so-called 'useless Deku mercilessly beat down a peer two times his size. It wasn't just that shock that had everyone holding their breaths though, no it was that absolutely feral glint in the greenette's eyes…His very obviously *glowing eyes* .

As Bakugou watched the unbelievable scene in front of his eyes, the quirkless Deku he'd known for the entirety of his life straddled atop someone else with blood-covered fists and a look that chilled him to his very bones. He couldn't help but be forced completely breathless. He couldn't believe what he was witnessing, it was like a sick dream, maybe an ill-timed fantasy some would say. Seeing Deku, his once childhood best friend, turned biggest thorn in his side up to date, beating the ever-loving shit out of one of his so-called current 'friends,' he couldn't help but feel one of two things.

Above all else he felt stunned into silence, a small, very small part of him felt a twinge of fear caused by the bloodthirsty look in those vibrant and unnatural seafoam eyes. And most unexpected of all he had never felt so absurdly turned on in his entire life. If he wasn't a second away from pissing himself he might've had to deal with an entirely different *problem* .

It took a whole ten minutes of a very one-sided fight before someone had enough of a mind to call for help to stop the possible slaughter happening in the cafeteria. A flurry of teachers arrived a minute later and was somehow able to separate both boys. The winged boy was a bloodied mess, but he wasn't the only one, the difference was despite the healthy helping of blood and grime coating Izuku, not even a scratch could be seen. Blood was splattered generously across his face, coating both clenching fists, staining his black uniform with a dark crimson, and at that moment he looked like nothing but the god of war incarnate to Katsuki. And shit if that wasn't doing something to his mind. Izuku was a god, a *murder god* , and he was completely unscathed.

The same obviously couldn't be said for his peer though, that poor boy was covered in a multitude of scratches and scrapes. Frankly, he looked as if he had been mauled by some animal deep in the woods. It was by complete luck that the kid didn't have more than three broken fingers, minor internal bleeding, and a mass amount of cosmetic injuries that didn't go any deeper than the top of the skin.

After everything was said and done Izuku was punished and sentenced to finish the last month of classes at home. Luckily he was allowed to graduate with the rest of his class. Of course, this was only because of how commendable his grades were, and his previously passive behavior was taken into consideration. He was incredibly fortunate to avoid expulsion, as that was a very real possibility, one that would've very likely ruined his entire future. The school had far too much that could be used against them when it came to treatment of Izuku Midoriya, negligence, repeated reports of excessive bullying and assault and other very looked down upon practices for any school.

In fear of such horrible practices being brought to light in an appearance of a future trial or investigation led to them making such a lenient decision. They were also very much aware of Inko Midoriya's background in law practices and strictly from the fear of god instilled into them the school refused to press any type of charges and even agreed to sweep this entire event under the rug.

The next victim to face Izuku's wrath was to no one's surprise Katsuki himself, for a similar reason. Well not exactly, he'd just pushed Izuku just a tad too far one day and it ended up biting him in the ass. Said confrontation resulted in him obtaining a real pretty black eye, a fractured left arm, and a painful blow to an already sorely oversized ego. That specific event resulted in Mitsuki and Inko not being on speaking terms for a short time, as both women were too upset or too embarrassed to face the other for the time being. That event bled into a landslide, spurring a true butterfly effect that would change everything as they knew it.

Mitsuki and Inko's relationship wasn't the only one to sour from his poor decision, Izuku, and Inko's relationship became strained as well. Katsuki's and Izuku's relationship however had reached a completely *different* turning point, one that was incredibly unexpected and equally as explosive as all the others. Izuku just didn't know that for the time being. Nothing had changed for him regarding Katsuki, however the same couldn't be said for the ill-tempered blonde.

Everything had changed for him.

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"This is ***all*** *your fault*. If I hadn't met **you** *none* of this would've happened. Of ***all the people*** you could've *possessed* why did you choose a useless vessel like ***me***?"

"Huh!? Do you *enjoy* ***mocking*** me this much, enjoy turning my entire world upside down chasing your fleeting desire to break me?"

"Is it really that *enjoyable* for you?"

"Tsk that's not very nice of you Izuku. You can't blame me for simply removing you of the invisible burdens you put on yourself. You should feel so liberated" A sultry voice teased, a smirk clear in their unseen voice.

"...Yet here you are wasting breath and lying through your teeth to what some…what do you call me? Oh yes, some 'invisible monster.'

"That's what you call me when you think I'm not listening right?"

"I'll ***never*** **forgive** you for this…any of this."

"Funny, I was thinking the same thing. If you'd just accept ***me*** *already life would be* ***so much easier****."*

"I'll ***die*** before I accept a monster like you." He spat with venom. The beast hmmed.

"Honey, it's the ***monster we are*** *."*

"I hope you rot."

"Are you being disobedient again? Did you truly not learn your lesson the first time?"

"**...**"

"You know what, even if you said you did, I'd know you were lying . It seems it's time for your second lesson, seeing as you have ***not yet*** *learned anything."*

“We’ll see how far arrogance gets you.”

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Izuku’s Flashback to the first nightmare

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Though touchless, every lesson was *unbearably painful* . The creature’s frigid words clung in the already freezing atmosphere, and just like that Izuku was transported back in time, to the very moment his heart broke for the third time. Though not for the first, this time however was certainly the most painful. *Cerberus* was an exceedingly *heartless* entity. That was abundantly made clear with each passing day, each pained and unwanted meeting. It was a tyrannical type of punishment that not even his worst enemy should be forced to bare witness to.

If Cerberus was one thing it was methodical, everything it did was with absolute purpose. Its daggers always knew exactly where to puncture, every weakness was exploited and used when it came to ‘educating’ Izuku. No punches were held back when the beast was challenged. The deepest cut given to him was the constant reminder of how monstrous Izuku himself was. Izuku was now a presence that others feared, if not outright cowering before. It was the opposite of everything he’d ever wanted to be as a hero.

Memories of hateful words and unfair stabs at anyone that looked his way, aimed towards anyone that dared come within five feet of him plunged the deepest. The same willing victim and most abused was Inko, she was always at the butt of every emotional tantrum. He was utterly disgusted with his behavior, yet he couldn’t change or find the strength to do anything else. He’d been put in a box of his own making. He could blame all he could and yet when he looked deep into the roots of the problem he was always the first and last issue.

As if that alone wasn’t heinous enough, Cerberus showed Izuku just how callous it could get when it was truly serious. At the beginning of this hellish torment, the teen fought back against the beast inside of his head. But the fight was always shortsighted, as the victor had been crowned before Izuku could even breathe properly. He’d never stood a fighting chance, to begin with. The beast had shown Izuku just how weak, and how truly powerless he was when in the face of a demon such as it. Unfortunately, that lesson was given for the sole purpose of breaking one’s very spirit. Something that had long been chipped away at prior thanks to Kacchan’s terse and abrasive means of ‘punishing the weak.’

It took time to break down all the boy's walls of defense, it crashed at his walls for a long while before Izuku's defense truly fell, landing in a shattered heap of what it once was. Cerberus wasn't particularly patient, but it was hella resilient, unkillable really, and had all the time in the world to win this uphill battle. Really it was too easy to win against the teen, no matter how strong-willed he was, because the beast knew of every insecurity, every fear, everything that was Izuku's *belonged* to Cerberus. It alone had the ability to plant its fearsome claws into every one of the boy's worst fears. It really was unfair how many cards the beast held in its icy palms. Really this was no war, it was child's play a mere game between *oh-so-good friends* .

A surefire way to break a boy's mind was to hit them where it really hurt, rip out the very place they carried the most love. Exploiting such powerful feelings was as simple as breathing for a beast with an ironclad desire to do so. Losing your biggest supporter right before your eyes in the most putrid and stomach-churning of ways was the beast's weapon of choice in this battle. Inko was a mere puppet and Izuku was an observer, an existence that could do little more than watch as his mother was ruthlessly slaughtered before his eyes by the hands of an invisible demon.

The first time he'd seen her innards get ripped from her with greedy hands, spraying the ground with a thick coat of chunky red and dark crimson his voice was nowhere to be found. He could do little more than gape at the horrible sight presented to him with little to no moment's notice. Her intestines had been torn from her plump figure with so little ease that he had to control the bile flooding his mouth.

Over and over again he was tormented, forced to experience and witness her death, seeing it over and over in a timeless loop of horrors. If he shut his eyes or turned away an invisible force would pry his eyes open all over again or his neck would unnaturally snap in the direction of the necrosis. The same image played on an endless loop, the blackened beast, his mother's terrified face, the blood galore, and the feeling of utter devastation.

The towering black beast held his mother's limp body hostage in its gangly arms, its elongated snout snared viciously as it bared its razor-sharp rows of bone-shattering teeth. Then there were those inhuman and bioluminescent reptilian eyes, the ones whose pupils were nothing more than mere slivers of black against the bleeding teal pools. The teal glowed unnaturally, lighting up the area in front of the beast, standing out like floodlights against the monotone overcast skies. Teal flashlights that held as much playfulness as they did malice.

Just as it always happened the beast locked all four monstrous teal eyes with Izuku's two frightened emeralds, right as it used eight-inch nails to rip open the petite woman's stomach. Izuku cried out and begged for the beast to stop, but the creature just watched in morbid amusement as it raked its murderous claws even deeper along the woman's natural seams.

"*Oops, I did it again. Didn't I* ?" Its sultry voice taunted, a deep crackle rumbling from its throat. " *She's just so delicate isn't she* ?"

Long and bloodied intestines fell from her lifeless figure, splattering to the ground as crimson painted the beast's snow-white feet and all the surrounding area. Her intestines were then strung up on the nearest foliage as macabre decor, tattered and torn like broken ropes of licorice and discarded streamers. The blood leaked down the entire front of the beast, leaving a darkened and wet happy trail that eventually led back to the flooding crimson below.

Each and every time izuku was left helpless. Izuku had tried everything he could possibly think up, he changed his pathing, he attempted to fight the beast with weapons of his own crafting, he ran... There were even times he took his own life with same said weapons a few times in hopes of ending the cycle. He begged for forgiveness, he bargained with whatever devil would listen. He cried and he sobbed a river. He'd even offered up himself to the beast in place of his mother. He did anything no matter how small. But alas nothing ever worked, didn't so much as tempt the horrible beast. Nothing deterred the creature from killing his mother.

Izuku frankly had lost count of how many times he'd seen this same nightmare play out. He wished the nightmare would end each time his failure was thrown back into his face. Though like all his other pleas, he was *left* to **rot** . And **rot** his insides did, until nothing but decay filled up his heart and corrupted his forsaken soul.

With each death, he grew more and more detached until finally, he was left completely broken. Instead of crying or sobbing…getting angry…any emotion really… all Izuku felt as he watched his mother beg for help was *numb* .

His face was an unbreakable mask, it lacked emotion or even subtle facial expressions, it was simply blank. If popcorn had been handed out in this world he figured he'd have eaten at least three buckets full by now. If he was being forced to watch this show on repeat he at least wanted some type of snack, didn't he deserve that much at least? At one point he even contemplated outright asking for such.

At this point, Izuku was worried that he had become so desensitized by this whole nightmare that he didn't even have the capacity to properly grieve his mother, nor his love for her anymore. He felt *so numb* . So *broken* that he was sure if she actually died in his world he wouldn't even flinch.

After all, he'd been forced to witness it so many hundreds, maybe thousands of times already, what was one more? This beast had taken that away from him, and for what reason? How could he know? Was his suffering really that good of entertainment for that sadistic beast? Surely the beast had better things to do than break a preteen that hadn't even properly gone through puberty yet.

Maybe this was his own personal slice of hell, his costly karma from taking *those* innocent lives. The rabbits, so many rabbits he'd lost count. Maybe that mother deer, or maybe something else entirely. He couldn't be sure of his morals anymore. Couldn't trust them. Who was he thinking, playing god? His memories were as unreliable as the voices haunting his head. Nothing could be trusted.

In that kind of mindset, there was really no way of knowing what horrible things he had done and would likely continue to do. He held no answers and the one creature that probably had *all* the answers was cryptic and kept its shitty secrets to itself.

So in the end, the 'why' he was being subjected to this eternal suffering would likely never have an answer. At least one that could ever be trusted. Maybe it was simply because the universe had *hated* him so much it wished for nothing more than his *eternal suffering*.

A change happened with Izuku's new expression, or lack there off, and time froze. This time around as the beast was about to rip out his mother's organs it paused midmotion. Izuku watched on in slight curiosity. His mother, who was previously screaming and begging for Izuku to save her had frozen midscream, an expression of complete terror and fear forever suspended on her rounded face. The beast's blackened and unnaturally jointed arm too was suspended in motion. A beat passed before a thunderous crack echoed throughout the space between them. It sounded like that of a large bone being broken in half, or maybe something being split by a rogue bolt of lightning.

The blackened beast's head snapped to the side in a motion that Izuku figured would look quite similar to that of demonic possession, like in those scary movies he used to watch with Kacchan. The creature's neck snapped to the side a few times before its reptilian eyes found Izuku's unamused emerald irises. The teen's dark eyebrows quirked up in curiosity, and the creature gave a low and throaty cackle that sounded like distorted tv static. Very inhuman and deep. As to be expected of a monster straight out of someone's nightmares.

A wild and feral grin began to spread across the creature's features, starting under the elongated snout until it nearly reached the creature's luminescent eyes. The wider the grin grew the more of

the beast's skin seemed to tear, as the grin stretched the skin around it tore with stress and more frightful fangs peeked out.

"*Oh my, it seems the little pup has grown tired?* " The beast mocked, a long electric blue serpentine tongue darted out from its wolfish lips. The creature's lips pulled up in a deceiving snarl, exposing its hidden fangs and four rows of neverending razor-sharp teeth.

Izuku was sure the gesture was meant to be a display of power, a form whose intention was to intimidate, but rather than feel any fear all Izuku felt was disinterest, in the creature before him and life itself. The beast noticed right away, its luminescent eyes glowered as complete amusement bled into turquoise pools. A look of unadulterated mirth filled the irises as the pupils dilated even more until the black all but disappeared in a flash of electric teal.

"*My my, you stopped reacting to such a sight, why is that? Is it because you are in so much pain?* " The creature questions, its voice changing several octaves, switching between sultry and mocking.

Its voice was quite deep, sultry to the point it was almost seductive, though a strange dissertation to the voice left it innately inhuman and unsettling rather than alluring. Its siren call would long go unanswered before Izuku let himself be seduced by such an unappealing sound. Izuku gave it no answer, nor any facial cue.

"*Or perhaps…is it that you simply no longer care if your dear mother lives or dies? Is she but a mere burden to you? Huh, little pup do you wish her dead?* "

"*After everything, she has done for you too. What a shame.* " It cooed with mockery.

At its piercing words, Izuku bristled, his previously extinguished anger surfacing and burning even hotter than ever before. Izuku gave an animalistic snarl of his own, the inhuman rumble assembling in his own chest with an unexplainable power backing it. The growl was only on par with the very beast in front of the boy.

The beast's eyes sparkled with an unknown flicker of emotion at his reaction. Its twisted grin just continued to grow. It gave a taunting loll of its serpentine tongue. Izuku felt like going straight on feral, he was one step away from frothing at the mouth.

"*Aww, the little puppy looks so angry now?* " The beast taunted.

One of the last strands tethering him to his sliver of morality snapped. As he viciously looked at the creature up and down, looking for a weakness. *Any would do, if he couldn't find one he'd just fucking make one himself!* The teen's anger got the best of him and he bit down on his lip with enough strength to break his jaw. His teeth clattered and ground against each other in a vicarious song of destruction, another thunderous growl escaped from him as the beast blew a breath of citrus directly in his face.

The beast's breath meant to smell of death and decay, surprisingly smelt strictly of freshly peeled oranges, a calming and sweet scent with the aftertaste of soft citrus caressed Izuku's own nose. The sound of his teeth shattering from strength alone crackled around them. The beast's reptilian eyes glowed in clear amusement, its elongated snout was covering the majority of its razor-sharp teeth, but Izuku knew they lurked underneath. The blackened blood dripped down Izuku's chin as the pool gathering in his mouth began to overfill.

The sound of the roar echoed throughout the entirety of the monotone woods around them. Even the earth beneath his feet shook from the impact of the guttural snarl. Though despite that display of rage, the beast towered still, not in the least bit put off by the sound. The shadow trees flickered in and out of existence as an invisible force blew through them. The sky seemed to only darken, as the bursts of static faded and shortcircuited, causing a worldwide blackout. More shadowed entities chanted from the sidelines, whispering mantras Izuku couldn't properly hear, but he innately knew what they were saying 'Kill the monster.' Unbeknown to Izuku, the more blood he bore the more shadows were born, filling the entirety of the space with their darkness.

In such a situation either could be the so-called ‘monster’ of this fairy tale and honestly, Izuku didn’t care which side they were rooting for because he felt *empowered* by their foreign chants. More shadows joined until the entire whitewashed sky was absorbed and all that remained was the color of flickering shadows dancing around both boy and beast.

“I’ll kill you.” Izuku spat at the beast, though he was too far away for the tarry ooze to actually hit its intended target. The creature gave a full and hearty cackle at the other’s attempt at intimidation.

“ Oh is that so? You really think you could?” The beast taunted, holding a single lanky and monstrous finger up in mock surprise.

“ Is that tiny bark supposed to scare me Little Puppy? How foolish you are. Truly pitiful.”

“You have much left to learn, you are but a mere babe Little Pup. A lowly pup is no match for me. You must first grow stronger, grow wiser and become bolder. As you are now, no one will tremble in your unimpressive stance. Until you realize such you will bring always ***death*** *to those you love.”* The beast's eyes glowed even brighter, radiating as brightly as the blinding carmine moon above. Its radiant vermillion rays peeked out from behind clouds of darkness just enough to appear as bloodthirsty as the glinting eyes of a starved predator. Izuku wanted to whine, to cower, but he couldn’t. *Not now and no longer!*

“**I’ll kill you,**” Izuku repeated, baring his own frightful fangs, his own eyes glowed unnaturally under the downcast skies.

The beast’s smile grew wicked, flaps of skin ripping up everywhere the smile reached until it stopped directly under its fearsome floodlit eyes. Izuku’s body shook with untethered and unregulated rage. The beast huffed rolling its eyes before it tore its eyes away from the boy and towards the sky, silently staring up at the bloody moon that kept them company. A single stream of crimson peaked through the cold and derry clouds, directly landing on the beast and highlighting its every unnaturally monstrous feature in a pretty red.

Under the tampered light Izuku could see the distinct shine of pearly white teeth, even through the blood-stained overcoat, he could so clearly make out remarkably blinding white teeth. From his teeth, the creature's dark purple, borderline mauve gums stood out quite a lot. The color of the purple was deep and regal, appearing soft and silky despite housing such fearsome layered teeth. Though currently hidden, the electric blue of the creature's tongue was unmistakable, lying limply under rows of rotating teeth. Underneath its curled and snarled lips, the sound of sizzling could be heard in such close proximity. Upon closer inspection, one could notice the fluorescent green drool lazily dripping down its canine snout and cultivating deep inside the creature’s gluttonous jaws.

The constant sizzle of corrosive acid was addicting and hypnotizing, equally as luring as that creature's siren-like voice. Flashes of the day before flooded his mind, the acid drool, the chemical burns on his desk, and those pint-sized holes that were now permanently etched into his school trousers. It filled him with familiarity, that he hadn’t expected. Izuku felt his body shake less and feel more confident in itself. It was as if the adrenaline had finally caught up to him, as if giving him it's blessing to exploit such power. He was tempted to take the mysterious power and welcome it. But to do that would mean he would have to reach out and accept that monster’s hand and that… That was unimaginable.

The beast had stilled, and slowly it reached out an inhuman and beastly hand towards the boy, which still somewhat resembled that of a human. If one just ignored the thickened black and white fur, along with the very obvious cerulean paw pads and monstrous obsidian claws. Izuku hesitated, a part of himself falling away and his body leaning forward to reach the beast’s hand. He was barely an inch away from making contact when the illusion was snapped and he was reminded of everything he was fighting for. Every failure and every creature he had hurt because of the creature in front of him, the one he was nearly touching.

So with his very next unsteady breath, Izuku launched himself at the distracted beast before him. As he gained ground and was a foot away from making contact with the monster’s jugular, it gave him a side eye, one that appeared almost melancholy in nature. Obvious disappointment in its multitude of eyes and it gave a quiet, yet gruff sigh and Izuku hesitated. He fucking hated it, but hesitated and it cost him the battle.

Though the beast made no sign of moving, instead its vicious grin lost its light and dimmed considerably, as a new emotion filtered into its dimming eyes. A look filled with longing and ample sadness was what greeted the teen. This change of faces did nothing to deter Izuku after the 1st

time he slipped up, he was more than a little willing to kill this beast for the sake of getting proper revenge. If not for himself then for his poor mother who had been trapped in this timeless loop just as long as he had been.

The blackened beast rolled its eyes at the pup, one last glance at the sky was enough for it to know that their time together had come to an end. The real show would come soon enough, no need for either of them to continue wasting time playing around. It was high time both it and the boy moved on back to their respective times. To its disappointment, it was not yet time. The reveal, he could taste that it was on the horizon, yet so painfully far away. The pup was clueless, dull even, it realized. How truly unfortunate for both of them. *What will it take for you to just accept this part of yourself? Our union is inevitable.*

"I'd say I'd see you in hell, but seeing as we're already there I think I'd rather pray that we ***never*** meet again." Izuku snarled as his clenched fist made contact with the wolfish creature.

Or at least it would have hit the creature if it hadn't dropped his mother's limp and frozen body to the cold ground before it turned its lengthy body at the last second. Not only had it completely avoided the boy's fruitless attack but instead it even managed to bind the boy to itself. Inhuman black arms covered in coarse and thickened fur, completely encompassed Izuku's much smaller body, forcing its own unnatural body to cover every surface of the others and properly snare the boy.

The teen gasped and went to shout at the beast or maybe aim a second attack. Though he never got the chance as an elongated canine snout filled his entire line of sight. The opened mouth of razor-sharp spikes revealed something somehow more horrific than the last time Izuku caught a glance at the beast's ungodly mouth. Not only were there in fact not four rows of teeth, but six, these teeth rotated in a circular motion, each needled row twisting and turning in a different direction than the last.

Izuku opened his mouth probably to scream, but before any sound could leave him, the beast had closed its mouth around the boy's head, the entire motion having gone unnoticed until it was far too late to resist. With his head deeply buried inside its maw all he could really do was fall limp and hope this was but another game for the beast and not a *true* death sentence. He had died so many times already at the hands of this horrid entity, yet no prior experience felt quite as real as this one. It was entirely different and maybe it truly was the end of the line. It made sense, he'd been toeing that line for far too long and what did he expect? Monsters would never play fair.

His luck had long run out for the day though, not that there had been much, to begin with anyway. A certain paralysis overtook his limbs, starting from the base of his neck. It seemed that somewhere along the line the beast had bitten him, allowing acid venom to seep into his bloodstream and freeze his nervous system. He didn't even have a chance to blink before he lost all function of the mind and control of his body, a wet crunch followed right after. It had been a mystery where the sound had originated as it crackled around the space between them. Until he realized that the sound had in fact been created from his own head exploding. After that organic crunch, the world faded to black as an echo of what he figured to be the remnant of his soul whispered the chilling words of a silent promise.

"It is not yet time. You must wake up now Izuku."

"Go and see what you have done while you were asleep."

"May the tears you will soon shed be a lesson. You're far too weak to beat me."

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Chapter End Notes

I previously mentioned adding a brief overview of information on Izuku's 'condition' the further along we get with the story, you know cataloging certain events and strange occurrences!

So far this is what we know! (Some of the main points anyway)
-An outbreak of wolves that were previously thought to be harmless. (This happened on the night of a super blood wolf moon aka a crimson moon)

-Izuku went missing for two nearly three weeks shortly after the events of the slime villain and his first meeting with All Might.
-Next, we have a strange wolf corpse discovered
-Izuku is fatally wounded, he dies, but 'revives' shortly after? Probably we aren't sure yet
-A sighting of a large blackened beast roaming the woods.
-Izuku somehow returns home on a thundering night and scares Inko half to death.
-Strange things keep happening with Izuku and his hearing and senses are overpowering, he questions if he has a late quirk awakening.
-A creature keeps killing rabbits, though no one knows this just yet.
-Izuku is incredibly hungry all the time.
-Sleep becomes mostly unnecessary for the teen and he has a flurry of new energy.
-Izuku takes a fall in the shower and cracks his head open, he is rushed to the nearest emergency room by Inko and Mitsuki.
-A lot of surprising and startling results are born from this visit.
-Izuku is revealed to have a secondary skeleton harbored inside his body somehow along with canid characteristics appearing in his DNA and bone structure.
-Extreme radiation poisoning is found in his body, among other lethal toxins, though he doesn't get sick unless they remove said toxins, then he is rendered weak and has violent shivers (very bad reaction).
-His split open head is healed within an hour with no scarring or leftover damage.
-His spine is heavily misshapen and incredibly sharp, deadly, and has a centipede-like shape to it.
-New food cravings appear including Fugu (Pufferfish) and other exotic flavors.
-His skin is overly sensitive and burns at times as if something is writhing beneath his skin.
-The Static realm holds Izuku hostage and is the home of 'Cerberus' a currently unknown entity that seems otherworldly. He fancies torturing and breaking Izu's soul.
-Day and night appear the same in Izuku's eyes and he occasionally has infrared-like vision, though is unaware of it.
-His teeth have grown sharper, though not overly noticeable unless one is looking for such changes.
-He gets into a brutal fight and causes Katsuki's winged friend a few broken fingers and minor internal bleeding among other things.
-Katsuki and Izuku fight and Kat ends up with a broken arm. This causes a rift between the previously inseparable families.
-Shadows follow Izu and speak to him, though he can't understand them and fears them.
-Inko worries for her son and goes through a lot of conflicting feelings. (So does Izuku).
-Acid drool? Blackened blood? What does it all mean?

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